A DOCTORAL DISSERTATION

DINOS

The Vortex and the Vessel

Gravitation, Perversity, and the Poetics of Return in the Works of Edgar Allan Poe



MMXXVI

Δῖνος βασιλεύει, τὸν Δί᾽ ἐξεληλακώς.

Vortex is king; he has driven out Zeus.

ARISTOPHANES, *Clouds*



In the Original Unity of the First Thing lies the Secondary Cause of All Things, with the Germ of their Inevitable Annihilation.

EDGAR ALLAN POE, *Eureka* (1848)

Contents

Abstract 1

Note on Texts, Method, and Citation 3

Introduction 5
The Divided Poe and the Hypothesis of the Vortex

Part One · Genealogies of the Vortex 9

1 The Many and the One 10
Ancient Cosmogonies of Dispersal and Return

2 From Tourbillon to Nebula 15
Natural Philosophy and the Making of Eureka

3 Imagination, Taste, Terror 19
The Romantic and Gothic Inheritance

Part Two · The Tenets as Modes of a Single Law 24

4 The Calculus of Effect 25
Poetics as Cosmogony

5 *Eureka* 30
The Physics of Nostalgia

6 The Gravitation of the Will 35
Perversity, the Double, and the Heart Beneath the Floor

7 The Odyssean Knot 41
Ratiocination as Counter-Vortex

8 The Insurgent Center 47
The Beautiful Dead and the Will to Return

9 Vessels 56
Houses, Tombs, Ships, and the Ontology of Enclosure

10 Words as Forces 64
Script, Cipher, Refrain, and the Impossible Utterance

11 The Centrifugal Comedy 71
Hoax, Satire, and the Grotesque

Part Three · Comparative Horizons 80

12 The Mythographer without Gods 81
Poe and the Structures of Myth

13 Lineages of Dread 89
Poe in the Comparative History of Horror

Part Four · Synthesis and Critique 97

14 Twelve Theses toward a Unified Field Theory of Poe 98
15 The Odyssean Binding 104
Form, Market, and the Political Economy of Effect
16 The White Center 110
The Ideology of Return and Its Undoing
Conclusion 115
Nevermore and Evermore
Select Bibliography 117
Keywords 123

Abstract

Criticism has partitioned Edgar Allan Poe (1809–1849) into incommensurable personae — Gothic fabulist, analytic logician, cosmologist, hoaxer, satirist, prosodist, tomahawk critic, magazinist — and has unified him, when at all, through biography (Bonaparte), through allegories of the soul's flight from the world (Tate, Wilbur), or through readings of *Eureka* as the master-key to the fiction (Hoffman, Dayan) that leave the comic, the ratiocinative, and the political unintegrated. This dissertation argues that the corpus is governed by a single dynamic law, formalized in *Eureka: A Prose Poem* (1848) but operative from "MS. Found in a Bottle" (1833) onward, which it names the **dinic law**: all differentiated being tends to return to an originary unity, and that return, registered from within individuated consciousness, is an indissoluble compound of longing and dread.

The term derives from the Greek *dînos*, which names both a whirlpool and a round-bellied vessel. In Aristophanes' *Clouds* (423 BCE), Socrates announces that Vortex (*Dînos*) has deposed Zeus; Strepsiades later discovers that *dînos* is also the name of a pot. The pun furnishes the governing double emblem of this study: Poe's cosmos is a vortex of return, and Poe's work of art is the sealed vessel that rides it — the manuscript in the bottle, the cask to which the Maelström's survivor lashes himself, the jug "floating on the Mare Tenebrarum" that carries *Eureka*'s satirical letter from the future.

The method is fourfold. Genealogically, the study reconstructs the conceptual ancestry of Poe's tenets: pre-Socratic vortex cosmogonies (Anaxagoras, Empedocles, Leucippus, Democritus); Platonic, Plotinian, Gnostic, Hermetic, and Kabbalistic schemes of emanation and return; Cartesian, Kantian, and Laplacian natural philosophy; Coleridgean, Schlegelian, and Kantian aesthetics; Burkean and Radcliffean theories of terror; the Gothic and the Blackwoodian "tale of sensation." Formally, it reads across every genre Poe practised. Comparatively, it sets Poe beside katabatic, cosmogonic, and eschatological

myth, and beside the horror tradition from Mary Shelley to Lovecraft, Borges, Hitchcock, Junji Ito, and Danielewski. Critically, it subjects the dinic law to materialist, feminist, and race-critical interrogation.

The findings are these. Gravitation in *Eureka* is cosmic nostalgia, the homesickness of the atom for the One. The Imp of the Perverse is gravitation felt from within. Beauty is the Siren-song of the center; horror is the center's approach against the will; melancholy is the affect of the rim. Ratiocination is the Odyssean knot that permits the mind to hear the song and survive — a claim anchored in the epigraph of the first detective story, Sir Thomas Browne's "What song the Syrens sang," drawn from a treatise on funerary urns. Form, the "unity of effect," is the vessel, under the motto Poe borrowed from Ramon Llull for "Eleonora": *Sub conservatione formae specificae salva anima*. The Lacan–Derrida dispute over "The Purloined Letter" restages *Eureka*'s Attraction and Repulsion. The "Heart Divine" that *Eureka* declares "our own" is the heart beneath the floorboards, so that theodicy collapses into confession: "Thou art the man" and *tat tvam asi* are one sentence. Finally, the center is ideologically coded white and male, yet it is also "untenanted": Poe's texts erect their center and evacuate it in the same gesture.

Poe emerges as a mythographer without gods, whose vortex underwrites both great lineages of modern horror — the auto-theistic, in which the abyss is the self, and the xeno-theistic, in which the abyss is indifferent and other — and whose vessel-poetics anticipates the commodified sublime of the modern culture industry.

Note on Texts, Method, and Citation

Poe's tales and poems are cited by title and date of first publication, following the canon established in Thomas Ollive Mabbott's *Collected Works of Edgar Allan Poe* (3 vols., 1969–78) and Burton R. Pollin's *Collected Writings* (1981–); the criticism follows G. R. Thompson's Library of America *Essays and Reviews* (1984); *Eureka* follows the edition of Stuart and Susan F. Levine (2004). Poe revised obsessively, and where a revision bears on the argument (the 1842 "Life in Death" that became "The Oval Portrait," the 1842 and 1847 versions of the Hawthorne review) the variant is named. Secondary works are cited by author and year of first publication; translations are the author's own unless otherwise noted. No page numbers are given, since the argument rests on passages identifiable in any edition.

Three grades of genealogical claim are distinguished throughout, because the history of Poe scholarship is littered with influence-hunting that confused resemblance with transmission. A **documented source** is one Poe names, quotes, reviews, or demonstrably paraphrases: Coleridge, the Schlegels, Locke, Schelling, Fichte, Glanvill, Sir Thomas Browne, Ramon Llull, Bacon, Laplace, Nichol, Humboldt, Kepler, Babbage, Kircher, Mercator, Beckford, Godwin, Dickens, and the books in Roderick Usher's library. A **mediated atmosphere** is a body of thought Poe could only have met second-hand — Kant through Coleridge and Victor Cousin, Plotinus through the Platonic tradition, Swedenborg through his American popularizers. A **structural homology** is a resemblance for which no line of transmission exists or is claimed: Valentinian Gnosis, Lurianic Kabbalah, Vedānta, Norse cosmology. Homologies are not weaker evidence than sources; they are evidence of a different thing. They show that Poe's system belongs to a recurrent grammar of the human imagination rather than to a library.

Theory is treated in the same spirit. Psychoanalytic, deconstructive, and materialist critics are read not as external instruments applied to Poe but as later readers drawn into the field his texts generate. The fact that the founding

documents of Lacanian and Derridean criticism are readings of Poe is not an accident of reception history; it is, this study contends, a consequence of the dinic structure itself.

INTRODUCTION

The Divided Poe and the Hypothesis of the Vortex

0.1 The scattered corpus

No major author has been more thoroughly dismembered by his readers. Rufus Wilmot Griswold's "Ludwig" obituary (1849) and his forged "Memoir" (1850) produced the depraved Poe; Baudelaire's essays of 1852 and 1856 converted that depravity into martyrdom and the *poète maudit*; Mallarmé's "Le Tombeau d'Edgar Poe" (1876) canonized him as the poet who gave "a purer sense to the words of the tribe"; Valéry, in "Au sujet d'Eurêka" (1923), made him the engineer of a rigorous poetics. The Anglophone tradition resisted. T. S. Eliot, in "From Poe to Valéry" (1949), granted Poe a powerful intellect arrested before maturity, and puzzled that the French saw a master where English readers saw a stylist of the second rank. D. H. Lawrence (1923) read the tales as clinical records of a love that sought to know the beloved and therefore to destroy her. Marie Bonaparte (1933), with a foreword by Freud, read them as symptoms of the infant's fixation on a dead mother.

The mid-century tried to reunify the man through the soul. Allen Tate's "The Angelic Imagination" (1952), borrowing Maritain's critique of Cartesian "angelism," argued that Poe's characters are disembodied intellects and wills that feed vampirically on one another. Richard Wilbur's "The House of Poe" (1959) read the tales as an allegory of the poet's soul withdrawing, through hypnagogic reverie, from the material world. Daniel Hoffman (1972) and, with greater philosophical rigor, Joan Dayan's *Fables of Mind* (1987) made *Eureka* the key to the fiction. Against all of these, G. R. Thompson's *Poe's Fiction: Romantic Irony in the Gothic Tales* (1973) argued that the Gothic tales are pervasively ironic, often parodic, and that the solemn metaphysical Poe is a misreading.

The last three decades have historicized. Terence Whalen (1999) placed Poe in the political economy of antebellum publishing; Meredith McGill (2003) in the culture of reprinting; Jonathan Elmer (1995) in the affective economy of mass culture; Toni Morrison (1992), J. Gerald Kennedy and Liliane Weissberg (2001), and others in the racial order of the slaveholding republic; John Tresch (2021) in the contested institutions of American science.

Each of these Poes excludes the others. The metaphysical Poe cannot account for the hoaxer; the ironic Poe cannot account for the evident sincerity of *Eureka*'s preface; the market Poe dissolves metaphysics into commodity; the racialized Poe is read against the cosmologist rather than through him. The problem this dissertation addresses is therefore not a gap in coverage but a failure of integration.

0.2 The hypothesis

Poe himself proposed the terms on which his work might be unified. He was, above all else, a theorist of unity: of "unity of effect" (the Hawthorne review, 1842), of "Oneness" (*Eureka*), of "consistency" as the criterion of truth. His detective asserts that the principle of the *vis inertiae* "seems to be identical in physics and metaphysics" ("The Purloined Letter," 1844). His narrator in "The Island of the Fay" (1841) imagines "cycle within cycle without end," all revolving "around one far-distant centre which is the God-head." *Eureka* closes the circle by declaring that "the plots of God are perfect," that "the Universe is a plot of God," and that a tale's plot and the cosmos are constructed on the same principle of reciprocal adaptation.

The hypothesis advanced here is that these are not isolated aperçus but the surface traces of a single generative law, a dynamics rather than a theme, which produces Poe's genres as its modes. That law is stated in *Eureka*'s general proposition: "In the Original Unity of the First Thing lies the Secondary Cause of All Things, with the Germ of their Inevitable Annihilation." Every Poe text is a local configuration of the two forces that *Eureka* derives from that proposition — Attraction, the tendency of the dispersed to return to the One, and Repulsion, the force that preserves difference and so makes individual existence possible.

0.3 Dinos: the vortex and the vessel

In Aristophanes' *Clouds*, Socrates explains to the bewildered Strepsiades that it is not Zeus who drives the clouds but "ethereal Vortex" (*aitherios Dînos*), and

Strepsiades concludes that Zeus no longer exists and that Vortex now reigns in his stead. At the comedy's close, he points to a pot standing before the house of the Thinkery — a *dînos* — and confesses that he took the vessel for a god. The joke records the moment Greek physics, in the person of Anaxagoras and the atomists, replaced theogony with a whirl; it also records the bathos lurking in every such replacement.

Poe's corpus inhabits both senses of the word with uncanny precision. It is saturated with vortices: the polar whirlpool of "MS. Found in a Bottle," the Moskoe-ström, the cataract at the end of *Pym*, the tarn that swallows the House of Usher, the cosmic contraction of *Eureka*, the spiralling refrain of "The Raven." It is equally saturated with vessels: the bottle, the cask, the oblong box, the wine-pipe of Amontillado, the burial urn of Browne's *Hydriotaphia*, the sealed abbey, the coffin, the ship, the house, and — in Poe's own theory — the poem's "close circumscription of space," which "has the force of a frame to a picture."

The two meet in a single textual nexus. The narrator of "A Descent into the Maelström" (1841) looks out on an ocean so inky that it recalls "the Nubian geographer's account of the *Mare Tenebrarum*." The satirical letter from the year 2848 embedded in *Eureka* was "found corked in a bottle and floating on the *Mare Tenebrarum*"; its twin in "Mellonta Tauta" (1849) arrives "tightly corked up in a jug" on the same sea. The Sea of Darkness is the medium in which the vortex turns and on which the vessel floats. This dissertation proposes that it is also the medium of Poe's literature.

0.4 Argument and contribution

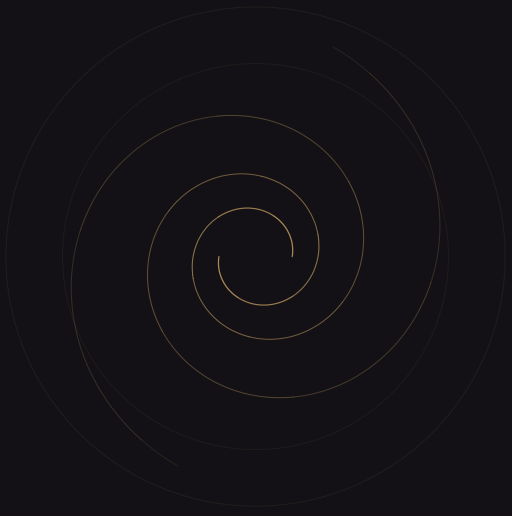
Part One reconstructs the genealogy of the dinic law in ancient cosmogony, natural philosophy, and Romantic aesthetics. Part Two reads the tenets — the poetics of effect, *Eureka*'s cosmology, perversity, ratiocination, the returning dead, enclosure, language, and the comic — as modes of a single dynamics. Part Three tests the law comparatively against myth and against the history of horror. Part Four states the synthesis in twelve theses, then interrogates its political economy and its racial and sexual ideology.

The contribution is distinct from its predecessors in six respects. Against Hoffman and Wilbur, it treats the law as a generative grammar of genres rather than a theme. Against Lawrence and Tate, it locates the destructive drive not in a psychology of love but in a physics. Against Peter Brooks's "Freud's Masterplot" (1977), it shows that Poe theorized narrative's return-toward-the-end as cosmological law seventy years before *Beyond the Pleasure Principle*. It supplies a

theory of form as vessel. It reads the major theorists of Poe as figures within his field. And it subjects the law's own fantasy of a pure center to the critique that center has always invited.

PART ONE

Genealogies of the Vortex



1 The Many and the One

2 From Tourbillon to Nebula

3 Imagination, Taste, Terror

CHAPTER

1

The Many and the One

Ancient Cosmogonies of Dispersal and Return

The dinic law has two ancient lineages, which Poe fused. The first is emanationist: the many proceed from the One and long to return to it (Plotinus, Gnosis, Kabbalah, Vedānta). The second is vortical and physical: worlds are generated by a whirl that sorts matter (Anaxagoras, the atomists, Descartes, Kant, Laplace). Poe's originality, this chapter argues, was to give the physical vortex an emanationist teleology and to give emanationist return a gravitational mechanism.

1.1 Parmenides, Heraclitus, and the vertical axis

Eureka's "Oneness" is Parmenidean in its insistence that plurality is secondary and, in the last account, unreal. Its universe, however, is Heraclitean in its restlessness. One Heraclitean fragment (DK B60) states the axiom of Poe's entire vertical imagination: the road up and the road down are one and the same. In "The Poetic Principle" the soul's aspiration toward "the Beauty above" is figured as "the desire of the moth for the star" (the phrase is Shelley's). In "The Imp of the Perverse" the soul peers over a precipice and desires "this rushing annihilation." These are not opposed movements. They are the same motion toward the same point, apprehended from two sides. The star and the abyss coincide at the center.

1.2 Empedocles: Love, Strife, and the leap into Etna

Empedocles made the cosmos the theatre of two powers: Love (*Philotēs*), which unites the elements, and Strife (*Neikos*), which separates them. At the extreme of Love all things are gathered into the *Sphairos*, a motionless divine sphere in which no individual being survives. Our world exists only in the intermediate phases, where the two powers contend. *Eureka*'s Attraction and Repulsion reproduce this structure exactly, including its cyclical alternation, and Poe's "final globe of globes" is the Empedoclean *Sphairos* rendered in Newtonian idiom.

The parallel matters because of what it implies about desire. In Empedocles, Love's consummation is the abolition of individuals. When Freud, in "Analysis Terminable and Interminable" (1937), claimed Empedocles as the forerunner of his duality of Eros and the destructive drive, he identified Eros with Empedoclean Love. But Empedoclean Love, carried to its term, *is* dissolution. Poe saw what Freud's late schema obscures: the unifying drive and the death drive are a single vector seen from two positions. Viewed from the One, it is Love; viewed from the individual, it is annihilation. The legend that Empedocles leapt into the crater of Etna to prove himself a god (Diogenes Laërtius, *Lives* VIII), later dramatized by Hölderlin and by Matthew Arnold, is the archetype of the Poe protagonist: the perverse plunge that is also an apotheosis.

1.3 Anaxagoras, the atomists, and the truth in the depth

Anaxagoras taught that Mind (*Nous*) set the primordial mixture rotating, and that the rotation (*perichōrēsis*) separated dense from rare. Leucippus and Democritus made the whirl (*dinē*) the generator of worlds without any Mind at all: atoms colliding in the void fall into a vortex that sorts them by size and weight. This is the first non-theistic cosmogony of the West. It is also, through Aristophanes, its first parody.

Democritus left a second legacy that Poe used directly. A fragment preserved by Diogenes Laërtius (DK B117) states that in reality we know nothing, for truth lies in the depth (*en bythōi*). Poe's "A Descent into the Maelström" takes as its epigraph a passage adapted from Joseph Glanvill declaring that God's works "have a depth in them greater than the well of Democritus." The tale of the vortex is headed by the name of the philosopher of the vortex, and by his dictum that truth is at the bottom of the abyss. Dupin's chain of associations in "The Murders in the Rue Morgue" (1841) runs from stereotomy to "atomies," to

Epicurus, to "the nebular cosmogony." The detective's mind recapitulates the history of the vortex.

1.4 Pythagoras and palingenesis

"Morella" (1835) names "the modified Παλιγγενεσία of the Pythagoreans" among the doctrines that fascinate its narrator, and the tale enacts it: the dying Morella returns in the daughter who bears her name. Pythagorean harmony, the music of the spheres, reappears in "Israfel" (1831), whose angel's "heart-strings are a lute," and in "Al Aaraaf" (1829), where the spirit of harmony is called Ligeia. The doctrine of return thus enters Poe's work first as the return of a soul, long before *Eureka* generalized it to the return of matter.

1.5 Plato and Aristotle

The epigraph of "Morella" is from the *Symposium* (211b), Diotima's description of the Form of Beauty: "Itself, by itself solely, ONE everlastingly, and single." Poe's first tale of a returning woman identifies the woman with the Platonic One. The *Phaedrus* supplies the doctrine of recollection that haunts "Ligeia" (1838), whose narrator feels the meaning of his beloved's eyes "upon the very verge of remembrance" without ever attaining it. The *Timaeus* supplies a spherical cosmos fashioned by a Demiurge. Poe's "supernal Beauty" is the Platonic Beautiful made into an object of longing that cannot be satisfied in the body.

Aristotle, mocked in *Eureka* as "Aries Tottle," is nonetheless the unacknowledged legislator of Poe's poetics. In *Poetics* 7, beauty requires a magnitude that can be taken in at once; an animal a thousand miles long could not be beautiful, because its unity would be lost to the beholder. Poe's rule that a work must be read "at one sitting" is this principle relocated from memory to nervous excitement.

1.6 Plotinus: procession and return

Plotinus describes reality as an overflowing of the One into Intellect, Soul, and finally matter (*proodos*), answered by the soul's turning back toward its source (*epistrophē*). The treatise "On Beauty" (*Enneads* I.6) holds that the soul recognizes beauty as kin to itself, a trace of the origin. *Eureka*'s "irradiation" and "reaction" are procession and return translated into physics. The difference is decisive. Plotinian return is contemplative and preserves the soul in the One;

Eureka's return is gravitational and ends in "Nothing." Poe kept the Neoplatonic longing and removed its consolation.

1.7 Gnosis, Hermes, and the breaking of the vessels

The Valentinian system reported by Irenaeus (*Against Heresies* I) begins with a primal pair: Bythos, the Depth, and Sigē, Silence. From them proceed the Aeons of the Pleroma. The youngest, Sophia, conceives a passion to comprehend the unknowable Father; her overreaching precipitates her fall, the creation of a defective material world, and the dispersal of spiritual sparks in matter, until a limiting power, Horos, halts her. No transmission to Poe is claimed. The homology is nonetheless exact. Poe wrote a tale of the Depth (the Maelström, under the sign of Democritus' *bythos*), a fable of Silence ("Silence — A Fable," 1838), and a tale of a woman of forbidden wisdom: Ligeia, through whom the narrator approaches "a wisdom too divinely precious not to be forbidden." Barton Levi St. Armand (1972) has read "Usher" through Gnostic metaphysics; this study extends the reading to the corpus.

The Hermetic *Poimandres* describes the soul's ascent through seven planetary zones, surrendering a vice at each. Chapter 9 reads the seven chambers of "The Masque of the Red Death" as that ascent inverted into descent. Roderick Usher's library contains the Hermetic philosopher Robert Fludd.

Lurianic Kabbalah offers the most striking homology of all. In Isaac Luria's cosmogony, the infinite contracts to make room for creation (*tzimtzum*); divine light pours into vessels (*kelim*) too weak to hold it; the vessels shatter (*shevirat ha-kelim*), scattering sparks through matter; and the work of repair (*tikkun*) gathers them back. Here, centuries before Poe, are diffusion, the vessel, its fracture, and the return. The fissure that runs down the House of Usher is a *shevirah*. *Eureka* is a physics of *tikkun* without redemption.

1.8 Vedic breath and Stoic fire

The Nāsadīya hymn of the *Ṛg Veda* (X.129) imagines a primordial One that "breathed, windless, by its own nature." Purāṇic cosmology describes universes emitted and withdrawn with the days and nights of Brahmā. *Eureka* ends with "a novel Universe swelling into existence, and then subsiding into nothingness, at every throb of the Heart Divine." The Stoic doctrine of *ekpyrōsis*, the periodic conflagration and rebirth of the cosmos, underlies "The Conversation of Eiros and Charmion" (1839), whose world ends in fire under a Euripidean epigraph:

"I will bring fire to thee." The *Chāndogya Upaniṣad*'s identity of self and absolute, *tat tvam asi*, will return in Chapter 6 as the hidden twin of Poe's "Thou Art the Man."

1.9 Conclusion: the dinic archive

The two lineages answer different questions. Emanationist systems explain why the many long for the One but treat the return as a spiritual ascent. Vortical systems explain how worlds form mechanically but assign them no longing. Poe joined them. In *Eureka*, the longing of the emanationist soul becomes the mechanism of the physical cosmos: gravitation is the desire of each atom for the unity it lost. Poe did not invent the vortex or the return. He made the vortex *want* something.

CHAPTER

2

From Tourbillon to Nebula

Natural Philosophy and the Making of *Eureka*

Eureka is not a mystic's reverie dressed in scientific vocabulary. It is a deliberate intervention in the most contested cosmological question of the 1840s, and its central move is to supply what Newton had refused to supply: a cause for gravitation. Poe's answer is that gravitation is the longing of dispersed matter for its lost unity. This chapter traces the scientific materials from which that answer was built.

2.1 Descartes, Newton, and the missing cause

Descartes' *Principia philosophiae* (1644) filled space with a plenum of matter turning in great vortices (*tourbillons*) that carried the planets. Newton's *Principia* (1687) demolished the vortex theory in Book II and replaced it with universal gravitation, a force described exactly and explained not at all. In his letters to Richard Bentley (1692–93), Newton called the idea of action at a distance through a vacuum an absurdity no competent thinker could accept, and in the General Scholium he declined to frame hypotheses about its cause.

Eureka rushes into the vacancy Newton left. Poe argues that each atom tends not toward any particular atom but toward the common center from which all were irradiated, and that the inverse-square law is the geometric trace of the original spherical diffusion. Gravitation becomes the "reaction" to the divine "action" of dispersal. The word for such a force already existed in medicine: *nostalgia*, coined by Johannes Hofer in 1688 for the homesickness of Swiss

mercenaries, from the Greek *nostos* (return home) and *algos* (pain). *Eureka*'s gravitation is nostalgia universalized. The cosmos is homesick.

Descartes bequeathed a second legacy: the radical separation of thinking substance from extended substance. Tate's "angelic imagination" names Poe's dramatization of minds that survive or exceed their bodies. Valdemar speaks after death; Monos and Una converse after it; Ligeia's will outlasts her flesh. Poe's tales are experiments on the Cartesian seam.

2.2 The nebular hypothesis

Kant's *Universal Natural History and Theory of the Heavens* (1755) and Laplace's *Exposition du système du monde* (1796) proposed that the solar system condensed from a rotating nebula, shedding rings that coalesced into planets. William Herschel's catalogues of nebulae lent the idea observational weight; John Pringle Nichol's *Views of the Architecture of the Heavens* (1837) made it popular in the Anglophone world, and it was Poe's chief conduit. In 1845 Lord Rosse's great telescope at Parsonstown appeared to resolve certain nebulae into stars, and the hypothesis seemed endangered. *Eureka* defends it, and dedicates itself to Alexander von Humboldt, whose *Kosmos* (begun 1845) aspired to the same totality.

Poe's cosmogony runs thus: a primordial particle of absolute simplicity; its irradiation, by divine volition, into a sphere of atoms differing in size, form, and distribution; the condensation of those atoms into nebulae, suns, and Laplacean rings; and the eventual collapse of everything into a "final globe of globes" that then vanishes, leaving God "all in all." Along the way Poe offers the first qualitatively correct resolution of Olbers' paradox: the night sky is dark because the universe of stars is finite in age, so that from the invisible background "no ray ... has yet been able to reach us at all". Edward Harrison's *Darkness at Night* (1987) credits him accordingly, and Tresch (2021) took his title from the problem.

Resemblances to Lemaître's "primeval atom" (1931) and to the closed cosmologies of the twentieth century are real but structural. Poe deduced his universe from aesthetic premises, not from field equations. Its value is not scientific priority but the demonstration that a cosmos can be conceived as a plot.

2.3 Against Aristotle and Bacon: the epistemology of consistency

Eureka opens with a satirical letter from the year 2848 that ridicules "Aries Tottle" (deduction) and "Hog" (Baconian induction) and mocks John Stuart Mill's *System of Logic* (1843). Its hero is Kepler, who "guessed" his laws. Poe's criterion of truth is consistency: "a perfect consistency can be nothing but an absolute truth." And consistency is aesthetic: "symmetry and consistency are convertible terms: — thus Poetry and Truth are one."

This epistemology has a precise ancestor in Laplace's *Essai philosophique sur les probabilités* (1814), which imagines an intellect that, knowing every force and position at one instant, would see past and future at a glance. Poe's "The Power of Words" (1845) gives that intellect to the angel Agathos, who explains that a being of infinite understanding could trace any impulse given to the air through all its consequences. The idea comes from Charles Babbage's *Ninth Bridgewater Treatise* (1837), which describes the atmosphere as a vast library on which every word ever spoken remains inscribed. Babbage had already appeared in "Maelzel's Chess-Player" (1836), where Poe argued that the famous automaton could not be a pure machine: arithmetic proceeds by determinate steps, but no move in chess necessarily follows from any other. The line between calculation and judgment was Poe's first philosophical theme.

2.4 The subterranean and the polar

The Maelström's narrator reports that "Kircher and others" imagined an abyss at the center of the whirlpool penetrating the globe. Athanasius Kircher's *Mundus subterraneus* (1665) described the earth as an organism circulating fire and water through internal channels, with whirlpools as the mouths of that circulation. A note Poe appended to "MS. Found in a Bottle" cites "the maps of Mercator," which show the ocean "rushing, by four mouths, into the (northern) Polar Gulf, to be absorbed into the bowels of the earth," around a black rock at the Pole (the *Rupes Nigra* of Mercator's 1595 polar map). Roderick Usher reads Holberg's hollow-earth romance *Niels Klim* (1741). John Cleves Symmes's circular of 1818 declared the earth hollow and open at the poles, and his disciple Jeremiah N. Reynolds lobbied for the Antarctic expedition that Poe championed and that underwrites *Pym*. Reynolds also published "Mocha Dick" (1839), the tale of a white whale that fed *Moby-Dick*.

In this archive the poles are drains: points at which the planet's waters are drawn inward. The pole is the earth's center made visible on its surface. "Dream-

Land" (1844) names it with the classical word for the northernmost land: "an ultimate dim Thule."

2.5 Will, nerve, and the electric soul

Franz Anton Mesmer's theory of animal magnetism (1779) proposed a universal fluid through which one will could act on another body. Chauncy Hare Townshend's *Facts in Mesmerism* (1840) informed "Mesmeric Revelation" (1844), in which a dying man under trance declares that God is "unparticled matter." "Mellonta Tauta" mocks Andrew Jackson Davis, the "Poughkeepsie Seer," as the "Toughkeepsie Seer." Galvani's frog experiments (1791) and Aldini's galvanic stimulation of a hanged man's corpse (1803) stand behind "Some Words with a Mummy" (1845), in which a voltaic pile revives an Egyptian count. The Bishop of Llandaff's *Chemical Essays*, cited in a footnote to "Usher," supply Roderick's belief in "the sentience of all vegetable things." Phrenology (Gall, Spurzheim, Combe), which Poe reviewed favourably in 1836, is refuted in "The Imp of the Perverse" for having overlooked perversity.

These sources share one feature: each locates the threshold where matter becomes spirit, or life becomes death, inside physics. *Eureka* assigns Repulsion to electricity and calls it the spiritual principle. The will is an electric force; the soul is a field.

2.6 Conclusion: a science of rims

Poe's science is a science of thresholds: life and death, matter and spirit, calculation and judgment, the surface and the interior of the earth. Every threshold in this archive is a rim — the lip of a vortex, beyond which a different law prevails. Poe's narrators stand on these rims. *Eureka* explains why they cannot step back.

CHAPTER

3

Imagination, Taste, Terror

The Romantic and Gothic Inheritance

Romanticism gave Poe four things: the autonomy of the aesthetic, the sublime of terror, the double, and the dead beloved. He transformed all four in the same direction. He mechanized them. Where the Romantics sought transcendence through the infinite, Poe sought a calculable effect that would deliver the sensation of the infinite on demand. That conversion of the sublime into a reproducible technique is the hinge between Romantic metaphysics and the modern culture industry.

3.1 Coleridge

The *Biographia Literaria* (1817) is Poe's most important documented source. Chapter XIV defines a poem as a composition "opposed to works of science, by proposing for its immediate object pleasure, not truth"; Poe's "Letter to B——" (1831) restates the definition almost verbatim. Coleridge's distinction between the creative Imagination and the merely aggregative Fancy Poe first accepted and then demolished. In his review of Thomas Moore's *Alciphron* (1840) he argued that neither faculty truly creates, since novel conceptions are only "unusual combinations." Poe's theory of originality is combinatorial, a point to which the Lullian epigraph of "Eleonora" (Chapter 8) gives an unexpected lineage.

Coleridge's "The Eolian Harp" (1795) asked whether all of nature might be "organic Harps diversely framed," swept by "one intellectual breeze, / At once the Soul of each, and God of all." Poe restrung that harp twice. "Israfel" borrows

its angel "whose heart-strings are a lute"; "Usher" takes its epigraph from Béranger: "His heart is a suspended lute; / Whenever one touches it, it resounds." Roderick is the Aeolian harp tuned to its own destruction. *The Rime of the Ancient Mariner* (1798) gave Poe the polar voyage, the ghost ship, and the dicing figure Life-in-Death. "The Oval Portrait" first appeared, in 1842, under the title "Life in Death."

3.2 The Schlegels, Scott, and Hugo

August Wilhelm Schlegel's *Lectures on Dramatic Art and Literature* (translated by John Black, 1815) gave Poe the doctrine of "unity of interest," which he converted into "unity of effect." Friedrich Schlegel's "Dialogue on Poetry" (1800) called the arabesque the oldest and most original form of human fancy and theorized Romantic irony, the artist's sovereign detachment from his own creation. G. R. Thompson's reading of the Gothic tales as ironic is, in effect, a Schlegelian reading.

The titular terms of *Tales of the Grotesque and Arabesque* (1840) most probably derive from Walter Scott's essay "On the Supernatural in Fictitious Composition" (1827), a critique of E. T. A. Hoffmann that deploys both words. Wolfgang Kayser traced the line. Poe's preface answers the charge of "Germanism" with a sentence that is also a philosophical claim: "terror is not of Germany, but of the soul." Victor Hugo's preface to *Cromwell* (1827) had already declared the grotesque the distinctively modern principle, the necessary companion of the sublime. Poe's paired adjectives encode that companionship.

3.3 Kant, Cousin, and the triad of faculties

"The Poetic Principle" divides "the world of mind" into "the Pure Intellect, Taste, and the Moral Sense," placing Taste in the middle, concerned with Beauty as Intellect is with Truth and the Moral Sense with Duty. Glen A. Omans (1980) traced the triad to Kant's three *Critiques*, which Poe could have met through Coleridge and through Victor Cousin's popular lectures on the True, the Beautiful, and the Good. Kant's *Critique of Judgment* (1790) defined the beautiful as the object of a disinterested pleasure and as purposiveness without purpose. Poe's "poem written solely for the poem's sake" sounds Kantian, and was received in France alongside Théophile Gautier's *l'art pour l'art*.

It is not Kantian. Kant's aesthetic judgment contemplates; Poe's aesthetic acts. The 1842 Hawthorne review states its premise without euphemism: "During the

hour of perusal the soul of the reader is at the writer's control." Poe's autonomy of the poem is autonomy from moral instruction, not from purpose. The purpose is the effect, and the effect is a calculated operation on the reader's nervous system. Poe's aesthetic is a technology.

3.4 Burke, Radcliffe, Longinus

Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) made terror "the ruling principle of the sublime" and catalogued its sources: obscurity, power, and the privations — vacuity, darkness, solitude, and silence. "Silence — A Fable" is a Burkean privation dramatized. Burke also described an "artificial infinite," produced by the succession and uniformity of parts, as in a colonnade. Poe's refrain, whose pleasure he derived from "the sense of identity — of repetition," is a Burkean artificial infinite built of sound.

Ann Radcliffe's posthumous essay "On the Supernatural in Poetry" (1826) distinguished terror, which "expands the soul," from horror, which "contracts, freezes, and nearly annihilates" it. Radcliffe preferred terror and explained her phantoms away. Poe crossed her line deliberately. The "nearly liquid mass of loathsome — of detestable putrescence" at the end of "Valdemar" is horror in her strict sense: contraction to the point of annihilation. In the dinic vocabulary, terror is the vertigo of the rim, and horror is arrival at the center. Longinus, finally, supplied the idea that great writing transports the soul out of itself (*ekstasis*); Poe's definition of poetic effect as "an elevating excitement of the soul" is Longinian.

3.5 Scottish rhetoric and backward composition

Margaret Alterton (1925) showed that Poe's unity of effect owes as much to the Scottish rhetoricians as to German metaphysics. Hugh Blair's *Lectures on Rhetoric and Belles Lettres* (1783), Lord Kames's *Elements of Criticism* (1762), and Archibald Alison's associationist *Essays on Taste* (1790) taught that literary pleasure arises from a controlled chain of associated ideas. The Romantic sublime, filtered through this rhetoric, became something that could be produced on purpose.

"The Philosophy of Composition" (1846) opens with Dickens' remark that William Godwin wrote *Caleb Williams* (1794) backwards, beginning with the third volume. Dickens is present for another reason: Poe's review of *Barnaby*

Rudge (1842) regretted that its raven, Grip, had not been given a more prophetic role. Three years later Poe gave his own raven that role.

3.6 The Gothic archive

Poe's epigraphs function as a portable genealogy, each tale opening with a vessel from the past: Browne for "Rue Morgue," Llull for "Eleonora," Glanvill for "Ligeia" and the Maelström, Plato for "Morella," Luther for "Metzengerstein," Béranger for "Usher," Quinault for "MS. Found in a Bottle," Alcman for "Silence," Euripides for "Eiros and Charmion," Sophocles for "Monos and Una," Novalis for "Marie Rogêt," Crébillon at the end of "The Purloined Letter."

Behind them stands the Gothic proper. Horace Walpole's *Otranto* (1764) opens with death by a falling helmet; Matthew Lewis's *The Monk* (1796) ends with Ambrosio dropped by Satan from a height onto rocks — the Gothic's founding fiction of the fall. Radcliffe's *Udolpho* (1794) built a novel around a black veil and what lies behind it. William Beckford's *Vathek* (1786) ends in the subterranean Hall of Eblis, and "The Premature Burial" invokes its Carathis by name. Gottfried August Bürger's ballad "Lenore" (1774), in which a dead lover rides back for his bride, gave Poe a name. Goethe's "The Bride of Corinth" (1797) returned a dead bride to her lover's bed. Jean Paul's *Siebenkäs* (1796–97) coined the word *Doppelgänger* and contained the "Speech of the Dead Christ," a vision of a godless universe that anticipates cosmic horror. Hoffmann's *The Devil's Elixirs* (1815–16) and "The Sandman" (1816) supplied doubles and automata; Tieck appears in Usher's library. Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) framed its reanimation within a voyage toward the pole. Charles Brockden Brown's *Wieland* (1798) and *Edgar Huntly* (1799) naturalized the Gothic in America, with ventriloquism, somnambulism, and a waking in a pit. Blackwood's "tales of sensation" provided the clinical first-person narrative of extremity, and William Mudford's "The Iron Shroud" (1830), with its contracting cell, is the immediate source of "The Pit and the Pendulum." Thomas De Quincey's "On Murder Considered as One of the Fine Arts" (1827) aestheticized crime, and his "Suspiria de Profundis" (1845) mythologized sorrow as three dark Madonnas.

The Romantic metaphysicians appear by name. "Morella" cites Locke on personal identity, "the wild Pantheism of Fichte," and "the doctrines of Identity as urged by Schelling." "Marie Rogêt" takes its epigraph from Novalis, who held that ideal series of events run parallel with real ones. Novalis's *Hymns to the*

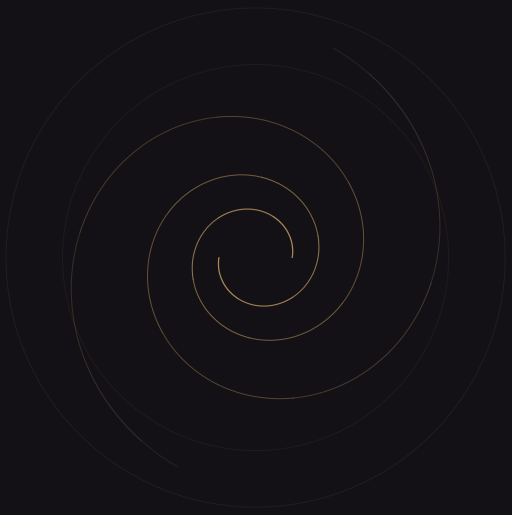
Night (1800), written after the death of his young fiancée Sophie von Kühn, are the most important Romantic precedent for Poe's sacralized dead beloved.

3.7 Conclusion: the sublime made reproducible

Every Romantic inheritance reached Poe as a form of transcendence and left his hands as a procedure. The infinite became the refrain; the sublime became the effect; the dead beloved became "the most poetical topic in the world"; the double became a mechanism of plot. Poe did not betray Romanticism by mechanizing it. He discovered that its longing for the infinite could be packaged, sealed, and delivered at the length of one sitting. That discovery is the subject of Part Two.

PART TWO

The Tenets as Modes of a Single Law



4 The Calculus of Effect

5 *Eureka*

6 The Gravitation of the Will

7 The Odyssean Knot

8 The Insurgent Center

9 Vessels

10 Words as Forces

11 The Centrifugal Comedy

CHAPTER

4

The Calculus of Effect

Poetics as Cosmogony

Poe's poetics is a theory of force, not of form. Its four rules — the primacy of effect, the limit of a single sitting, composition from the end, and the closed frame — describe a dynamical system in which the writer irradiates a design outward from a preconceived center and the reader is drawn back toward it. *Eureka* does not borrow this vocabulary by analogy. It extends the poetics to the cosmos and says so: "The Universe is a plot of God."

4.1 Beauty as effect

The founding sentence of the poetics is a definition by displacement: "When, indeed, men speak of Beauty, they mean, precisely, not a quality, as is supposed, but an effect" ("The Philosophy of Composition," 1846). From Plato to Plotinus, beauty had been a property of things or a radiance of Being. Kant removed it from the object but kept it within the free play of a contemplating subject's faculties. Poe relocates it into the relation between text and reader, and describes that relation kinetically: an "elevation," an "excitement," a motion "of the soul." Beauty is no longer something one beholds; it is something that happens to one, as gravitation is not a property of a body but a relation between bodies. Poe's aesthetic is a field theory *avant la lettre*.

The "Letter to B——" (1831) specifies the field's object. A poem seeks "an indefinite instead of a definite pleasure," and music is essential to it "since the comprehension of sweet sound is our most indefinite conception." Indefiniteness

here is not vagueness. It is the felt presence of a magnitude the soul cannot circumscribe. "The Poetic Principle" names that magnitude: poetry is "a wild effort to reach the Beauty above," and its tears arise from "a certain, petulant, impatient sorrow at our inability to grasp now, wholly, here on earth, at once and for ever, those divine and rapturous joys" of which we receive only glimpses. This is the affect of a body in orbit, which perceives its attractor and cannot reach it. Melancholy, which the 1846 essay calls "the most legitimate of all the poetical tones," is the name of that orbit.

Poe borrowed his governing image from Shelley: poetry is "the desire of the moth for the star." A long-standing, though now contested, explanation of the moth's flight into a flame holds that an insect steering at a constant angle to a light infinitely distant flies straight, while the same rule applied to a candle carries it along an equiangular spiral into the fire. Whatever entomology now concludes, the figure states the dinic law with precision. The star above and the flame below are one attractor seen at two distances, and the orientation that steers by the first spirals the moth into the second. Jacob Bernoulli asked that this spiral, his *spira mirabilis*, be cut on his tomb at Basel beneath the words *Eadem mutata resurgo*: though changed, I rise the same. The mason carved an Archimedean spiral instead. The history of mathematics affords no more exact emblem of Poe's law than a self-similar spiral inscribed on a sepulchre with a promise of return, and none more Poe-like than a vessel that failed its content.

4.2 The single sitting as a law of containment

The 1842 review of Hawthorne's *Twice-Told Tales* states the premise without euphemism: "During the hour of perusal the soul of the reader is at the writer's control." Unity of effect "cannot be thoroughly preserved in productions whose perusal cannot be completed at one sitting." "The Philosophy of Composition" names the enemy: "if two sittings be required, the affairs of the world interfere, and every thing like totality is at once destroyed." The world is the dispersive force. The one-sitting rule is a rule of closure, which isolates the reader's descent from every external force that might arrest it. Hence Poe's prescribed dimensions: for the tale, the "short prose narrative, requiring from a half-hour to one or two hours in its perusal"; for the poem, about a hundred lines. "The Raven" has one hundred and eight.

The rule abolishes the long poem. "I hold that a long poem does not exist," "The Poetic Principle" declares, and *Paradise Lost* is reduced to a succession of brief poems separated by depressions. Aristotle had required that a beautiful

whole be graspable as one (*Poetics* 7). Poe moved the requirement from the memory to the nerves, and so turned an aesthetic of proportion into an aesthetic of duration. The epic dissolves into lyric fragments; the novel leaks; the tale is sealed.

The 1846 essay supplies the rule's mathematics: "the brevity must be in direct ratio of the intensity of the intended effect." Kepler, the hero of *Eureka* because he "guessed" his laws, established in his second law that a planet sweeps equal areas in equal times, and therefore moves fastest when nearest the sun. A body falling around an attractor accelerates as its orbit contracts; so does water in a whirlpool. Poe's ratio of brevity to intensity is Kepler's second law transposed to composition. The short form was a concession to the magazine page (Chapter 15), but it is first the shape of an accelerating approach to a center.

4.3 Composition from the end

"Nothing is more clear than that every plot, worth the name, must be elaborated to its *dénouement* before any thing be attempted with the pen." The account of "The Raven" proceeds accordingly. Its climactic stanza was composed first: "Here then the poem may be said to have its beginning—at the end, where all works of art should begin." Composition begins at the center and moves outward; reading begins at the rim and is drawn inward. The two motions are *Eureka*'s Irradiation and Reaction. The writer reenacts the divine volition that diffuses the primordial particle, and the reader undergoes the return. The work is a closed cycle of Repulsion and Attraction, and its effect is the moment of arrival: the reader's local collapse into unity.

Every element is therefore a vector toward the center. "If his very initial sentence tend not to the outbringing of this effect, then he has failed in his first step," the Hawthorne review insists; "in the whole composition there should be no word written, of which the tendency, direct or indirect, is not to the one pre-established design." The 1841 review of Bulwer's *Night and Morning* defined plot as an arrangement from which no part can be displaced without ruin to the whole. *Eureka* generalizes the definition. In fiction "we should aim at so arranging the incidents that we shall not be able to determine, of any one of them, whether it depends from any one other or upholds it"; finite intelligence cannot achieve this, but "the plots of God are perfect." Total reciprocal dependence is a gravitational aesthetic: in a Newtonian system every body acts on every other, and in a perfect plot every incident on every other.

Whether "The Philosophy of Composition" is sincere or a deadpan hoax has divided readers since Baudelaire took it as gospel. The dispute matters less than the essay's form. It is itself composed backward from an effect, the effect of mastery, and so it is the poem's double: a prose vessel built around "The Raven."

4.4 The frame, the refrain, and the undercurrent

"A close circumscription of space is absolutely necessary to the effect of insulated incident:—it has the force of a frame to a picture. It has an indisputable moral power in keeping concentrated the attention." The lover's chamber in "The Raven," the pentagonal turret of "Ligeia," the welded abbey of Prince Prospero, and the shrinking cell at Toledo are applications of a formal law, the law of the vessel (Chapter 9).

The refrain is the law of periodicity. Its pleasure, Poe says, "is deduced solely from the sense of identity—of repetition," and his innovation was to keep the sound constant while varying its application, so that each return of "Nevermore" means more. "The Rationale of Verse" (1848) generalizes: "Verse originates in the human enjoyment of equality, fitness." Rhyme is the attraction of like sound to like; the refrain is periodic return; the stanza is a closed orbit. Prosody is the microphysics of the dinic law, and in "The Colloquy of Monos and Una" (Chapter 10) the identity becomes explicit, for the same equalization of pulse that governs verse adjusts "the cycles of the firmamental orbs."

Meaning obeys the same physics. A poem needs "some under-current, however indefinite, of meaning," but the Transcendentalists ruin poetry by making the suggested meaning "the upper instead of the under current." The 1847 review of Hawthorne condemns allegory for the same fault. Allegory drags the center to the surface. Poe keeps it beneath, as an undertow that draws the surface down.

4.5 Arnheim: the landscape of effect

"The Landscape Garden" (1842) and its expansion, "The Domain of Arnheim" (1847), turn the poetics into topography. Ellison, Poe's millionaire aesthete, conjectures that nature's disarrangements "were prognostic of death": the earth's surface was first designed for an immortal humanity, and its geological disturbances were preparations for man's "subsequently conceived deathful condition." Art accordingly restores the primitive intention, arranging the

landscape as it would appear to the "earth-angels" for whose scrutiny, Ellison supposes, the hemispheres were set in array.

The approach to his paradise is a single scripted effect. The visitor enters "a light canoe of ivory, stained with arabesque devices in vivid scarlet." Without oar or helmsman, the canoe begins to move "with a gentle but gradually accelerated velocity," as a body falls toward a mass. It threads a gorge of a thousand turns, so that at every moment the vessel seems "imprisoned within an enchanted circle," its keel balanced upon its own inverted reflection, "a phantom bark." At last, through a gate of burnished gold, "the whole Paradise of Arnheim bursts upon the view."

Arnheim is the Maelström redeemed: a benign vortex whose center is paradise, entered by a passenger as passive as a reader "at the writer's control." The two tales are one design with opposite signs. Their kinship is the clearest evidence that Poe's art is a technology of approach, indifferent to whether the center is Eden or the abyss.

Poe's first ambitious poem had already set its scene upon a rim. "Al Aaraaf" (1829) takes its title from al-Aʿrāf, the heights between Paradise and Hell where, in the seventh sura of the Qur'an, souls whose deeds are evenly balanced wait. Poe placed that limbo on the star that Tycho Brahe saw blaze up in 1572 and fade. The poet's first world is a waiting-place between two centers.

4.6 Conclusion: the poetics as the first chapter of *Eureka*

Read as a system, the poetics yields a set of correspondences. The writer is the God of *Eureka*, irradiating a world from a pre-established end; the reader is matter returning; the effect is the center; the frame is the vessel; the refrain is periodicity; melancholy is orbit; the ratio of brevity to intensity is Kepler's law. *Eureka* is not an aberration at the end of a career. It is the last chapter of the poetics, written when Poe saw that the laws of the tale were the laws of the world.

CHAPTER

5

Eureka

The Physics of Nostalgia

Eureka states the dinic law in its own terms: everything that exists is a dispersion of an original unity, and gravitation is the tendency of the dispersed to return. Read as a theory of desire, it makes nostalgia the fundamental force of the universe. Read against the science that followed it, it imagines the end of the world as a total gathering at the very moment physics was about to imagine it as a total dispersal. That opposition will divide modern horror into two lineages (Chapter 13).

5.1 The whirling observer

The book's first image is a method. "He who from the top of Ætna casts his eyes leisurely around, is affected chiefly by the extent and diversity of the scene. Only by a rapid whirling on his heel could he hope to comprehend the panorama in the sublimity of its oneness." The cosmologist stands where Empedocles leapt (Chapter 1), and he can grasp the One only by becoming a vortex. Totality, in *Eureka*, is perceptible only to a spinning eye. The rest of the book attempts that whirl in prose.

The satirical letter that follows explains why ordinary method fails. It was found "corked in a bottle and floating on the *Mare Tenebrarum*" — an ocean "well described by the Nubian geographer, Ptolemy Hephestion, but little frequented in modern days unless by the Transcendentalists and some other divers for crotchets." It ridicules deduction ("Aries Tottle") and induction ("Hog," that is,

Bacon), and praises Kepler, who "guessed" his laws. The joke conflates al-Idrīsī, known in Latin Europe as the Nubian Geographer, with the Alexandrian mythographer Ptolemy Hephaestion; the learned confusion is itself a specimen of the crotchets it mocks. Truth is reached by intuitive leaps tested by consistency, and consistency is a form of beauty: "symmetry and consistency are convertible terms:—thus Poetry and Truth are one." The book's epistemology is the poetics of Chapter 4 promoted to a method of science.

5.2 The general proposition and the geometry of return

"In the Original Unity of the First Thing lies the Secondary Cause of All Things, with the Germ of their Inevitable Annihilation." By an act of divine volition a single particle is created in a state of absolute simplicity, and from it matter is irradiated "spherically—in all directions," broken into atoms that differ in size, form, and distribution. Difference is the condition of a universe. The irradiation is checked by Repulsion, which Poe identifies with electricity and calls the spiritual principle; its counterpart, Attraction, is gravitation and the material principle. Poe will allow nothing else: matter "exists only as Attraction and Repulsion."

Newton's law follows from the geometry of the first act. Matter thrown outward from a point is distributed over concentric spheres whose surfaces grow as the squares of their radii. The reaction toward unity therefore varies inversely as the square of the distance. Poe derived the inverse-square law from the shape of creation.

The decisive move concerns the meaning of the center. Atoms do not seek the center as a geometrical point. They tend toward it "because of its being a point in tending towards which each atom tends most directly to its real and essential centre, Unity—the absolute and final union of all." The center of Poe's universe is not a place but a state, and the geometrical point is merely the shortest road to it. This is the first textual warrant for the claim, developed in Chapter 16, that Poe's center is untenanted.

5.3 Nostalgia as force

Johannes Hofer coined *nostalgia* in 1688 for the wasting homesickness of Swiss soldiers abroad. *Eureka*'s gravitation is that malady universalized: every atom suffers the pain of return, and its tendency toward the others is the trace of a lost home. The book's final pages extend the analogy to the soul. "We walk about,

amid the destinies of our world-existence, encompassed by dim but ever present Memories of a Destiny more vast—very distant in the by-gone time, and infinitely awful." We know these as memories, not dreams. Platonic anamnesis, the soul's recollection of the Forms, is here extended from minds to matter.

The longing has an ancient name. In the *Symposium*, Aristophanes tells how Zeus split the original double humans in two, so that each half searches for its other; "the desire and pursuit of the whole is called love" (192e–193a). In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), Freud borrowed this myth as his sole precedent for a drive to restore an earlier state of things. It is the same Aristophanes who, in the *Clouds*, enthroned Vortex in place of Zeus. His two myths, the erotic and the comic, are the two faces of the dinic law. *Eureka* unites them: the vortex is love, and love is the vortex.

5.4 Unity is Nothing; the heart is ours

The return ends in a disappearance. Matter, losing both Attraction and Repulsion, ceases to be matter, and "in sinking into Unity, it will sink at the same time into that Nothingness which, to all finite perception, Unity must be." The final globe of globes vanishes, and God remains "all in all," Paul's phrase for the end of the world (1 Corinthians 15:28) now describing a gravitational collapse. The cycle may begin again: "a novel Universe swelling into existence, and then subsiding into nothingness, at every throb of the Heart Divine." Then comes the sentence on which this dissertation turns: "And now—this Heart Divine—what is it? It is our own."

The cardiac image organizes the system. Diastole is irradiation; systole is collapse. Each human pulse repeats in miniature the beat of creation and destruction. Chapter 6 will show that Poe had already buried this heart beneath a floor.

Eureka's theology is a pantheism of divine self-dispersion. God "now exists solely in the diffused Matter and Spirit of the Universe," and "each soul is, in part, its own God—its own Creator." The doctrine dissolves the problem of evil by relocating its author: "Our souls no longer rebel at a Sorrow which we ourselves have imposed upon ourselves, in furtherance of our own purposes—with a view—if even with a futile view—to the extension of our own Joy." This is a cosmology of *tzimtzum* without *tikkun* (Chapter 1). The One withdraws into multiplicity to multiply its joy, and all suffering is self-inflicted divinity.

A note in Poe's annotated copy completes the theology and changes its tone. The pain of losing individual identity, it says, ceases when one sees that the final

process is "the absorption, by each individual intelligence, of all other intelligences (that is, of the Universe) into its own. That God may be all in all, each must become God." Return is not dissolution into a neutral whole. It is universal incorporation, each self swallowing every other. Tate's charge that Poe's lovers feed on one another, and Lawrence's that they seek to know the beloved until she dies, find their metaphysical ground in this sentence. It is the law Ligeia obeys (Chapter 8).

5.5 The shape of the end

Eureka is often praised as a prophecy of modern cosmology. Its finite universe of stars explains the darkness of the night sky; its primordial particle resembles Lemaître's "primeval atom"; its pulsing cosmos resembles Richard Tolman's oscillating universe (1934), the "ekpyrotic" and cyclic models proposed by Paul Steinhardt, Neil Turok, and their collaborators (2001–02), named for the Stoic conflagration, and Roger Penrose's conformal cyclic cosmology (2010). It even proposes a plurality of universes, each existing "in the bosom of its proper and particular God." These resemblances are structural, not anticipations of evidence. Poe reached them by deducing a cosmos from the requirements of a perfect plot.

The more consequential fact is a divergence. In 1852, three years after Poe's death, William Thomson announced a universal tendency in nature toward the dissipation of mechanical energy. Hermann von Helmholtz described the resulting heat death in 1854, and Rudolf Clausius named entropy in 1865. The eschatology of the later nineteenth century became dispersal: a cold, uniform, scattered universe in which nothing returns. *Eureka*'s is the opposite, a total gathering. Two images of the end now stood side by side, collapse into the One and dissipation into an indifferent Many. Chapter 13 argues that they generate the two great lineages of modern horror.

5.6 Emerson's circles and Poe's vortex

Eureka shares a metaphysics with the Transcendentalism it mocks. In *Nature* (1836) Emerson wrote: "I become a transparent eye-ball; I am nothing; I see all; the currents of the Universal Being circulate through me; I am part or particle of God." In "Circles" (1841) the soul is a circle that rushes outward, from a ring imperceptibly small, to larger circles without end. Poe's atoms are also particles of God, and his soul too is nothing in the end. The difference is one of vector and

affect. Emerson's circles expand; Poe's contract. Emerson's nothingness is exhilaration; Poe's is vertigo. The quarrel between Poe and the "Frogpondians" of Boston was not only a matter of temperament or regional pride. It was a disagreement about the direction of the universe.

5.7 *Eureka* among the cosmological poems

Eureka asked to be judged "as a Poem only," and it belongs to a short line of poems that tried to say everything. Lucretius' *De rerum natura* used atomic physics to free its reader from the fear of death; Poe used gravitational physics to make death the object of longing. Dante's *Paradiso* ends in the love "that moves the sun and the other stars" (XXXIII.145), and its twenty-eighth canto shows nine circles of angels whirling around a point of piercing light, the nearest the swiftest, the point on which heaven and all nature depend. Dante's cosmos is a vortex around a full center; Poe's is a vortex around an empty one. Milton's Chaos is "the womb of nature and perhaps her grave" (*Paradise Lost* II.911): vessel and abyss in a single line. Blake, in *Milton* (1804–10), wrote that "every thing has its / Own Vortex," which a traveller through eternity sees roll behind him "into a globe itself infolding." No line of transmission connects Blake and Poe. Both nevertheless reached for the same figure, the vortex folding itself into a sphere, to describe how the infinite becomes a world.

5.8 Conclusion

Eureka's achievement is a single principle that is at once physical (gravitation), psychological (longing), aesthetic (plot), and theological (the self-dispersion of God). Its horror is that the fulfilment of longing is annihilation. Its consolation is that the annihilated self becomes God by absorbing every other. The remaining chapters of Part Two read the tales as local solutions of this cosmic equation.

CHAPTER

6

The Gravitation of the Will

Perversity, the Double, and the Heart Beneath the Floor

The Imp of the Perverse is gravitation felt from inside an individual consciousness. Poe described perversity in cosmological language, as one of the *prima mobilia* of the soul, and its signature scene is a body on the lip of an abyss, drawn to fall. The confessional tales, the double tales, and "The Tell-Tale Heart" are three forms of one event: the dispersed self is pulled back toward a unity in which judge and criminal, self and other, murderer and victim, are the same.

6.1 The primum mobile of the soul

"The Imp of the Perverse" (1845) opens as an essay. Phrenologists and moralists alike, its narrator charges, "in the consideration of the faculties and impulses—of the *prima mobilia* of the human soul," have overlooked "a propensity which, although obviously existing as a radical, primitive, irreducible sentiment," has gone unnamed. The phrase is cosmological. The *primum mobile* was the outermost sphere of the Ptolemaic heavens, which turned all the others. Poe places perversity among the first movers of the soul, the forces that set its rotation.

The definition is a paradox stated with logical care: perversity is "a mobile without motive, a motive not *motivirt*," and "through its promptings we act, for the reason that we should not." "The Black Cat" (1843) had already named it "one of the primitive impulses of the human heart," an "unfathomable longing

of the soul *to vex itself*—to offer violence to its own nature—to do wrong for the wrong's sake only."

Its emblematic scene is the precipice. "We stand upon the brink of a precipice. We peer into the abyss—we grow sick and dizzy. Our first impulse is to shrink from the danger. Unaccountably we remain." Slowly the vertigo condenses into a shape, "as did the vapor from the bottle out of which arose the genius in the Arabian Nights": the idea of the fall. "And this fall—this rushing annihilation—for the very reason that it involves that one most ghastly and loathsome of all the most ghastly and loathsome images of death and suffering which have ever presented themselves to our imagination—for this very cause do we now the most vividly desire it." "There is no passion in nature so demoniacally impatient, as that of him who, shuddering upon the edge of a precipice, thus meditates a Plunge."

Both dinic emblems meet in this passage. The abyss is the vortex, and the thought of falling rises like the jinni from the sealed brass vessel of the *Nights*. Perversity is what escapes when the vessel of the self is unstopped.

6.2 Beyond akrasia: Augustine's fall and Poe's return

The tradition knew weakness of will. Aristotle analyzed *akrasia*, action against one's better knowledge (*Nicomachean Ethics* VII); Ovid's Medea sees the better and follows the worse (*Metamorphoses* VII.20–21); Paul does the evil he would not (Romans 7:19). Poe's perversity differs in kind. The akratic agent knows the good and fails to do it. The perverse agent is moved by the knowledge of the forbidden itself. The prohibition is not an obstacle the desire overcomes; it is the attractor that generates the desire.

The closest precedent is Augustine's theft of pears (*Confessions* II.4–9), committed not for the fruit but for the theft: he loved, he says, his own undoing, not the thing for which he fell but the falling itself. In Augustine's ontology, evil is privation, a turning of the will from Being toward nothing. Poe inherits the structure and inverts its meaning, for in *Eureka* Nothing is Unity and Unity is God. The soul's plunge toward annihilation is therefore also its return to the divine. This is the most radical proposition this dissertation attributes to Poe. His system abolishes the distinction between the Fall and the Return. The individual experiences the pull of the One as sin, because the law of individual life is Repulsion, and whatever draws it toward the center draws it toward its own end.

6.3 The dizziness of freedom

In June 1844, thirteen months before "The Imp of the Perverse," Kierkegaard published *The Concept of Anxiety* under the pseudonym Vigilius Haufniensis. Anxiety, he wrote, may be compared with the dizziness of one who looks down into a yawning abyss; anxiety is "the dizziness of freedom," and its structure is a sympathetic antipathy and an antipathetic sympathy. No line of transmission connects the two texts. The homology is nonetheless exact, down to the phrase Poe used for the same doubled affect: "the fierceness of the delight of its horror."

Behind both stands Schelling's treatise on human freedom (1809), which Poe could not have read but whose author he names in "Morella." Schelling locates the origin of evil in a dark ground within God, a longing (*Sehnsucht*) that precedes the divine understanding. The creature, he argues, is driven out of the center in which it was created by the anxiety of life itself, and the temptation to evil is like the secret voice heard by one seized with vertigo on a high summit, bidding him plunge. Schelling's anxiety drives the creature out of the center; Poe's perversity draws it back in. Read together they describe the two halves of *Eureka*'s pulse.

6.4 The compulsion to confess

Perversity's second form is confession. The narrator of "The Imp" commits a perfect murder by a poisoned candle and inherits his victim's estate. Years later the words "I am safe" rise in his mind, followed by their perverse completion: "I am safe—yes—if I be not fool enough to make open confession!" He runs through the streets; "some invisible fiend, I thought, struck me with his broad palm upon the back. The long-imprisoned secret burst forth from my soul." The narrator of "The Black Cat" raps with his cane on the very wall behind which his wife's corpse stands, and the cat walled up with her answers. The narrator of "The Tell-Tale Heart" tears up his own floor. Montresor, in "The Cask of Amontillado" (1846), confesses fifty years after the fact, to "you, who so well know the nature of my soul."

The secret is the inner vessel of the self, and keeping it requires a constant expenditure of Repulsion. Confession is the vessel's rupture and the return of its contents to the common center, the law. Theodor Reik's *The Compulsion to Confess* (1925) took Poe's tale as a literary anticipation of its thesis, and Freud's "Criminals from a Sense of Guilt" (1916) argued that guilt can precede the crime and seek it out as a place to rest. Dostoevsky, whose journal *Vremya* printed translations of "The Black Cat" and "The Tell-Tale Heart" in 1861, gave the

structure its great novel: Raskolnikov is drawn back to the scene, toward Porfiry Petrovich, and at last to the public square. *Notes from Underground* (1864) supplied the theory: a man will act against his own advantage merely to prove that he is not a piano key.

Every confessional narrative in Poe is also a manuscript in a bottle. Its speaker writes from the rim of execution, as the narrator of "The Imp" does from his cell: "To-day I wear these chains, and am here! To-morrow I shall be fetterless!—but where?"

6.5 The heart beneath the floor

"The Tell-Tale Heart" (1843) is the dinic law in the form of a domestic crime. "Object there was none. Passion there was none. I loved the old man." The narrator kills because of an eye, "the eye of a vulture—a pale blue eye, with a film over it." The pun on *eye* and *I* is a commonplace of criticism. The murder destroys the gaze that individuates the narrator by looking at him from outside. What follows is the return of a center. The narrator's hearing is godlike — "I heard all things in the heaven and in the earth. I heard many things in hell" — and after the dismemberment and the burial under the planks he hears "a low, dull, quick sound—much such a sound as a watch makes when enveloped in cotton." It grows until he shrieks: "tear up the planks!—here, here!—it is the beating of his hideous heart!"

Readers have long suspected that the heartbeat is the narrator's own. *Eureka* confirms the suspicion as metaphysics. Five years after the tale, Poe asked what the Heart Divine is, and answered: "It is our own." The heart beneath the floor is the cosmic heart beneath the floor of the world, and it is the narrator's. The tale is a theodicy turned inside out. In *Eureka*, sorrow is something "we ourselves have imposed upon ourselves"; in the tale, the murderer discovers that the pulse he buried is his own.

6.6 "Thou art the man"

Poe gave the discovery its formula in a comic detective story. In "Thou Art the Man" (1844), the corpse of Mr. Shuttleworthy is delivered to his murderer in a case of wine, rigged to spring upright and pronounce, through the narrator's ventriloquism, the words of the title. The phrase is Nathan's to David (2 Samuel 12:7), after the king has condemned the rich man of the parable without

knowing he condemned himself. Tiresias tells Oedipus the same thing: he is the murderer he seeks (*Oedipus Tyrannus* 362).

The same grammar names the identity of the self and the absolute in the *Chāndogya Upaniṣad* (6.8.7): *tat tvam asi*, "thou art that." Schopenhauer, who made the Upaniṣadic formula the basis of his ethics, drew its darkest consequence (*The World as Will and Representation* I, §63). Once the illusion of individuation is seen through, the tormentor and the tormented are one: the tormentor errs in thinking he has no share in the torment, the tormented in thinking he has no share in the guilt, and the will, divided against itself, sets its teeth in its own flesh. Baudelaire, Poe's translator, compressed the doctrine into a line of "L'Héautontimorouménos" (1857): "Et la victime et le bourreau!"

Poe reached this identity from the opposite side. *Eureka* declares that each soul is in part its own God; the tales draw the corollary that each soul is therefore the author of all suffering, its own included. "Thou art the man" and "thou art that" are one sentence. Spoken by the absolute, it is a revelation. Spoken by a corpse in a wine case, it is an indictment.

6.7 The double

"William Wilson" (1839) gives the identity a body. The narrator is shadowed from his school days by a namesake born on the same day, the nineteenth of January, which was Poe's own birthday. The double speaks only in a whisper and appears whenever the narrator is about to commit a crime. The school itself, Dr. Bransby's house at Stoke Newington, where Poe was a pupil, is a labyrinth: "there was really no end to its windings—to its incomprehensible subdivisions." At Rome, during carnival, the narrator runs the double through, and in a mirror that was not there before sees his own bloodied form, which speaks with his voice: "In me didst thou exist—and, in my death, see by this image, which is thine own, how utterly thou hast murdered thyself."

Otto Rank's study of the *Doppelgänger* (1914, expanded 1925) took this tale among its principal examples and argued that the double, first an assurance of immortality, becomes a harbinger of death; Freud adopted the formula in "The Uncanny" (1919). The dinic reading specifies it. The double is the self's unity appearing outside the self, the One's attraction taking the shape of a second person. To kill it is to restore unity by annihilation, which is why the murder is a suicide. The lineage runs through Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846), Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886), Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray*

(1890), which inverts "The Oval Portrait" by letting the picture age in place of the sitter, and Conrad's "The Secret Sharer" (1910).

"The Man of the Crowd" (1840) presents the double's sociological form. The narrator follows an old man through London for a night and a day and discovers that he cannot bear to be alone: when the crowd thins, he hurries to where it is densest. He is an atom that cannot tolerate dispersion, a particle of pure Attraction. The narrator abandons the pursuit with the tale's opening judgment, that the worst heart of the world is a book which does not permit itself to be read. Walter Benjamin saw in the tale the birth of the detective story from the anonymity of the metropolitan crowd. It is also the birth of the crowd as a vortex.

6.8 Conclusion

Perversity, confession, the murdered heart, the accusing corpse, and the double are five appearances of a single force. *Eureka* explains it: every soul is a dispersed fragment of a God who is the sum of souls, and every soul feels the pull of that sum as a desire to fall. Freud later divided the drives into Eros, which binds, and a death drive, which undoes. Poe did not divide them, and in this he was closer to Empedocles than Freud was. The desire for union and the desire for annihilation are one desire viewed from two positions. Poe's murderers are not monsters of difference. They are lovers of the One.

CHAPTER

7

The Odyssean Knot

Ratiocination as Counter-Vortex

Ratiocination is the technique by which a mind hears the song of the center and survives. The detective tale and the vortex tale were born together, in consecutive numbers of *Graham's Magazine* in 1841, and they are halves of one design: the first headed by the Sirens, the second by the well of Democritus. The detective is Odysseus at the mast, bound to a vessel at the rim and reading the abyss from its surface.

7.1 Twin births

"The Murders in the Rue Morgue" appeared in *Graham's* in April 1841; "A Descent into the Maelström" followed in May. Within the same year the magazine also printed "A Few Words on Secret Writing," "The Island of the Fay," "The Colloquy of Monos and Una," and the comic decapitation of "Never Bet the Devil Your Head." In six months Poe set out the detective, the vortex, the cipher, the decaying orbit, the voice from beyond death, and the centrifugal joke. The dinic system appeared complete in a single magazine year.

The twin tales take opposite positions on one proposition. The Maelström's epigraph, adapted from Joseph Glanvill, declares that the works of God have "a depth in them greater than the well of Democritus," invoking the atomist's dictum that truth lies in the depth. Dupin had answered a month earlier: "Truth is not always in a well. In fact, as regards the more important knowledge, I do believe that she is invariably superficial. The depth lies in the valleys where we

seek her, and not upon the mountain-tops where she is found." One tale descends into the depth; the other insists on the surface. Together they define the detective's position: knowledge of the center obtained from the rim.

7.2 What song the Sirens sang

The epigraph of the first detective story comes from the fifth chapter of Sir Thomas Browne's *Hydriotaphia, Urn-Burial* (1658): "What song the Syrens sang, or what name Achilles assumed when he hid himself among women, although puzzling questions, are not beyond all conjecture." Browne's sentence goes on to concede that the identity of the dead whose ashes fill the urns lies beyond the reach of antiquarian science. The detective story was founded under the sign of the funerary vessel.

In the twelfth book of the *Odyssey*, the Sirens sit in a meadow heaped with the bones of men and promise that whoever hears them will go on his way knowing more. Odysseus has himself bound to the mast and stops his rowers' ears with wax. He hears the song and survives because he cannot act on it. Horkheimer and Adorno, in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944–47), read the episode as the prehistory of bourgeois reason: the master enjoys the song as a spectacle while bound, the laborers row deaf, and self-preservation is purchased by self-denial. The reading illuminates Poe's detective. Ratiocination is the knot that lets the mind hear the song of the center — the knowledge whose attainment, in "MS. Found in a Bottle," "is destruction" — without being drawn in. Its price is that the song becomes a puzzle.

7.3 The fisherman as first detective

The Maelström's survivor is Poe's first ratiocinator. Caught in the whirlpool with his brother, he passes from terror into curiosity: "I began to reflect how magnificent a thing it was to die in such a manner"; "I positively felt a wish to explore its depths, even at the sacrifice I was going to make; and my principal grief was that I should never be able to tell my old companions on shore about the mysteries I should see." This is the Sirens' promise of knowledge, and with it the narrative impulse itself.

Inside the funnel the moon shines down the walls of water, and in the spray at the bottom hangs "a magnificent rainbow, like that narrow and tottering bridge which Mussulmen say is the only pathway between Time and Eternity": al-Ṣirāṭ, the bridge of judgment, another rim between two worlds. The fisherman

survives by turning the desire to know into observation. He makes "three important observations": larger bodies descend faster, spheres faster than other shapes, and cylinders most slowly of all. He lashes himself to a water cask, cuts it loose, and leaps; his brother, who will not reason, clings to the ring-bolt of the doomed smack and is lost. The fisherman rises as the vortex slackens, his hair turned white. He binds himself not to a mast but to a vessel, the dinic emblem in its purest form. A schoolmaster later explains the phenomenon, and Poe's footnote cites Archimedes' treatise on floating bodies, *De Incidentibus in Fluido*. The citation is fanciful; Archimedes says nothing about cylinders in whirlpools. The name is the point.

7.4 *Eureka*: the detective's cry

According to Vitruvius (*De architectura* IX, preface), King Hiero of Syracuse suspected that a goldsmith had adulterated the gold of a votive crown. Archimedes, stepping into a bath and watching the water rise, saw that the crown's volume could be measured by displacement, and ran home naked crying *Heurēka*, "I have found it." The most famous cry of discovery in Western legend is a detective's cry, uttered on solving a fraud by the physics of immersion. Poe named his cosmology with that cry, and he made the authority for the Maelström survivor the same Archimedes. The title of the book about the vortex is the exclamation of the man who discovered how vessels float. In the word *Eureka* the vortex and the vessel meet.

The word has an elder sibling. Near the end of "MS. Found in a Bottle" (1833), the narrator discovers that the careless strokes of his tar-brush on a folded studding-sail, now set upon the ghost ship, have spelled the word DISCOVERY. Poe's first major tale and his last major work are bracketed by the same word in two languages.

7.5 The bi-part soul

The opening essay of "The Murders in the Rue Morgue" distinguishes analysis from calculation. Chess rewards attention. Draughts, where moves are few, rewards the analyst who "throws himself into the spirit of his opponent, identifies himself therewith." Whist rewards observation of everything that is not the game. Watching Dupin in his analytic moods, the narrator "often dwelt meditatively upon the old philosophy of the Bi-Part Soul, and amused myself with the fancy of a double Dupin—the creative and the resolvent." The detective

contains both forces of *Eureka*: a creative power that irradiates hypotheses, and a resolvent power that reduces them to unity.

His first demonstration reconstructs the narrator's silent train of thought, and its links are the history of the vortex. Dupin traces it backward: "Chantilly, Orion, Dr. Nichol, Epicurus, Stereotomy, the street stones, the fruiterer." A stumble on loose paving suggested stereotomy; stereotomy suggested atoms; atoms, Epicurus; Epicurus, the "late nebular cosmogony" of Dr. Nichol, Poe's own source for the nebular hypothesis (Chapter 2); the cosmogony, the great nebula in Orion. The first deduction in detective fiction passes through atomism and the nebular hypothesis.

Dupin's method moves against the direction of events. The crime runs from cause to effect; the detective runs from effect back to cause, as "The Philosophy of Composition" runs from effect to design. The detective story is the most rigorous application of Poe's poetics, because its end, the solution, is necessarily known first. It also preserves the Odyssean distance. Dupin's model of perception is averted vision: "To look at a star by glances—to view it in a side-long way, by turning toward it the exterior portions of the retina... is to behold the star distinctly." Stare at the center and it dims. Read it obliquely, from the rim, and it shines.

7.6 The letter at the center

"The Purloined Letter" (1844) places the center in plain view. The Minister D —— has hidden the Queen's compromising letter by not hiding it. Refolded and re-addressed, it hangs in "a trumpery fillagree card-rack of pasteboard, that hung dangling by a dirty blue ribbon, from a little brass knob just beneath the middle of the mantel-piece." It sits at the center of the room, on its surface, and the police cannot see it because they search for depth. Dupin explains with a game played on a map, in which the large names stretched across a continent escape notice "by dint of being excessively obvious," and with a law of inertia that "seems to be identical in physics and metaphysics." He substitutes a facsimile inscribed with lines from Crébillon's *Atrée et Thyeste* about a design worthy of Atreus or Thyestes, the brothers whose feud ended in a father eating his own sons. The detective tale closes on a myth of incorporation, and it hints that Dupin and the Minister, each both poet and mathematician, are doubles and perhaps brothers.

The tale became the founding text of a theoretical controversy. In his seminar on it (delivered 1955, rewritten 1956, and placed at the head of the *Écrits* in

1966), Lacan read the letter as a pure signifier whose displacements assign each subject a position, and concluded that a letter always arrives at its destination. In "Le facteur de la vérité" (1975), Derrida objected that Lacan had ignored the narrator and the frame, and that the letter's divisibility means it can always fail to arrive. Barbara Johnson's "The Frame of Reference" (1977) showed that each critic repeats the gesture he condemns in the other.

The dinic reading adds a precise claim: the controversy restages *Eureka*. Lacan is Attraction, in which the circuit closes and the letter returns to its place. Derrida is Repulsion, in which the letter disseminates, divides, and may never come home. Johnson describes the field in which the two forces hold each other in tension, which *Eureka* says is the only condition under which a universe exists. The theorists did not apply a method to Poe. They took up positions in the field his text generates.

7.7 Cipher, gold, and the limit of analysis

"A Few Words on Secret Writing" (1841) states the detective's faith: "human ingenuity cannot concoct a cipher which human ingenuity cannot resolve." "The Gold-Bug" (1843) dramatizes it. Legrand breaks Captain Kidd's cipher by letter frequency, follows its directions to a skull nailed high in a tulip-tree, drops the golden beetle through the skull's left eye, and digs where a line from the tree through the fallen beetle meets the ground. There he finds a chest. Every ratiocinative quest in Poe ends in a vessel: a chest, a letter, a cask.

"The Mystery of Marie Rogêt" (1842–43) tests the limit. Poe transposed to Paris the unsolved death of Mary Rogers, whose body was taken from the Hudson in 1841, and had Dupin solve it from newspapers alone. The case was never solved, and when new reports suggested a botched abortion, Poe quietly revised the text for 1845. The tale's epigraph, from Novalis, concedes the gap in advance: ideal series of events run parallel with the real ones and rarely coincide. Analysis can trace the spiral toward the center, but it cannot enter it.

7.8 The fraying of the knot

The detective's later history records the slow failure of the knot. Conan Doyle's Holmes dismisses Dupin as an inferior fellow in *A Study in Scarlet* (1887), though Doyle himself credited Poe with breathing life into the form. Charles Sanders Peirce's "abduction," read beside Dupin and Holmes in Umberto Eco and Thomas Sebeok's *The Sign of Three* (1983), and Carlo Ginzburg's "evidential

paradigm" (1979) gave the method a philosophical genealogy reaching back to hunters reading tracks. In Borges's "Death and the Compass" (1942), the detective Lönnrot reasons his way, by the very elegance of his inferences, into the villa where the killer who designed the riddle for him waits; the knot has become a noose. Robbe-Grillet's *Les Gommes* (1953) returns to Oedipus, the detective who is the murderer he seeks. In Paul Auster's *City of Glass* (1985), the writer of detective novels who loses himself in his case publishes under the name William Wilson.

7.9 Conclusion

Ratiocination is the counter-vortex: a mind trained to move against the spiral, from effect back to cause and from the center back to the rim. It survives by binding itself to a vessel, whether a cask, a method, or a genre. In Poe the bargain of the knot holds. The detective hears the Sirens and lives. What he brings back is not their song but its solution.

CHAPTER

8

The Insurgent Center

The Beautiful Dead and the Will to Return

The dead beloved is the dinic center in human form. Having passed in death into the Unity that *Eureka* calls Nothing, she draws the survivor as the One draws the dispersed, and Poe's poetics assigns her the place of a passive attractor: her death is the most poetical topic, and the voice that speaks it belongs to the man who survives her. The tales refuse the assignment. Morella, Ligeia, Madeline Usher, and Eleonora come back, and their return reverses the vector of the law, for the center travels to the rim. This chapter calls that reversal the insurgent center and argues that it is the point at which Poe's system turns against the ideology it states.

8.1 The most poetical topic in the world

The syllogism of "The Philosophy of Composition" is the most notorious in American criticism. Melancholy is the most legitimate poetic tone; death is, "according to the universal understanding of mankind," the most melancholy topic; it is most poetical "when it most closely allies itself to Beauty"; therefore "the death, then, of a beautiful woman is, unquestionably, the most poetical topic in the world—and equally is it beyond doubt that the lips best suited for such topic are those of a bereaved lover." Read dinically, the syllogism allocates positions in a field. Beauty is the song of the center (Chapter 4); death is passage into the center; the beautiful woman who dies therefore becomes the center, and

the bereaved lover is left on the rim, where melancholy, the affect of orbit, is the only tone available.

Biography has supplied a model for every Poe heroine: Eliza Poe, the actress dead of consumption in Richmond in December 1811, before her son was three; Jane Stith Stanard, the mother of a schoolfriend, whom Poe called the first purely ideal love of his soul and who died in 1824; Frances Allan, his foster mother, dead in 1829; Virginia Clemm, the cousin he married in 1836, dead at Fordham in January 1847. Marie Bonaparte built her reading on that sequence. The dinic reading does not deny it. It denies that the sequence explains the law, and section 8.2 gives a chronological reason.

"To Helen" (1831), the poem Poe associated with Jane Stanard, states the law in its benign form, and states it as a law of vessels: "Helen, thy beauty is to me / Like those Nicéan barks of yore, / That gently, o'er a perfumed sea, / The weary, way-worn wanderer bore / To his own native shore." Beauty is not the shore but the ship, a vessel of *nostos* that carries the wanderer home. One persistent gloss on "Nicéan" refers the barks to the Phaeacian ship that brought Odysseus, asleep, to Ithaca (*Odyssey* XIII). Homer supplies a sequel that Poe does not mention and that his poem nonetheless enacts: returning to its harbor, the Phaeacian ship is turned to stone by Poseidon. The vessel of homecoming is petrified. In Poe's last stanza the beloved who was the bark stands "statue-like" in a "brilliant window-niche," an "agate lamp" in her hand: "Ah, Psyche, from the regions which / Are Holy Land!" The lamp is the one Psyche lit, in Apuleius' *Metamorphoses* (IV–VI), to look upon a forbidden husband, whose spilled oil woke him and put him to flight. The poem compresses Poe's erotic theory into a single emblem: the beloved carries the lover home, turns to stone, and holds the light whose use destroys love. D. H. Lawrence's sentence on Poe—"To know a living thing is to kill it"—glosses the lamp.

"Ulalume" (1847), written in the year of Virginia's death, gives the malign form. The speaker walks with Psyche, his soul, in "the lonesome October / Of my most immemorial year," and "we knew not the month was October, / And we marked not the night of the year." He follows "Astarte's bediamonded crescent," the star of love, against Psyche's terrified protest, trusting that it points "To the Lethean peace of the skies," and it brings him to the door of a tomb: "the vault of thy lost Ulalume." The poem is the moth and the star (Chapter 4) in a single walk. The lover steers by love's star and arrives at a grave; having forgotten the date, he keeps the anniversary. The center guides the feet of a mourner who does not know where he is going.

8.2 Ligeia, or the Siren's will

The name is the first clue. Ligeia, "the clear-voiced," is the name of a Siren in Hellenistic tradition (Lycophron's *Alexandra*) and in Milton's *Comus*, which invokes "fair Ligea's golden comb"; in "Al Aaraaf" Poe had already given it to the spirit of harmony. The woman through whom the narrator approaches "a wisdom too divinely precious not to be forbidden" bears the name of a singer whose song promises knowledge to whoever hears it (*Odyssey* XII). "Ligeia" (1838) is the Siren episode of Chapter 7 without the mast. Its narrator is bound, but not to anything that could save him: he is "a bounden slave in the trammels of opium."

She is an origin without an origin. "I cannot, for my soul, remember how, when, or even precisely where, I first became acquainted with the lady Ligeia"; he has "never known the paternal name of her who was my friend and my betrothed." Her eyes hold the tale's cosmology. Their expression, which he approaches "upon the very verge of remembrance" without attaining, he finds in "a circle of analogies" scattered through the universe: in a moth, a chrysalis, a stream of running water, the ocean, "the falling of a meteor," and above all in "a star of the sixth magnitude, double and changeable, to be found near the large star in Lyra." The analogies are dinic emblems: the moth that flies to the star, the chrysalis that dies into a second life, the meteor that falls. The last is the most exact. In 1803 William Herschel demonstrated that certain double stars revolve about one another, the first proof that Newtonian gravitation acts beyond the solar system. The beloved's gaze is compared to the visible evidence that attraction is universal.

The epigraph, attributed to Joseph Glanvill but found nowhere in his writings and probably Poe's own, makes will the substance of the cosmos: "For God is but a great will pervading all things by nature of its intentness. Man doth not yield himself to the angels, nor unto death utterly, save only through the weakness of his feeble will." Schopenhauer had published his metaphysics of the will in 1819; Poe could not have read it, and the homology is the more striking. "The Conqueror Worm," published separately in 1843 and inserted into the tale in 1845 as Ligeia's dying poem, stages the world as a theater in which mimes "in the form of God on high" are "Mere puppets ... who come and go / At bidding of vast formless things," with "much of Madness, and more of Sin, / And Horror the soul of the plot." The last line is Poe's poetics in a phrase. Ligeia's dying cry —"Are we not part and parcel in Thee?"—recalls Emerson's "part or particle of

God" (Chapter 5), but as protest rather than rapture. She asks that the part not be lost in the whole.

Her return is achieved through the second wife. Rowena Trevanion is fair-haired and blue-eyed, and her name comes from Scott's *Ivanhoe* (1819), in which the Saxon Rowena marries the hero and the dark Rebecca leaves England. Poe reverses Scott. Ligeia, whose eyes are "far larger than the ordinary eyes of our own race," fuller than "the gazelle eyes of the tribe of the valley of Nourjahad," is the dark and foreign woman, orientalized in the very syntax of her description, and she does not depart. She returns and consumes the fair one. In the pentagonal bridal chamber, with its Egyptian sarcophagi and its arabesque tapestries whose figures change as the viewer moves, the narrator sees, "or may have dreamed" he sees, "three or four large drops of a brilliant and ruby colored fluid" fall into Rowena's goblet "as if from some invisible spring in the atmosphere of the room." The essence of the dead enters the living through a vessel. Through the night of vigil, "time after time, until near the period of the gray dawn, this hideous drama of revivification was repeated," each relapse "into a sterner and apparently more irredeemable death," until the shrouded figure rises and the narrator sees "the full, and the black, and the wild eyes ... of the LADY LIGEIA."

The oscillation is *Eureka*'s pulse: systole and diastole, death and return, repeated until the final beat. Its outcome is *Eureka*'s marginal note (Chapter 5), in which the pain of losing individual identity ends when each intelligence absorbs all others: "That God may be all in all, each must become God." Ligeia does not dissolve into the One. She becomes the One by incorporating Rowena. The return of the dead is the victory of a will that has learned the law of the center and turned it into a weapon.

A letter Poe wrote to George W. Eveleth on 4 January 1848 completes the case and inverts its usual use. "Six years ago, a wife, whom I loved as no man ever loved before, ruptured a blood-vessel in singing." She recovered partially; "At the end of a year the vessel broke again—I went through precisely the same scene. Again in about a year afterward. Then again—again—again & even once again at varying intervals. Each time I felt all the agonies of her death." The letter's summary is exact: "I became insane, with long intervals of horrible sanity." Virginia's illness was the repeated breaking of a vessel during song, each break followed by a death and a return: the "hideous drama of revivification" lived for five years. But "Ligeia" appeared in 1838, four years before the first hemorrhage. The tale does not transcribe the life; the life fell into the shape of the tale.

Biography cannot be the origin of a structure that precedes it. The dinic law explains why Poe experienced his wife's dying as he did; the dying does not explain the law.

8.3 Morella and Berenice: the name and the idea

"Morella" (1835) is the earlier and more abstract version. Its heroine's erudition is "profound," her studies are in the mystics, and her husband shares her absorption in Locke's account of personal identity and in "the notion of that identity which at death is or is not lost for ever." The question is the *principium individuationis*: what keeps one self distinct from another, and whether the distinction survives death. In *Eureka*'s terms it is a question about Repulsion. The husband comes to loathe her; she dies in childbirth with a prophecy—"I am dying, yet shall I live"—and a curse: "her whom in life thou didst abhor, in death thou shalt adore." The daughter grows into her mother's exact likeness and remains unnamed until her baptism, where the father hears himself whisper the forbidden name: "What fiend spoke from the recesses of my soul, when ... I whispered within the ears of the holy man the syllables—Morella?" The child answers, "I am here!" and dies. When he lays her in the family vault, he finds "no traces of the first, in the charnel where I laid the second."

Three features of the tale recur throughout the corpus. The decisive act is an utterance the speaker experiences as perverse (Chapter 6). The name is the vessel of identity, and pronouncing it collapses two persons into one (Chapter 10). And the tomb, opened, is empty: the center is untenanted (Chapter 9). Pythagorean palingenesis, which the narrator lists among his studies, is not refuted but fulfilled. The soul returned; it was the second body that could not survive the return.

"Berenice" (1835) relocates the center from the name to the body. Its narrator, Egaeus, suffers from "a morbid irritability of those properties of the mind in metaphysical science termed the attentive": his attention collapses onto single objects, the margin of a book, a shadow on a tapestry, the flame of a lamp, until it fixes on the teeth of his cousin and betrothed. "Of Mad'selle Sallé it has been well said, 'que tous ses pas étaient des sentiments,' and of Berenice I more seriously believed que toutes ses dents étaient des idées." The teeth are ideas: Platonic Forms imagined as hard white objects lodged in a perishable body. After her burial, Egaeus is shown a spade against the wall and learns that her grave has been violated and her body, still living, disfigured; the box on his table spills "thirty-two small, white and ivory-looking substances." The epigraph,

from Ebn Zaiat, had promised that a visit to the beloved's grave would ease the mourner's sorrow. Egaeus went with a spade. "Berenice" is the most literal of Poe's idealisms. The Form is extracted from the body and sealed in a vessel, and the body is left behind. Tate's charge that Poe's lovers prey upon one another's essence (Introduction) has no clearer warrant.

8.4 Eleonora and the Lullian vessel

"Eleonora" (1842) opens with a manifesto for the visionary rim: "Men have called me mad; but the question is not yet settled, whether madness is or is not the loftiest intelligence." Those who dream by day "obtain glimpses of eternity, and thrill, in awakening, to find that they have been upon the verge of the great secret." They sail, "however rudderless or compassless, into the vast ocean of the 'light ineffable,'" and, "like the adventurers of the Nubian geographer, 'agressi sunt mare tenebrarum, quid in eo esset exploraturi'": they set out upon the Sea of Darkness to discover what it held. The *Mare Tenebrarum* of the Maelström and of *Eureka* (Introduction) is also the sea of the visionary lover. The claim that madness may be the loftiest intelligence descends from the pseudo-Aristotelian *Problemata* (XXX.1), which asked why all who excel in philosophy, poetry, or the arts are melancholic, and from the Renaissance doctrine of saturnine genius that Ficino elaborated and Dürer engraved in *Melencolia I* (1514).

The narrator and his cousin grow up in the Valley of the Many-Colored Grass, ringed by mountains and watered by a stream they call the River of Silence. It is a vessel-landscape, an Eden sealed against the world. When love awakens, the valley blooms; when Eleonora dies, it fades. He vows never to bind himself "in marriage to any daughter of Earth," leaves for a strange city, and marries Ermengarde, whereupon a voice absolves him: "Sleep in peace!—for the Spirit of Love reigneth and ruleth, and, in taking to thy passionate heart her who is Ermengarde, thou art absolved, for reasons which shall be made known to thee in Heaven, of thy vows unto Eleonora." Many readers have concluded that Ermengarde is Eleonora returned.

Euripides' *Alcestis* (438 BCE) is the mythic homology. Admetus vows to his dying wife that he will never remarry; Heracles wrestles Death and brings back a veiled woman whom Admetus is pressed to take into his house; unveiled, she is Alcestis, though she may not speak for three days. "Eleonora" and "Ligeia" are the two solutions to the Alcestis problem. In the first, the second wife is the first, and the vow is fulfilled in its breaking. In the second, the first wife destroys the second in order to occupy her body.

The epigraph governs the benign solution: *Sub conservatione formæ specificæ salva anima*, which Poe attributes to Raymond Lully. Under the preservation of the specific form, the soul is safe. Ramon Llull (c. 1232–1316) built his *Ars* from concentric rotating figures inscribed with the divine attributes, whose combinations were meant to generate every truth; Leibniz's *Dissertatio de arte combinatoria* (1666) acknowledged the debt, and Swift satirized the method in the word-engine of Lagado (*Gulliver's Travels* III.5). Poe's theory of invention, stated in the review of Moore's *Alciphron*, holds that all novel conceptions are merely "unusual combinations" (Chapter 3). The theory is Lullian in form. Its instrument is the rotating wheel, a combinatory machine that works by turning: a vortex of invention. The motto, meanwhile, is the creed of the dinic vessel. The soul survives not in a substance but in a form. Eleonora returns not as a body but as the specific form of love, which Ermengarde can fill. Form is the vessel that rides the vortex, and this is why Poe's poetics cannot stop talking about it.

8.5 The Oval Portrait: the vessel that kills

The motto has a dark corollary, which "The Oval Portrait" draws. The tale first appeared in 1842 under the Coleridgean title "Life in Death" (Chapter 3). A wounded traveler sheltering in one of the Apennine piles that have frowned "not less in fact than in the fancy of Mrs. Radcliffe" moves a candelabrum and discovers the portrait of a young girl of "absolute life-likeliness." A volume on his pillow explains it. The painter's bride sat for weeks in a dark turret where the light dripped from above, and "he would not see that the tints which he spread upon the canvas were drawn from the cheeks of her who sat beside him." At the last stroke he cried, "This is indeed Life itself!" and turned to his beloved: "She was dead!"

The tale reverses Ovid's Pygmalion (*Metamorphoses* X), whose statue warms into a woman; here a woman cools into a picture. Hawthorne's "The Birth-Mark" (1843), in which a scientist's removal of his wife's single blemish kills her, and Balzac's "Le Chef-d'œuvre inconnu" (1831), in which a painter's pursuit of absolute life ends in an illegible canvas, belong to the same reckoning with the price of perfection. In dinic terms the portrait is a vessel that fills only by emptying another. Its frame is the "close circumscription of space" the poetics requires (Chapter 4), and its effect is purchased with a life. The sitter's long session mirrors the reader's single sitting: both are held at the artist's control, and in both the effect consumes its occasion. Here the 1846 syllogism confesses

what it concealed. The death of a beautiful woman is not merely the work's preferred topic. It is the work's material.

8.6 The insurgent center

Feminist criticism has named the economy these tales sustain. Elisabeth Bronfen's *Over Her Dead Body* (1992) argues that Western culture makes the feminine corpse the privileged site at which death is at once represented and held at a distance, so that the dead woman becomes the precondition of the aesthetic itself; Poe's syllogism is her central exhibit. J. Gerald Kennedy (1987) reads Poe's writing as a sustained response to the fact of death. Cynthia Jordan (1987) reads "Ligeia" and "Usher" as recovering a suppressed "second story," the one told by women whom the male narrators silence. Joan Dayan (1994) links the idealized lady to the owned slave, a link Chapter 16 develops.

The dinic reading confirms these critiques and specifies their mechanism. The poetics distributes the cosmos by gender. The woman receives the center: dead, silent, beautiful, attractive only in the passive sense in which *Eureka*'s center is not a body but a state toward which bodies fall. The man receives the rim: alive, speaking, orbiting, melancholic, and in possession of the narrative. The tales do not keep the distribution. Ligeia wills; Morella prophesies and curses; Berenice is alive in her violated grave; Madeline breaks from her coffin and "stands without the door" (Chapter 9). The center acquires a will, and the vector of the law reverses. The lover no longer falls toward the center; the center rises toward the lover. This is the Abstract's definition of horror made literal: the approach of the center against the will.

Myth knows the reversal and usually forbids it. Orpheus descends to retrieve Eurydice and loses her by a backward look (Virgil, *Georgics* IV; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X). Maurice Blanchot's "Le regard d'Orphée" (1955) made that look the origin of the literary work, since the writer desires the dead not restored to daylight but in her own darkness. Poe's lovers are inverted Orpheuses. They do not descend; the dead ascend unbidden. Ueda Akinari's "The House Amid the Thickets" (*Ugetsu monogatari*, 1776), in which a husband returns after seven years to a wife who receives him for one night and is revealed at dawn to be a ghost, and the segment "Black Hair" in Kobayashi Masaki's *Kwaidan* (1964), adapted from Lafcadio Hearn, whose Cincinnati mentor nicknamed him "the Raven" for his devotion to Poe, show the same structure in another tradition. Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) supplies the clinical form: in mourning the libido withdraws from the lost object, while in melancholia the

ego identifies with it and the object's shadow falls across the self. Poe's narrators never mourn. Their objects return because they were never released.

Gérard de Nerval found the emblem in "El Desdichado" (1854): "Ma seule Étoile est morte,—et mon luth constellé / Porte le Soleil noir de la Mélancolie"—my only star is dead, and my starred lute bears the black sun of melancholy. Julia Kristeva's *Soleil noir* (1987) made the line the motto of a theory of melancholia. In Poe's cosmology it is literal. *Eureka* explains the darkness of the night sky by the finite age of the stars and the finite speed of their light (Chapter 2), and a star seen at night may have perished before its light arrives. The dead beloved is such a star. Her light still reaches the lover, who orbits a center that no longer exists by a radiance that remains.

The insurgency has a cosmological meaning. *Eureka* describes two longings, not one. The many long for the One, and that longing is gravitation. But the One first dispersed itself into the many "with a view ... to the extension of our own Joy" (Chapter 5): creation is the One's desire for multiplicity, the divine form of Repulsion. The returning dead woman repeats that first act. When Ligeia rises from Rowena's body, the center irradiates back into individual life, as God irradiated the primordial particle into a world. The marriage plot of the tales is *Eureka* in domestic form. The husband enacts Attraction, falling toward his dead wife; the wife enacts Diffusion, returning into individual life. Their meeting at the chamber door is the meeting of the two forces, and its affect is horror.

8.7 Conclusion

The beautiful dead woman is the dinic center personified, and Poe's poetics enthroned her there to secure the lover's melancholy and the poem's effect. The tales find the throne occupied by a will. Ligeia turns the law of absorption into conquest; Morella turns her name into a summons; Berenice's ideas are pulled from her mouth; Eleonora survives as a form; the painter's bride dies into a frame. In each case the center refuses to remain a place and becomes a power. The return, it turns out, runs in both directions.

CHAPTER

9

Vessels

Houses, Tombs, Ships, and the Ontology of Enclosure

Every major Poe text contains a vessel, and every vessel is breached. The House of Usher splits and sinks; Prospero's welded abbey admits the Red Death; the dungeon at Toledo closes toward its pit; coffins open; ships go down in whirlpools. This chapter argues that enclosure in Poe is not a defense against the vortex but its architecture. Walls concentrate what they hold, and concentration is approach to the center. The breach always comes from within, because what a Poe vessel excludes is already inside it. And the center, when reached, is empty.

9.1 The empty center

A vessel is defined by what it is not. The eleventh chapter of the *Daodejing* makes the point with three images: thirty spokes share one hub, and the wheel is useful because of the emptiness at its center; clay is shaped into a pot, and the pot is useful because of the emptiness within; doors and windows are cut to make a room, and the room is useful because of the space it encloses. The wheel, the vessel, and the room are the three dinic forms—vortex, vessel, and house—and the *Daodejing* derives all three from an empty center. Heidegger's lecture "Das Ding" (1950) argued the same of a jug: its thingness lies not in the clay but in the void that holds, which the potter shapes as surely as the walls. Reinhard May (1989) has argued that the lecture owes an unacknowledged debt to the Daoist text.

Western tradition gave Poe the theological form of the idea. Paul's "treasure in earthen vessels" (2 Corinthians 4:7) and his "vessels of wrath" and "vessels of mercy" (Romans 9:22–23) make the human person a container of divine content. Sir Thomas Browne's *Hydriotaphia*, the source of the first detective story's epigraph (Chapter 7), is a meditation on funeral urns that ends with a sentence *Eureka* would echo: "Life is a pure flame, and we live by an invisible Sun within us."

Poe's vessels fall into two classes. Vessels of preservation—house, abbey, cell, tomb, the closed room—hold their contents against the world. Vessels of transmission—bottle, cask, box, ship, manuscript—carry their contents across an abyss. The first fail by implosion, the second by sinking. Three laws govern both. The walls move inward. The breach comes from within. The center, reached, is untenanted.

9.2 The House of Usher: the fissure and the tarn

"The Fall of the House of Usher" (1839) makes the house and its family a single being. The peasantry's name, the "House of Usher," includes "both the family and the family mansion," and the narrator's first view shows a face with "vacant eye-like windows." "The Haunted Palace," Roderick's poem, published separately earlier the same year, makes the identity explicit: a palace "By good angels tenanted" is a head whose windows are eyes and whose door is a mouth, until "evil things, in robes of sorrow," assail it and "A hideous throng rush out forever, / And laugh—but smile no more." Wilbur's reading of the house as the poet's mind (Introduction) begins here.

The vessel is breached from the start. A "barely perceptible fissure" runs from the roof "in a zigzag direction, until it became lost in the sullen waters of the tarn." It is the *shevirah* of Lurianic cosmogony (Chapter 1), the crack through which a vessel's light escapes, and it is the vortex's track drawn on the facade like a lightning path. The tarn below holds "the remodelled and inverted images" of the house, so that building and abyss appear as one figure. The atmosphere, Roderick believes, has "no affinity with the air of heaven," and the stones, by "the method of collocation" and the fungi that overspread them, have acquired sentience. The house is not a shelter but a living vessel whose contents are being drawn into its own foundations.

Gaston Bachelard read Poe through this tarn. *L'Eau et les rêves* (1942) devotes a chapter to the "heavy water" of Poe's imagination: dark, still, maternal, a substance in which life is slowly absorbed by death. The same book names a

"Charon complex," the reverie in which death is a voyage by water and the boat the first coffin. Usher's library is oriented the same way. Beside Swedenborg's *Heaven and Hell*, Holberg's hollow-earth romance, and Tieck's *Journey into the Blue Distance*, it holds Campanella's *City of the Sun* (written 1602), a utopia laid out in seven concentric rings named for the planets around a circular temple at the summit. Roderick's favorite book is a funeral office, the *Vigiliæ Mortuorum secundum Chorum Ecclesiæ Maguntinæ*.

Madeline is entombed in a vault "at great depth," once a donjon and later a powder magazine, its floor and archway "carefully sheathed with copper," as a ship's hull was sheathed. The house contains a ship, and the ship contains a living woman. As the narrator reads aloud from Sir Launcelot Canning's "Mad Trist," each sound in the romance is answered by a sound from below, until Roderick confesses—"We have put her living in the tomb!"—and shrieks that "she now stands without the door!" Madeline falls inward upon her brother and bears him to the floor "a corpse, and a victim to the terrors he had anticipated." The narrator flees; the blood-red moon shines through the widening fissure; and with "a long tumultuous shouting sound like the voice of a thousand waters," the tarn closes "sullenly and silently" over the fragments. The sound is that of the divine voice in Ezekiel (43:2) and Revelation (1:15), a voice like the noise of many waters. The house returns to the abyss it had reflected from the beginning, and vessel and vortex become one.

9.3 The Masque of the Red Death: the untenanted center

"The Masque of the Red Death" (1842) is the purest vessel in the corpus and the clearest proof of the third law. Prince Prospero withdraws with a thousand courtiers into a castellated abbey, and "the courtiers, having entered, brought furnaces and massy hammers and welded the bolts." The plague outside is described as a sacred descent: "Blood was its Avatar and its seal." The Sanskrit *avatāra* names the descent of a god into a body.

The masquerade fills seven chambers, so irregularly disposed that there is "a sharp turn at every twenty or thirty yards," colored from east to west blue, purple, green, orange, white, violet, and black, the last with panes of "a deep blood color." The suite has been read as the course of a day, of a life, and of the seven ages of man. Three further homologies sharpen it. In Campanella's *City of the Sun*, which Usher kept, the seven rings bear the names of the planets. In the Hermetic *Poimandres*, the soul rises through the seven planetary zones, shedding a passion at each, to reach God beyond the seventh (Chapter 1). And Prospero's

name is Shakespeare's. In *The Tempest* (IV.1) Prospero's masque breaks off when he remembers a conspiracy against his life—"Our revels now are ended"—and the speech that follows dissolves the world into a dream rounded with a sleep. Poe wrote the sequel to an interrupted masque.

In the black chamber stands an ebony clock. Each hour its chime stops the orchestra, and "the waltzers perforce ceased their evolutions." The waltz was the dance of rotation; the chime is the periodic stroke that suspends it. The masquers are orbiting bodies whose motion is measured, and at intervals arrested, by the clock of the end. At midnight a figure appears in the costume of a corpse, its vesture "dabbled in blood." Prospero pursues it from east to west through all seven chambers and falls dead in the black one. When the revelers seize the intruder, they find "the grave-cerements and corpse-like mask ... untenanted by any tangible form."

This is the master emblem of the dinic system. The ascent through the spheres, which in Hermetic tradition ends in the presence of God, ends at an empty costume. The god whose avatar is blood has descended into nothing. The abbey was welded against the plague, and the plague was inside from the start, because it was the destiny of the bodies within. "And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all."

9.4 The Pit and the Pendulum: the walls move inward

"The Pit and the Pendulum" (1842) states the first law in pure form. Its prisoner, condemned by the Inquisition at Toledo, explores his dungeon in total darkness, measuring it with a strip torn from his robe, stumbles, and finds himself at the lip of a circular well at its center: "the pit, typical of hell, and regarded by rumor as the Ultima Thule of all their punishments." Thule, the northernmost land of ancient geography and the "ultimate dim Thule" of "Dream-Land" (Chapter 2), has been moved to the middle of a cell. The pole of the world is a hole in a floor.

The torments that follow make the dinic forces mechanical. Strapped beneath a painted figure of Time, the prisoner watches a crescent blade descend on a pendulum, each sweep a little lower: periodicity, the principle of the refrain (Chapter 4), become an instrument of execution. Freed by rats that gnaw his bonds, he sees the walls glow red and close in, the square chamber deforming until "two of its iron angles were now acute—two, consequently, obtuse," to drive him into the pit. The vessel has become a press. At the brink, "an outstretched arm caught my own as I fell, fainting, into the abyss. It was that of General Lasalle. The French army had entered Toledo."

The source was William Mudford's "The Iron Shroud" (*Blackwood's*, 1830), whose prisoner watches his cell contract day by day into a coffin (Chapter 3). Poe added the center: Mudford's cell crushes, while Poe's drives its prisoner toward a hole. And Poe added the arm. Lasalle's rescue is the only moment in the Gothic tales when the outer world enters a vessel to save rather than to destroy, and readers have often found it arbitrary. It is better understood as the knot of Chapter 7 in historical form. The narrator survives, like Odysseus, because something outside the vortex holds him.

9.5 Tombs, berths, and the cask

"The Premature Burial" (1844) catalogues cases of the living entombed, and its cataleptic narrator builds a vault that opens from within, with a bell whose rope runs into the coffin. He wakes one night in absolute darkness in a box too narrow to turn in, certain he has been buried, and discovers that he is in the berth of a small sloop on the James River, "laden with garden mould." Ship and coffin are interchangeable, as Bachelard's Charon complex predicts, and the cargo is earth. The narrator is cured and abandons graveyard reading—"no fustian about churchyards—no bugaboo tales—such as this"—but closes by warning that the "grim legion of sepulchral terrors" are like the demons in whose company Afrasiab sailed down the Oxus: "they must sleep, or they will devour us."

The tomb is the home toward which the dinic law tends, and Poe says so outright. At the end of "The Colloquy of Monos and Una" (1841), when Monos has lost sensation and then even the sense of time, retaining only a consciousness of place, "for all this nothingness, yet for all this immortality, the grave was still a home." Nostalgia finds its object in the grave. "The Sleeper" (1831) records the child's version of the same intuition: a girl who once threw stones against a tomb door, "Thrilling to think, poor child of sin! / It was the dead who groaned within."

"The Cask of Amontillado" (1846) builds the vessel on the page. Montresor lures Fortunato, dressed in motley and bells, through the nitre-encrusted catacombs with the promise of a cask, "a pipe of what passes for Amontillado," and walls him into a niche, tier by tier, with the trowel he had earlier produced as proof that he was one of "the masons." Fortunato came for the contents of a vessel and became the contents of one. Montresor's arms are "a huge human foot d'or, in a field azure; the foot crushes a serpent rampant whose fangs are imbedded in the heel," with the motto *Nemo me impune lacessit*. The device illustrates Genesis 3:15, in which the woman's seed will bruise the serpent's head

and the serpent his heel. It is an emblem of mutual destruction, container and contained wounding one another. The tale's last words are a burial blessing delivered across half a century: "*In pace requiescat!*"

9.6 Ships, boxes, and the bottle

The vessels of transmission are ships, and in Poe the ship is alive. In "MS. Found in a Bottle" (1833), the narrator, flung by a storm onto a vast black ship running south, notices the "extreme porousness" of its timber and recalls an old Dutch navigator's saying: "as sure as there is a sea where the ship itself will grow in bulk like the living body of the seaman." The ancient crew does not see him. He understands that "we are hurrying onwards to some exciting knowledge—some never-to-be-imparted secret, whose attainment is destruction." The ice parts, the ship whirls "in immense concentric circles, round and round the borders of a gigantic amphitheatre," the circles "rapidly grow small," and the manuscript ends in the present tense: "the ship is quivering—oh God! and—going down!" The text survives because it was sealed in a bottle. Its epigraph, from Quinault's libretto *Atys*, states the confessional law of the last moment: he who has but a moment to live has nothing left to dissemble.

Two tales test the vessel against the vortex. In "A Descent into the Maelström" the fisherman lashes himself to a buoyant cask and survives (Chapter 7). In "The Oblong Box" (1844) the artist Wyatt travels with a long box in his stateroom that the narrator takes for a smuggled painting; it holds the corpse of Wyatt's wife, packed in salt and concealed from the sailors' superstition. When the ship founders, Wyatt refuses to abandon it, lashes himself to the box, and sinks; the captain remarks that the box will rise again once its salt has melted. The gesture repeats the fisherman's; the outcome is the opposite. The fisherman binds himself to an empty vessel and rises. Wyatt binds himself to a full one and goes down. The beloved dead are ballast.

The Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym (1838) begins with a vessel inside a vessel. Pym stows away in the hold of the *Grampus* in an iron-bound box, and when a mutiny prevents his release he lies buried alive in the dark, starving, until his dog brings him a scrap on which he reads, written in blood, "—blood—your life depends upon lying close." The voyage carries him through mutiny, shipwreck, cannibalism, and the black island of Tsalal to a white cataract (Chapter 16). It begins in a coffin aboard a ship and ends at a chasm that "threw itself open to receive us."

The manuscript in the bottle became the emblem of the lyric itself. Osip Mandelstam's essay "On the Interlocutor" (1913) compared the poem to a sealed letter thrown into the sea by a doomed navigator and addressed to whoever finds it. Paul Celan, accepting the Bremen Literature Prize in 1958, called the poem a message in a bottle (*Flaschenpost*), sent out in the not always hopeful belief that it may wash ashore somewhere, perhaps on a heart-land. Adorno ended his essay on Schoenberg in *Philosophy of New Music* (1949) by calling authentic modern music the true message in a bottle. The lineage begins with Poe's narrator, sealing his manuscript as his ship goes down.

9.7 The body as vessel

The human body is the last vessel, and "The Facts in the Case of M. Valdemar" (1845) breaches it under laboratory conditions. Mesmerized at the moment of death, Valdemar remains for seven months in a state neither living nor dead; his voice seems to come "from a vast distance, or from some deep cavern within the earth," and what it says is "I have been sleeping—and now—now—I am dead." Released from trance, the body collapses at once into liquid corruption. Mesmerism preserved a form after the soul had gone; when the form is withdrawn, nothing holds the matter together. The tale is the Lullian motto of "Eleonora" read backward (Chapter 8): under the preservation of the specific form, the soul is safe, and without it the body has nowhere to stand. Chapter 10 returns to the voice.

9.8 The interior and its case

In "The Philosophy of Furniture" (1840) Poe designs the ideal room: an oblong chamber in crimson and gold, lit by an Argand lamp through a crimson-tinted shade, its windows curtained in crimson silk. "The proprietor lies asleep on a sofa—the weather is cool—the time is near midnight: we will make a sketch of the room during his slumber." The perfect interior holds a sleeping soul and is described while he sleeps. Walter Benjamin, who treated Poe as a founder of the physiognomy of the interior, described the nineteenth-century dwelling in the *Arcades Project* as a receptacle for the person, encasing its occupant and his belongings as a compass lies in a velvet-lined case. The bourgeois interior is a vessel of preservation, and Benjamin tied it to the detective story, since an interior that takes impressions keeps traces. "The Domain of Arnheim" and

"Landor's Cottage" (1849) extend the ideal room into landscape: closed, curated, entered by a single path, and arranged for one effect (Chapter 4).

These benign vessels belong with the malign ones. The sleeper on the sofa, the corpse in the oblong box, the woman in the copper vault, and the masquers in the welded abbey are four states of a single figure, a soul in an enclosure. The interior that preserves is the tomb before the burial.

9.9 Conclusion

Enclosure in Poe is the vortex in architectural form. Its walls move inward because concentration is approach to the center. Its breach comes from within because the vessel holds the destiny it was built to exclude: the plague in the abbey, the sister in the vault, the corpse in the box, the heart beneath the floor. And its center, reached, is empty: the charnel without Morella, the costume without a wearer. Each is a *dînos* in both senses of Aristophanes' joke, a pot that is also a whirl. The vessel does not resist the vortex. It is the shape the vortex gives to whatever it carries.

CHAPTER

10

Words as Forces

Script, Cipher, Refrain, and the Impossible Utterance

In Poe a word is not a sign but a force. Spoken, it is an impulse on the air whose consequences never cease, so that speech is a mode of creation. Pronounced as a name, it is a vessel that holds a person and can summon or annihilate her. Written, it becomes a cipher, and the world itself appears as an inscription awaiting decipherment. Repeated as rhyme and refrain, it is the microphysics of return. At its limit, language tries to speak from the center itself and produces Valdemar's impossible sentence: "I am dead." This chapter argues that Poe's theory of language is the dinic law applied to signification. Words disperse from a speaker as matter from the primordial particle, and meaning is the force that draws them back.

10.1 The physical power of words

"The Power of Words" (1845) is a dialogue between two spirits in space. Oinos, newly dead, had expected to know all things at once; Agathos corrects him in a sentence that states the ethic of the orbit: "Ah, not in knowledge is happiness, but in the acquisition of knowledge! In for ever knowing, we are for ever blessed; but to know all were the curse of a fiend." Happiness belongs to the approach, damnation to the arrival. The narrator of "MS. Found in a Bottle" had said the same of the secret "whose attainment is destruction."

Agathos then expounds a physics of consequence. The Deity created only in the beginning; every later creation is mediate, the propagation of an original

impulse. A hand moved on earth sets the atmosphere vibrating, the vibration spreads without limit, and a sufficiently perfect intelligence could trace any impulse forward to all its effects, or any effect back to its cause. The source is Babbage's library of the air (Chapter 2), the epistemology Laplace's. The conclusion is Poe's own: "did there not cross your mind some thought of the physical power of words? Is not every word an impulse on the air?" The spirits hover above a "wild star," and Agathos confesses that he made it: "It is now three centuries since with clasped hands, and with streaming eyes, at the feet of my beloved—I spoke it—with a few passionate sentences—into birth. Its brilliant flowers are the dearest of all unfulfilled dreams, and its raging volcanoes are the passions of the most turbulent and unhallowed of hearts."

The passage is the poetics of 1846 projected as cosmogony. A world is spoken at the feet of a beloved, in tears; its flowers are unfulfilled longings and its volcanoes unhallowed passions. Lament creates. The creator's sorrow and sin pass into the substance of what he makes, as *Eureka*'s God disperses himself into a universe of self-imposed sorrow (Chapter 5). The angel weeps over the world his word has made.

The speakers' names extend the argument. *Oinos* is the archaic Latin form of *unus*, "one"; *Agathos* is Greek for "good." In "The Colloquy of Monos and Una" (1841) both speakers are called "one," in Greek and in Latin. Poe's dialogues of the dead are conversations of the One with itself across a division: Aristophanes' severed halves (Chapter 5) resumed in the afterlife.

Comparative cosmogony offers two exact homologies. The so-called Memphite Theology, inscribed on the Shabaka Stone around 700 BCE, describes the god Ptah conceiving the world in his heart and bringing it forth with his tongue, so that every divine word comes into being through what the heart devises and the tongue commands. *Eureka* supplied the heart ("It is our own"); "The Power of Words" supplies the tongue. The Kabbalistic *Sefer Yetzirah* describes creation through the twenty-two letters of the Hebrew alphabet, and the legend of the Golem, studied by Gershom Scholem (1960), carries the doctrine into clay. In one widespread version, the word *emet* (truth), inscribed on the creature's forehead, animates it; erasing the first letter leaves *met* (dead), and the body returns to dust. One letter divides truth from death, and the body that receives it is an earthen vessel.

Poe's century nearly built Agathos's library. In 1857 Édouard-Léon Scott de Martinville patented the phonautograph, which traced sound waves as wavering lines on soot-blackened paper but could not play them back. A tracing of a voice

singing "Au clair de la lune," made in 1860, was converted into sound in 2008, a hundred and forty-eight years after the singing. It is the most literal manuscript in a bottle the nineteenth century produced: a voice sealed as script, adrift until a reader could decode it.

10.2 The name as vessel

The name is the vessel of identity, and pronouncing it is a dinic act. In "Morella" the father stands at the baptismal font, itself a vessel, and "hesitated for a name"; the forbidden syllables rise unbidden, the child answers "I am here!" and dies (Chapter 8). The name pours the mother into the daughter, and the daughter cannot survive the filling.

The lost beloved survives only as a name, and the name has withdrawn to the center. The lover of "The Raven" mourns "the rare and radiant maiden whom the angels name Lenore— / Nameless here for evermore." The angels possess the name; on earth she has none. In "Ulalume" the speaker learns where his feet have led him by reading a name on a tomb door. In "Annabel Lee" (1849) the beloved's name and the sea share one rhyme from first stanza to last, ending "In her sepulchre there by the sea— / In her tomb by the sounding sea." The name sounds like the abyss because it has become part of it.

The philosophy of this relation was formulated a century later. In "La littérature et le droit à la mort" (1948), Maurice Blanchot cites Hegel's Jena lectures, in which Adam's first act of mastery is to name the animals, and so to annihilate them as existing things. The word gives being, Blanchot concludes, but deprived of being. Mallarmé, Poe's French translator, made the doctrine a poetics: I say "a flower!" and there rises, musically, the one absent from every bouquet ("Crise de vers," 1897). In Poe the annihilating name is not a premise of literature but an event inside it. Morella's daughter dies of her name; Lenore lives only in hers.

The name also defends. Poe's "Sonnet—Silence" (1840) describes "a two-fold Silence—sea and shore— / Body and soul." The first, the silence of the grave, has a name: "some solemn graces, / Some human memories and tearful lore, / Render him terrorless: his name's 'No More.'" The second is a nameless shadow haunting "the lone regions where hath trod / No foot of man," and before it the only counsel is "commend thyself to God!" Death named is bearable; the unnamed is terror. Five years later the named silence became a refrain.

10.3 Script, cipher, hieroglyph

Writing is the vessel of speech, and Poe's texts are inscribed at their decisive moments. A tar-brush spells DISCOVERY on the sail of the ghost ship (Chapter 7). In "Silence—A Fable" (1838) a demon shows the narrator a rock beside a river in Libya on which the characters read DESOLATION; when the demon curses the land with silence, they read SILENCE, and the man upon the rock flees. The demon falls back into his tomb and laughs (Chapter 11). Script is the form in which a fate becomes visible.

"A Few Words on Secret Writing" (1841) states the analyst's faith: "human ingenuity cannot concoct a cipher which human ingenuity cannot resolve." Poe had invited readers of *Alexander's Weekly Messenger* (1839–40) to send him substitution ciphers and claimed to solve them all. Two ciphers published in *Graham's* in 1841 over the signature "W. B. Tyler," a name some scholars believe concealed Poe himself, outlived him; the second resisted solution until 2000. William F. Friedman, the founder of modern American cryptanalysis, traced his vocation to reading "The Gold-Bug" as a boy, and Shawn Rosenheim's *The Cryptographic Imagination* (1997) draws a line from Poe's ciphers to the information age.

"The Gold-Bug" (1843) is a fable of writing as a vessel within a vessel. Captain Kidd's cryptogram, in an ink that appears only under heat, shares a scrap of parchment with a death's-head, so that Legrand's sketch of a beetle seems, in his friend's hand, to have become a skull. The beetle is a scarab, the Egyptian emblem of Khepri, who rolls the sun across the sky as the dung beetle rolls its ball and so stands for the sun's daily return. The solution requires that the golden scarab be lowered on a string through the left eye of a skull nailed high in a tulip-tree; the first descent, through the wrong eye, misplaces the dig. The emblem of return must pass through the eye of death to locate the buried chest.

The Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym (1838) reads the earth itself as script. The chasms of the island of Tsalal, an appended note explains, have the shapes of an Ethiopian root meaning "to be shady" and an Arabic root meaning "to be white," and the marks on their walls form an Egyptian word for "the region of the south." The note ends in scripture: "I have graven it within the hills, and my vengeance upon the dust within the rock." Champollion's *Lettre à M. Dacier* (1822) had announced the decipherment of the hieroglyphs sixteen years before. John Irwin's *American Hieroglyphics* (1980) reads Pym's voyage as a quest for the

origin of writing and of the self, ending at a figure that is at once a shadow and a sign.

The world as text has a long ancestry. Galileo's *Il Saggiatore* (1623) declared the book of nature written in the language of mathematics, its characters triangles, circles, and other figures. Jakob Böhme's *De signatura rerum* (1622) held that every thing bears on its surface the signature of its inner nature. *Eureka* inherits both doctrines: the universe is "a plot of God," legible to an intelligence that grasps its consistency. Encipherment and decipherment are inverse operations. The poet composes backward from an effect and hides the design beneath the surface; the analyst reads backward from the surface to the design. Both belong to one combinatory art, Llull's art of turning wheels (Chapter 8).

The comic coda is "X-ing a Paragrab" (1849). A frontier editor answers a rival who mocks his fondness for the letter *o* with a paragraph crammed with it, and his printer, finding that every *o* has been stolen from the case, sets *x* in its place. The circle, the letter in the shape of the vortex and of the vessel's mouth, is missing, and the text becomes a field of crossings-out that the town cannot read.

10.4 Refrain and rhyme: the microphysics of return

"Verse originates in the human enjoyment of equality, fitness," Poe wrote in "The Rationale of Verse" (1848), and from that principle he derived rhythm, meter, rhyme, and stanza. Rhyme is the attraction of like sound to like; the refrain is periodic return. Poe's innovation, as he explained it in 1846, was to keep the refrain's sound constant while varying its application, so that each return carries a new meaning.

"The Raven" chose its word by acoustics: "the long o as the most sonorous vowel, in connection with r as the most producible consonant." The word is a paradox of the dinic law. "Nevermore" denies return, and it closes eleven consecutive stanzas. The negation of return is the most insistently returning word in American poetry.

Its speaker is "a non-reasoning creature capable of speech," perched on "a bust of Pallas," the bird of the dead on the head of wisdom. The bird means nothing by its word. The meaning is supplied by the lover, who, Poe explains, "experiences a phrenzied pleasure in so modeling his questions as to receive from the expected 'Nevermore' the most delicious because the most intolerable of sorrow." This is the Imp of the Perverse as hermeneutics (Chapter 6). Meaning is not in the word but in the fall of the interpreter toward it, and the speaking center is untenanted, like Prospero's intruder (Chapter 9). Only in the

poem's last line, Poe says, may the bird be seen as "emblematical of Mournful and Never-ending Remembrance." The poem ends in a perpetual present: the Raven "still is sitting, still is sitting," and the soul "from out that shadow that lies floating on the floor / Shall be lifted—nevermore!" Mallarmé translated the poem in 1875, in an edition illustrated by Manet.

"Eldorado" (1849), written in the year of the California gold rush, compresses the technique into four stanzas. The word *shadow* ends the third line of each, and each time its meaning shifts: light and shade on a knight's long journey, grief falling across his heart, a "pilgrim shadow" met on the road, and at last "the Valley of the Shadow" through which the golden land must be sought. One sound is drawn, stanza by stanza, toward death.

"The Bells" (1849) makes the vessel itself the instrument. A bell is an inverted cup that speaks when struck. The poem descends through four metals, silver sledge bells, golden wedding bells, brazen alarm bells, and iron funeral bells, in a declension that recalls the ages of the world in Hesiod and Ovid compressed into one life. Its last movement gives the bells to the dead. In the steeple dwell beings "neither man nor woman," "neither brute nor human": "They are Ghouls:— / And their king it is who tolls," keeping time "In a sort of Runic rhyme." Melody descends into moaning, and periodicity becomes an incantation performed by the dead.

The deepest statement of Poe's prosody is a description of death. In "The Colloquy of Monos and Una," whose epigraph is Sophocles' *Mellonta tauta* ("these things are in the future"), Monos recounts the dissolution of his senses after death. One faculty survives the rest: "a mental pendulous pulsation," "the moral embodiment of man's abstract idea of Time," by whose "absolute equalization" "had the cycles of the firmamental orbs themselves, been adjusted." With it he measures the irregularities of the clock on the mantel and of his attendants' watches, and every deviation from true proportion affects him "just as violations of abstract truth were wont, on earth, to affect the moral sense." The last sense of the dead is meter, and meter is the periodicity by which the planets keep their orbits. Pythagorean harmony (Chapter 1) returns as the residue of the soul. Prosody, for Poe, is the cosmic law of return felt from within.

10.5 The impossible utterance

Language reaches its limit when it speaks from the center. M. Valdemar, mesmerized at the moment of death, answers his questioner in a voice that seems to come "from a vast distance, or from some deep cavern within the

earth," and that strikes the ear "as gelatinous or glutinous matters impress the sense of touch": "I have been sleeping—and now—now—I am dead."

Two founding texts of French theory took this sentence as their object. *La Voix et le phénomène* (1967), whose epigraph is drawn from Baudelaire's translation of "Valdemar," argues that the pronoun *I* signifies without the living presence of a speaker, so that every "I am alive" already implies the possibility of "I am dead." This, Derrida writes, is not an extraordinary tale by Poe but the ordinary story of language, a pun on Baudelaire's title *Histoires extraordinaires*. Roland Barthes's "Analyse textuelle d'un conte d'Edgar Poe" (1973) treats the sentence as a scandal: an utterance that language cannot properly contain, in which the first person and death coincide. Blanchot's *L'Espace littéraire* (1955) had already described dying as interminable, an event without a subject in which one cannot die. Valdemar spends seven months in that state.

Poe built his corpus around such utterances. The manuscript in the bottle ends in the present tense as its ship goes down. *Pym* breaks off at the edge of the cataract, and an editorial note reports "the late sudden and distressing death of Mr. Pym" and the loss of his final chapters. "Mesmeric Revelation" (1844) closes by asking whether the dying Vankirk had been speaking "from out the region of the shadows." Monos and Una, Eiros and Charmion, Oinos and Agathos converse after death. The beheaded narrator of "A Predicament" and the breathless one of "Loss of Breath" keep talking (Chapter 11). The survivor of the Maelström testifies with hair turned white. Each is a voice from beyond the rim, and each is sealed in a vessel: a bottle, an editor's note, a frame.

The dinic reading generalizes Derrida's point. If every word is an impulse that outlasts its speaker, every word is already posthumous, already a voice from the center. Poe's impossible utterances are not exceptions to language. They are language seen at the end of its trajectory.

10.6 Conclusion

Poe's words obey the forces of *Eureka*. Speech disperses, as an impulse that never ends and a world spoken into birth. The name contains and annihilates. Script makes the cosmos a cryptogram that analysis reads backward. Rhyme and refrain return, and the last sense of the dead is meter. At the limit the word speaks from the center itself, in a sentence no living speaker could utter. Every word in this system crosses the Sea of Darkness sealed, and is opened only by a reader on the far shore.

CHAPTER

11

The Centrifugal Comedy

Hoax, Satire, and the Grotesque

More than a third of Poe's tales are comic: burlesques, satires, extravaganzas, and hoaxes. Criticism has treated them as lapses of taste, as hackwork, or, with G. R. Thompson (1973), as the key that reveals the Gothic tales to be ironic. This chapter proposes that they are the centrifugal phase of the dinic pulse. Horror stages convergence on the center; comedy stages dispersal from it. In the comic tales bodies come apart, souls are lost, sold, or eaten, clocks strike thirteen, balloons rise, and readers are deceived. Nearly every Gothic tale has a comic twin built on the same device with the sign of the force reversed. The long dispute between the metaphysical and the ironic Poe is a dispute between Attraction and Repulsion, and each side is right about one force.

11.1 Grotesque and arabesque: the title as emblem

The comic and the Gothic were born in one vessel. Poe's first collection, planned in 1833 as *Tales of the Folio Club*, framed its stories as readings at the monthly dinner of a club of pretentious literati, among them Mr. Snap, Mr. Convolvulus Gondola, De Rerum Naturâ, Esqr., Mr. Horribile Dictu, and Chronologos Chronology. "MS. Found in a Bottle," which won the Baltimore *Saturday Visiter* prize that year, was to be one of their tales. Alexander Hammond's reconstruction of the project (1972) and Thompson's ironic reading both begin here. The manuscript in the bottle was first placed inside a comedy.

The title of the collection of 1840, *Tales of the Grotesque and Arabesque*, names both forces. *Grotesque* derives from the *grotte*, the buried chambers of Nero's Golden House, excavated around 1480, whose painted hybrids, copied by Raphael's workshop in the Vatican Logge, gave the word its sense. The grotesque is an art of buried rooms: an art of the vessel. *Arabesque* names the interlacing, endlessly self-returning ornament of Islamic art, which Friedrich Schlegel called the oldest form of human fancy and which Kant cited, as foliage on wallpaper, among his examples of free beauty, form without concept (*Critique of Judgment* §16). The arabesque is an art of infinite return: an art of the vortex. Poe applied the first term roughly to his burlesques and the second to his tales of the ideal (Chapter 3). His title is the double emblem of this dissertation.

11.2 The body in pieces

The comic tales dismember. In "The Man That Was Used Up" (1839) the narrator seeks the secret of Brevet Brigadier General John A. B. C. Smith, hero of the "Bugaboo and Kickapoo campaign," a man of superb physique, and finds on the floor of his bedroom an "exceedingly odd looking bundle of something," which speaks to him. The general's valet, Pompey, assembles it: cork leg, arm, shoulders, bosom, wig, teeth, eye, and at last a palate, while the general names the maker of each part as it is fitted. Henri Bergson's *Le Rire* (1900) defined the comic as the mechanical encrusted on the living. Poe's general is that definition and its inverse: the living encrusted on the mechanical. The hero of a mock-Indian war is an assemblage, put together each morning by the hands of his Black servant (Chapter 16).

"Loss of Breath" (1832; revised 1835) gives the soul the same treatment. Mr. Lackobreath, berating his wife the morning after their wedding, loses his breath, and with it his standing among the living. Taken for a corpse, he is crushed in a stagecoach, sold to a surgeon for dissection, hanged in place of a criminal, and laid in a public vault, narrating throughout. In the vault he finds his neighbor Mr. Windenough, who has the missing breath. Breath is the oldest name of the soul (*pneuma*, *spiritus*, *ruach*, *ātman*); Poe makes it a commodity that can be lost, found, and bargained for.

"A Predicament" (1838), companion piece to "How to Write a Blackwood Article," is the comic twin of "The Pit and the Pendulum." Signora Psyche Zenobia climbs the steeple of a Gothic cathedral in Edinburgh, puts her head through an aperture that proves to be the face of the clock, and is caught by the minute hand, which she calls the scythe of Time. It descends, slowly, into her

neck. Her eyes start from their sockets and one rolls into the gutter; her head falls to the street; she goes on narrating without it. The Psyche of "To Helen" and "Ulalume" (Chapter 8) is beheaded by the periodic blade from which the prisoner of Toledo escapes. Mr. Blackwood's advice to Zenobia states Poe's own method as farce: should she ever be drowned or hanged, she must note her sensations, for they will be worth ten guineas a sheet.

"Never Bet the Devil Your Head" (1841), subtitled "A Tale with a Moral" in mockery of reviewers who demanded morals, gives perversity (Chapter 6) its farce. Toby Dammit habitually wagers his head; a little lame old gentleman in black takes him at his word; Dammit tries to leap a turnstile on a covered bridge and is decapitated by an iron bar he did not see. The narrator, left with the funeral bills, sells the body for dog's meat. Federico Fellini's *Toby Dammit* (1968) made the tale a fable of celebrity and self-destruction.

Two theorists of the grotesque frame these tales from opposite sides. Wolfgang Kayser's *Das Groteske* (1957) read the Romantic grotesque, Poe's prominently, as the estranged world, an encounter with a demonic power behind the familiar. Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965) objected that Kayser had lost the older carnival grotesque, in which the open, eating, dying body is renewed in the collective body of the people. Poe's comic bodies come apart without renewal, and in that respect Kayser is right. But they do not disclose an alien power. They disclose that the self was an aggregate all along, held together by force. Comedy shows the many inside the one; horror shows the one devouring the many.

11.3 Clocks, courts, asylums: the rim seizes the center

The second comic device inverts center and rim. "The Devil in the Belfry" (1839) describes the Dutch borough of Vondervotteimittiss, built in a perfectly circular valley, its sixty houses facing inward toward a steeple whose clock governs every life. A dandified stranger with a fiddle climbs the belfry and makes the clock strike thirteen. The town, a clock-face built of houses, is a vessel of perfect periodicity, and comedy enters as one irregular stroke. It is the comic twin of Prospero's ebony clock (Chapter 9) and of Monos's sense of perfect measure (Chapter 10).

"King Pest" (1835) is the comic twin of "The Masque of the Red Death." Two drunken sailors in plague-stricken London break into an undertaker's shop and find a court of grotesques drinking from skulls: King Pest the First, his queen,

and their kin, among them Duke Tem-Pest and the Arch Duchess Ana-Pest. The court of the plague includes a metrical foot.

"The System of Doctor Tarr and Professor Fether" (1845) carries the inversion into an asylum in the south of France, where the narrator dines with the staff and gradually realizes that the inmates have seized the institution and tarred and feathered the keepers, who are locked below. When the keepers break loose, they appear to him as apes. "Hop-Frog" (1849) ends the series in fire. A crippled dwarf, carried off from some barbarous region to serve as court jester, avenges an insult to Trippetta, his fellow captive, by costuming the king and his seven ministers as eight chained orangutans in tar and flax, hoisting them by the chain of the chandelier, and setting them alight. The court comedy ends with "a fetid, blackened, hideous, and indistinguishable mass."

These are Saturnalian plots, the world upside down of carnival and the Feast of Fools, in which the rim seizes the center. The recurrence of tar, feathers, flax, and apes is not incidental. In a slaveholding republic, keepers blackened by those they confined, and a captive who burns his master, could not be read innocently. Chapter 16 returns to these tales.

11.4 Souls as goods

The third device makes the soul a commodity. In "Bon-Bon" (1832; revised 1835) a philosopher-restaurateur of Rouen entertains the devil, who proves to be a gourmet of souls and discusses the flavors of philosophers he has eaten. In "The Duc de L'Omelette" (1832) a duke dies of disgust at an ill-served ortolan, wakes in hell, and wins back his soul at cards. These tales put into comic form the theology of *Eureka*'s marginal note, in which every intelligence absorbs every other (Chapter 5). The devil of "Bon-Bon" is the comic god of incorporation: the One as gourmand.

"The Angel of the Odd" (1844), an "extravaganza," gives contingency a body made of vessels. Its narrator, who scoffs at reports of improbable accidents, is visited by a being whose body is "a wine-pipe, or a rum-puncheon," whose legs are kegs, whose arms are bottles with the necks outward for hands, and whose head is a Hessian canteen topped with a funnel. The angel speaks in a thick German accent and presides over odd accidents, which promptly befall the narrator. Montresor lured Fortunato into the catacombs with "a pipe of what passes for Amontillado" (Chapter 9). In comedy the pipe is a god; in horror it is the bait of a tomb.

"Diddling Considered as One of the Exact Sciences" (1843) generalizes the commodity form into an anthropology: "Man is an animal that diddles, and there is no animal that diddles but man." The diddler, the swindler of small sums, requires minuteness, interest, perseverance, ingenuity, audacity, nonchalance, originality, impertinence, and a grin. He is the comic double of the analyst. Dupin wins at draughts by identifying himself with his opponent's mind (Chapter 7); the diddler profits by the same identification. Melville's *The Confidence-Man* (1857) gave the diddler his epic, and among its passengers is a haggard, inspired-looking beggar hawking a rhapsodical tract, whom many readers have taken for a caricature of Poe.

11.5 The hoax: the vessel turned outward

The hoax applies the poetics of effect to belief. Its effect is credence; its frame is a documentary form, the news report, the scientific memoir, the expedition journal; and its success, like a tale's, depends on the consistency of every detail with a pre-established design. "The Unparalleled Adventure of One Hans Pfaall" (1835) sends a Rotterdam bellows-mender to the moon in a balloon of dirty newspapers, after he blows up his creditors with a hidden cask of powder at the moment of ascent. Midway Pfaall wakes to find the earth above him and the moon below: his balloon has crossed the point where lunar attraction overcomes terrestrial, and his world has turned over. Comedy is a change of center. Two months later Richard Adams Locke's "Great Moon Hoax" in the New York *Sun* (August 1835) described bat-winged men on the moon and eclipsed Poe's tale; Poe believed he had been plagiarized. The genre in which he placed Pfaall runs from Lucian's *True History* (second century CE), which announces that its only truthful statement is that it lies, through Francis Godwin's *The Man in the Moone* (1638) and Cyrano de Bergerac's *États et Empires de la Lune* (1657).

"The Balloon-Hoax," printed as news in the *Sun* on 13 April 1844, reported a crossing of the Atlantic in seventy-five hours. "The Facts in the Case of M. Valdemar" (1845) was reissued in London in 1846 as a pamphlet presenting it as a true case of mesmerism arresting death. "Von Kempelen and His Discovery" (1849), which reported the transmutation of lead into gold, was meant, Poe told Evert Duyckinck, as an experiment in the verisimilar that might briefly check the gold fever. *The Journal of Julius Rodman* (1840) counterfeited the first crossing of the Rocky Mountains.

The hoax is the manuscript in the bottle turned outward. The bottled manuscript is a document its reader takes for a tale; the hoax is a tale its reader

takes for a document. Both are sealed vessels set adrift on a public sea, and both depend on the reader's ignorance of their origin. Neil Harris's *Humbug* (1973) identified in the age of P. T. Barnum an "operational aesthetic," in which audiences enjoyed being deceived and then working out how the deception was done. Poe's hoaxes and detective tales are the two halves of that aesthetic: the vessel sealed and the vessel opened. Barnum's career began in 1835, the year of Pfaall's balloon, with the exhibition of an enslaved woman, Joice Heth, advertised as George Washington's 161-year-old nurse. The American hoax was born on a Black body (Chapter 16).

Two late comedies turn the hoax against their century. In "Some Words with a Mummy" (1845) a voltaic pile revives Count Allamistakeo, who explains that Egyptian historians had themselves embalmed for centuries so that they could wake and correct the errors of later chroniclers; the narrator resolves to be embalmed for two hundred years to learn who will be president in 2045. The sarcophagus becomes a time machine. In "The Thousand-and-Second Tale of Scheherazade" (1845), under the epigraph "Truth is stranger than fiction," Scheherazade tells the king of the true marvels of nineteenth-century science, and he has her strangled for lying. Tzvetan Todorov observed of the *Nights* that narration equals life and the absence of narration death. Poe adds a corollary: the vessel of narration fails when it is filled with fact.

11.6 The comic twins

Most of Poe's Gothic tales have a comic counterpart built on the same device. The pairs are not parody and original; each is one configuration of force under two signs.

Shared device	Centripetal version (horror)	Centrifugal version (comedy)
The periodic blade	"The Pit and the Pendulum" (1842): the prisoner escapes	"A Predicament" (1838): the narrator is beheaded and keeps narrating
The clock at the center	"The Masque of the Red Death" (1842): the ebony clock tolls the end	"The Devil in the Belfry" (1839): the clock strikes thirteen
The plague court	"The Masque of the Red Death" (1842)	"King Pest" (1835)
Breath and burial	"The Premature Burial" (1844); "Valdemar" (1845)	"Loss of Breath" (1832)
The perverse wager	"The Imp of the Perverse" (1845)	"Never Bet the Devil Your Head" (1841)
The assembled body	"Valdemar" (1845): a body held together by trance	"The Man That Was Used Up" (1839): a body held together by prostheses

Shared device	Centripetal version (horror)	Centrifugal version (comedy)
Revivification	"Ligeia" (1838)	"Some Words with a Mummy" (1845)
The corpse that accuses	"The Tell-Tale Heart" (1843)	"Thou Art the Man" (1844)
Voyage to the limit	"MS. Found in a Bottle" (1833)	"Hans Pfaall" (1835)
The pipe of wine	"The Cask of Amontillado" (1846): bait for a tomb	"The Angel of the Odd" (1844): the body of a god

In every pair the horror tale moves inward, toward a center that closes over its victim, and the comic tale moves outward, toward dispersal, ejection, or an absurd second center. The device is constant; the sign of the force changes. Genre in Poe is a matter of vector.

11.7 Laughter as Repulsion

The demon of "Silence—A Fable" laughs. When his tale is done he falls back into the hollow of the tomb and laughs, and he curses the narrator because he cannot laugh with him. In "De l'essence du rire" (1855) Baudelaire began from a maxim of uncertain source, that the sage laughs only with trembling, and observed that the Word incarnate never laughed. Laughter, he argued, is satanic and therefore profoundly human: it is bound to the Fall, it springs from the laugher's sense of his own superiority, and it is the sign at once of infinite grandeur and infinite misery. He distinguished the "significative comic," an imitation, from the "absolute comic" of the grotesque, a creation. Poe's comic tales are of the second kind.

The dinic reading specifies Baudelaire's theology. Laughter is the affect of Repulsion: the self's assertion of its separateness from the fallen body it watches. Freud's *Jokes and Their Relation to the Unconscious* (1905) described laughter as the discharge of psychic energy that inhibition had held in reserve. In Poe's terms that energy is the force holding the self apart from the center, released for a moment in a convulsion. The comic is dispersal enjoyed.

"The Sphinx" (1846) shows how thin the line is. During the cholera epidemic in New York, the narrator, reading at a window in the country, sees a monster descend a distant hill, larger than any ship of the line. His host identifies it from a natural history: a death's-headed sphinx moth, crawling down a strand of spider web a sixteenth of an inch from the narrator's eye. The cosmic horror was an error of distance. The moth that flies to the star (Chapter 4) wears a skull on its back, and comedy is the discovery that the abyss was near and small.

The critical dispute runs along the same line. Thompson's ironic Poe, Clark Griffith's reading of "Ligeia" (1954) as a covert satire on German transcendentalism, and the hoaxing Poe of the newspapers all describe Repulsion: distance, irony, detachment. The metaphysical Poe of Wilbur and Hoffman describes Attraction. Each reading is correct about one force and wrong to take it for the whole. Romantic irony, the artist's sovereign detachment from his creation (Chapter 3), is Repulsion as method. Without it no one could look at the center and write.

11.8 The cosmos in a jug

The most serious book Poe wrote opens with a joke. *Eureka*'s satirical letter from the year 2848, "found corked in a bottle and floating on the *Mare Tenebrarum*," mocks the method of the treatise it introduces (Chapter 5). Poe reused it in "Mellonta Tauta" (1849), a letter written aboard the balloon *Skylark* on 1 April 2848 by one Pundita. Its future is a farce of misreading: archaeologists unearth the cornerstone of a monument to Washington and take Cornwallis for a dealer in corn, and the ancient Americans are remembered as a people who governed themselves until a despot named Mob seized power. At the end the balloon collapses toward the sea, and Pundita has just time to cork her letter for the waves. The comic vessel falls like the ghost ship of 1833. Repulsion delays return; it does not abolish it.

The structure is the dinic emblem in final form. The cosmology is the contents; the comedy is the jug. The vortex of the *Clouds*, the founding image of this study, also entered literature in a comedy, and Aristophanes' Strepsiades ended by taking a pot for a god. Poe's comedy is not the opposite of his metaphysics but its container, the only vessel, Poe seems to have judged, in which a theory of everything could be set afloat on the Sea of Darkness and reach a reader intact.

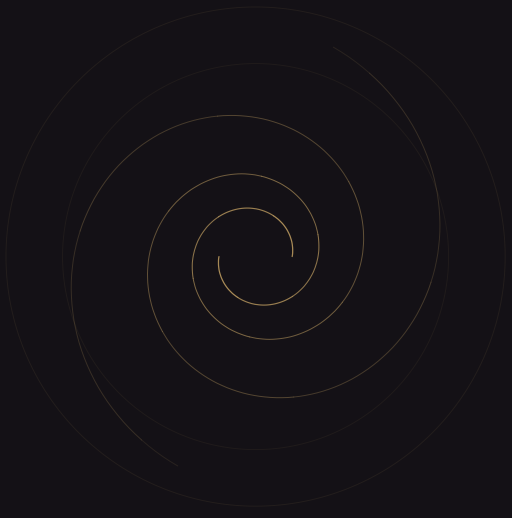
11.9 Conclusion

The comic tales are the diastole of Poe's system. Their bodies fly apart, their souls are sold and eaten, their centers are seized by the rim, their balloons escape the earth only to fall toward other centers, and their hoaxes float fictions into belief. Their laughter is the affect of Repulsion, as dread is the affect of Attraction. Read with the Gothic tales, they complete the pulse that *Eureka* describes, and they show what the horror conceals: that every self is a temporary

assembly held apart from the center by force, and that when the force is withdrawn, the general lies on the floor in a bundle.

PART THREE

Comparative Horizons



12 The Mythographer without Gods

13 Lineages of Dread

CHAPTER

12

The Mythographer without Gods

Poe and the Structures of Myth

Poe's corpus reproduces the deep structures of myth: a cosmos generated by a whirl, the descent to the underworld and the return, the dead who come back, the labyrinth with a monster at its center, the serpent that encircles the world, the end of the world by water and by fire. In every case Poe keeps the structure and removes the god. The center that myth fills with a deity Poe leaves untenanted, and the affect that Rudolf Otto called the numinous, the *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*, survives the removal of the numen. That surviving affect is the dinic compound of longing and dread. This chapter reads Poe as a mythographer without gods and argues that his corpus is, in Lévi-Strauss's sense, a single myth in many versions, whose contradiction is that union is annihilation and separate existence is exile.

12.1 The numinous without a numen

Rudolf Otto's *Das Heilige* (1917) described the experience of the holy as a mystery at once terrifying and fascinating. It is *tremendum*, an overpowering majesty before which the creature feels itself, in Abraham's words, dust and ashes; and it is *fascinans*, an attraction that draws the creature toward what overwhelms it. Its object is the "wholly other." Otto placed "daemonic dread" at the root of religious feeling and found its debased survival in the shudder of the ghost story, whose attraction, he suggested, lies in its being wholly other to the ordered world.

Poe's effect is Otto's numinous with the numen withdrawn. The Imp of the Perverse is fascination at the edge of the abyss (Chapter 6); the approach of the center against the will is the *tremendum* (Chapter 8); creature-feeling, the sense of one's own annihilation, pervades the vortex tales. But at the center there is no god: an empty costume in the abbey, an empty charnel in "Morella," a "non-reasoning" bird on the bust of Pallas. *Eureka* explains the absence. God has dispersed himself into the universe and now exists "solely in the diffused Matter and Spirit" of it (Chapter 5). The holy has not vanished; it has been distributed. What remains at the center is the place where it was.

Hans Blumenberg's *Arbeit am Mythos* (1979) describes the function of such stories. Myth, Blumenberg argued, is the work by which human beings reduce the "absolutism of reality," the overwhelming and unnamed power of the world, first by naming it and then by telling stories that hold it at a distance. Poe's "Sonnet—Silence" performs the first step: the silence that has a name, "No More," is "terrorless"; the nameless one is terror (Chapter 10). His tales perform the second, and then undo it. They name the power and tell its story, and the story ends by bringing the power back.

Poe's resistance to allegory has a mythological theory behind it. Coleridge, in "On the Prometheus of Aeschylus" (1825), called myth "tautegorical" rather than allegorical: it means what it says and does not stand for something else. Schelling adopted the word in his Berlin lectures on the philosophy of mythology and credited Coleridge with it. Poe's rule that meaning remain an undercurrent and his condemnation of Hawthorne's allegories (Chapter 4) are tautegorical in this sense. The House of Usher does not allegorize a mind. House and mind are one structure in two materials.

The Romantic generation knew that modern poetry lacked what myth had given the ancients. Friedrich Schlegel's "Rede über die Mythologie" (1800) named the lack in one word: modern poetry, he wrote, lacks a center (*Mittelpunkt*) such as mythology was for the ancients, and "we have no mythology." The fragment known as the "Oldest System-Programme of German Idealism" (1796–97) demanded a new mythology in the service of ideas, a "mythology of reason." *Eureka* is an American answer to both: a mythology built from physics, with gravitation for its theology and a center that is a state rather than a god.

12.2 The symbolism of the center

Mircea Eliade's *Le Mythe de l'éternel retour* (1949) opens with "the symbolism of the center." In archaic thought, temples, palaces, and cities stand at the center of the world, where the axis joining heaven, earth, and underworld passes. The center is the zone of the sacred and of absolute reality, and the road toward it is arduous, a labyrinth or a pilgrimage, because reaching it is a passage from the profane to the sacred. Mount Meru stands at the center of the Hindu and Buddhist cosmos beneath the pole star. At Delphi the omphalos marked the navel of the earth, where two eagles released by Zeus from its opposite ends had met.

Poe's topography is Eliade's with the sign reversed. His centers are reached by arduous roads: the thousand windings of Arnheim's gorge, the seven chambers of Prospero's suite, the catacombs beneath Montresor's palazzo, the labyrinthine school of William Wilson. Each is a zone of absolute reality, and each is lethal. Eliade's archaic man seeks the center to be saved by it; Poe's narrators are drawn there to be undone. The pole is an axis in Poe too, Mercator's black rock and Symmes's polar openings (Chapter 2), and the voyage toward it ends in a chasm and a white figure without a name (Chapter 16).

Eliade's second theme is time. Archaic societies, he argued, periodically abolish profane time by repeating the cosmogony in ritual, and so escape the "terror of history," the accumulation of irreversible suffering without meaning. *Eureka* restores this mythic time inside a scientific cosmology: a universe "swelling into existence, and then subsiding into nothingness, at every throb of the Heart Divine." The refrain is its ritual form (Chapter 10). But Poe's eternal return redeems nothing. Each cycle ends in Nothing, and each self becomes God only by absorbing every other. Poe preserved the shape of the sacred year and removed the renewal.

12.3 Churning, stirring, whirling

Myth knows the vortex as a creative power. In the Hindu account of the churning of the ocean (*samudra manthana*), told in the *Mahābhārata* and the Purāṇas, gods and demons wind the serpent Vasuki around Mount Mandara and churn the ocean of milk. The rotation yields both the nectar of immortality and a world-destroying poison, which Śiva drinks. In the *Kojiki* (712 CE), the primal pair Izanagi and Izanami stand on the floating bridge of heaven and stir the brine with a jeweled spear; the drops falling from its tip form the first island. Creation by rotation separates contraries, immortality from poison and land

from sea. Anaxagoras's *perichōrēsis* (Chapter 1) is the philosophical form of the same intuition.

The vortex also destroys. In the twelfth book of the *Odyssey*, Charybdis sucks down the black water three times a day and spews it out again. Odysseus, his ship lost, drifts back toward her on the wreckage; as she swallows it, he leaps up and clings to a fig tree above the whirl, waits out her swallowing, and drops onto his mast and keel when she casts them up. Poe's fisherman survives the Maelström by the same means, a vessel that the vortex returns (Chapter 7). The correspondence goes further. The Sirens and Charybdis are adjacent episodes of the same book, and Poe's two tales of 1841 divide the pair: "The Murders in the Rue Morgue" under the sign of the Sirens' song, "A Descent into the Maelström" under the sign of the whirlpool. The twin births of the detective and the vortex reenact the twelfth book of the *Odyssey*.

Myth gives the whirlpool a schedule, three swallowings a day, and Poe's tale turns on one. The Moskoe-ström falls slack at the turn of each tide, and the brothers cross it only in that interval. On the fatal day the narrator's watch has run down; the brothers mistake the hour, and the whirl is in full fury when they reach it. The vortex is periodic, and the failed clock delivers the vessel to it. The periodicity that governs the refrain and the pendulum (Chapters 9 and 10) here governs the sea.

12.4 Katabasis: descent and return

The descent to the underworld (*katabasis*) is the oldest plot of the dinic law. In the Sumerian *Descent of Inanna*, the goddess passes through seven gates into the realm of her sister Ereshkigal and surrenders a garment or ornament at each, until she arrives naked, is struck dead, and hangs as a corpse on a hook. Revived with the food and water of life, she may leave only by sending a substitute in her place. Seven gates and a progressive stripping: the Hermetic ascent through seven spheres and Prospero's pursuit through seven chambers (Chapter 9) are the same structure, read upward and downward.

Gilgamesh, seeking the secret of life, passes through twelve double-hours of darkness under the mountain Mashu and crosses the waters of death to Utnapishtim, the survivor of the flood; he wins the plant of rejuvenation and loses it to a snake. Jonah, cast into the sea, prays from the belly of the fish: "Out of the belly of hell cried I... For thou hadst cast me into the deep, in the midst of the seas; and the floods compassed me about" (Jonah 2:2–3). Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949) made "the belly of the whale" the

threshold stage of the hero's journey. Pym begins his voyage stowed in an iron-bound box in the hold of a ship called the *Grampus*, and a grampus is a kind of whale (Chapter 9).

Dante's *Inferno* gives the descent the shape of a funnel narrowing toward the center of the earth, where Satan stands frozen in the ice of Cocytus. Climbing down his body, Virgil turns head over heels at the hips, and Dante, emerging on the other side, sees Lucifer upside down; Virgil explains that they have passed "the point to which all weights are drawn from every side" (XXXIV.110–111). Dante's universe has two centers: the point of light around which the angels whirl in *Paradiso* XXVIII (Chapter 5), and the center of gravity, which is the place of greatest sin. Poe's cosmos has one. In *Eureka* the center of gravity is Unity, and Unity is God. Poe merged Dante's two centers, and with them the Fall and the Return (Chapter 6). The reversal at Dante's center also has its comic double. Hans Pfaall wakes to find the earth above him and the moon below as his balloon passes the point where one attraction yields to another (Chapter 11). Dante's *Commedia* and Poe's comedy turn over at the same place.

The classical katabasis ends in return with knowledge: Odysseus from the land of the dead, Aeneas through the gate of ivory, Dante emerging to see the stars again. Poe's descents rarely return. When they do, the returner is marked, his hair turned white, or saved by an arm that reaches in from outside (Chapter 9). And no god presides below. Ereshkigal, Hades, and Satan rule their underworlds; Poe's have only a tarn closing over a house, a pit at the center of a cell, an empty mask.

12.5 The dead who return

Chapter 8 read Poe's returning women against Orpheus and Alcestis. A third myth fits more closely than either. In the *Kojiki*, Izanami dies giving birth to the god of fire and descends to Yomi, the land of the dead. Izanagi follows to bring her back. She has eaten the food of Yomi but agrees to ask its gods for leave, on condition that he not look at her. He breaks a tooth from his comb, lights it, and sees her body swarming with maggots and thunder deities. He flees; shamed, she pursues him with the hags of Yomi; he seals the pass between the worlds with a boulder. Across the stone she vows to kill a thousand of his people each day, and he answers that he will cause fifteen hundred to be born.

This is the insurgent center in its purest mythic form. The husband's light, like Psyche's lamp in "To Helen" (Chapter 8), reveals the dead wife's decay and turns her from a beloved into a pursuer. Her return is not a resurrection but an

assault, and order is restored only by sealing a vessel, the stone across the pass, and by an exchange of deaths for births. Ligeia's return through Rowena's body obeys the same arithmetic.

Inanna's descent states that arithmetic as law: the dead may return only if someone takes their place. Inanna, coming up, finds her husband Dumuzi sitting richly dressed on his throne, unmourning, and gives him to the demons in her stead. Alcestis died as Admetus's substitute. In Poe, Rowena dies so that Ligeia may live, Morella's daughter dies of the name that brings her mother back, and Madeline, returning, carries her brother down with her. Return from the center requires that a vessel be emptied for it.

One more myth joins return to laughter. In the Māori cycle recorded by George Grey (1855), the hero Māui seeks to win immortality for humankind by entering the body of Hine-nui-te-pō, the goddess of night and death, while she sleeps, reversing the path of birth. He warns the birds not to laugh. The fantail laughs; the goddess wakes and crushes him. Laughter, the affect of Repulsion (Chapter 11), interrupts the return to the source, and the hero dies on the threshold of the body that gave him life.

12.6 The labyrinth and its monster

The Cretan labyrinth is the archetype of the road to a center with a monster at its heart, and "The Murders in the Rue Morgue" is its modern version. The crime lies in a room locked from within, high in a house on the Rue Morgue, the street of the morgue. At its center is a hybrid: an orangutan that has escaped its master after watching him shave through the keyhole and attempting to imitate him with a razor. Half beast and half mimic of a man, it is a Minotaur. Dupin, like Theseus, follows a thread. At the foot of the lightning-rod he finds a scrap of ribbon "tied in one of those peculiar knots which few besides sailors can tie, and which is peculiar to the Maltese," and it leads him to the sailor who brought the beast from Borneo. Ariadne's thread is a knotted ribbon.

Plutarch reports that Theseus, on his way home, led at Delos a dance imitating the windings of the labyrinth (*Theseus* 21). Prospero's masquers move through seven chambers "so irregularly disposed that the vision embraced but little more than one at a time," and each chime of the ebony clock halts "their evolutions" (Chapter 9). The masque is a labyrinth dance with the Red Death at its center. Borges, Poe's most attentive twentieth-century reader, gave the Minotaur a voice in "La casa de Asterión" (1947), where the monster waits for a

redeemer and scarcely defends himself against Theseus's sword. Poe's centers wait in the same way.

12.7 The serpent at the circumference

The serpent biting its tail, the ouroboros, encircles the world in many traditions. In the Greek alchemical manuscript known as the *Chrysopoeia of Cleopatra*, it encloses the words *hen to pan*, "the All is One," the thesis of *Eureka* in a single emblem. In Norse cosmology Jörmungandr, the Midgard Serpent, lies in the ocean around the world with its tail in its mouth; at Ragnarök it rises, and Thor kills it and dies of its venom. Leviathan, "the piercing serpent... that crooked serpent" (Isaiah 27:1), is the biblical version, the chaos in the sea that God will slay at the end of days.

Poe's serpents hold the same position. Montresor's arms show a foot crushing a serpent whose fangs are embedded in the heel (Chapter 9). Ligeia's dying poem ends with "a blood-red thing that writhes from out / The scenic solitude," before which the mimes "become its food": the Conqueror Worm, the serpent of the end, consuming the play of the world. The ouroboros is usually read as an emblem of eternal renewal, the circle that returns into itself. Poe's version is the ouroboros carried to completion, a serpent that goes on swallowing until nothing remains outside it. That is the theology of *Eureka*'s marginal note, in which each intelligence absorbs every other until "each must become God" (Chapter 5).

12.8 Water and fire

Myth ends the world in two ways, by flood and by fire, and Seneca's *Natural Questions* (III.27–30) weighs both. Poe used both. Water closes over the House of Usher and the ghost ship of 1833. Fire consumes the world in "The Conversation of Eiros and Charmion," when a comet strips the atmosphere of its nitrogen and the remaining oxygen bursts into flame, and it consumes the palace of "Metzengerstein" (1832) and the court of "Hop-Frog." The *Völuspá* describes the end in the same double register: the sun turns black, the earth sinks into the sea, the bright stars fall, and then the earth rises again from the waters, green. The Stoic conflagration and the Purāṇic dissolution (Chapter 1) also return. Poe's ends do not. The tarn closes "sullenly and silently"; Eiros and Charmion speak of the world's end from beyond it, but no green earth rises. *Eureka* promises renewal only at the scale of universes, where no self survives to see it.

12.9 One myth in many versions

Claude Lévi-Strauss's "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955) proposed that a myth consists of all its versions, Freud's reading of Oedipus included, and that its purpose is to provide a logical model for overcoming a contradiction that cannot be resolved in fact. In the *Mythologiques* he showed that myths transform one another by systematic inversion. Poe's corpus answers to both claims. It is one myth told in many versions, and its contradiction is that the longing for union can be fulfilled only by the annihilation of the one who longs. The vessel is its mediator, the device that lets the self approach the center and survive. The comic twins of Chapter 11 are its transformations by inversion.

Georges Bataille's *L'Érotisme* (1957) gives the contradiction its modern philosophical statement. Human beings, Bataille argued, are discontinuous beings, separated from one another by an abyss and haunted by nostalgia for a lost continuity; eroticism, sacrifice, and death open the discontinuous being onto that continuity. Eroticism, in his formula, is assenting to life up to the point of death. Bataille called his project an atheology, a thinking of the sacred without God. Poe had written one a century earlier. *Eureka*'s Repulsion is Bataille's discontinuity; its Attraction is the nostalgia for continuity; its Unity is the continuity that death restores.

Poe is therefore a mythographer without gods. He kept myth's structures, the center and the road to it, the descent, the return, the substitute, the serpent, the flood and the fire, and he kept its affect, the compound of terror and fascination. He removed only the presence at the center. What myth had sealed with a god he left open, and the opening became the space of modern horror.

CHAPTER

13

Lineages of Dread

Poe in the Comparative History of Horror

Modern horror descends from Poe along two lines, divided by the question of what occupies the center. Chapter 5 showed that *Eureka* imagined the end of the world as a total gathering a few years before thermodynamics imagined it as a total dispersal. Once the gathering lost its physics, the center could survive in only two places. It could move inside the self, *Eureka*'s "It is our own" taken literally, so that the abyss is the mind and horror becomes psychological. Or it could move outside every self, the One replaced by an indifferent cosmos or a mindless god, so that the abyss is alien and horror becomes cosmic. This study calls the first lineage auto-theistic and the second xeno-theistic. Both inherit Poe's vessel, and a third tradition, the horror of transmission, inherits the vessel alone.

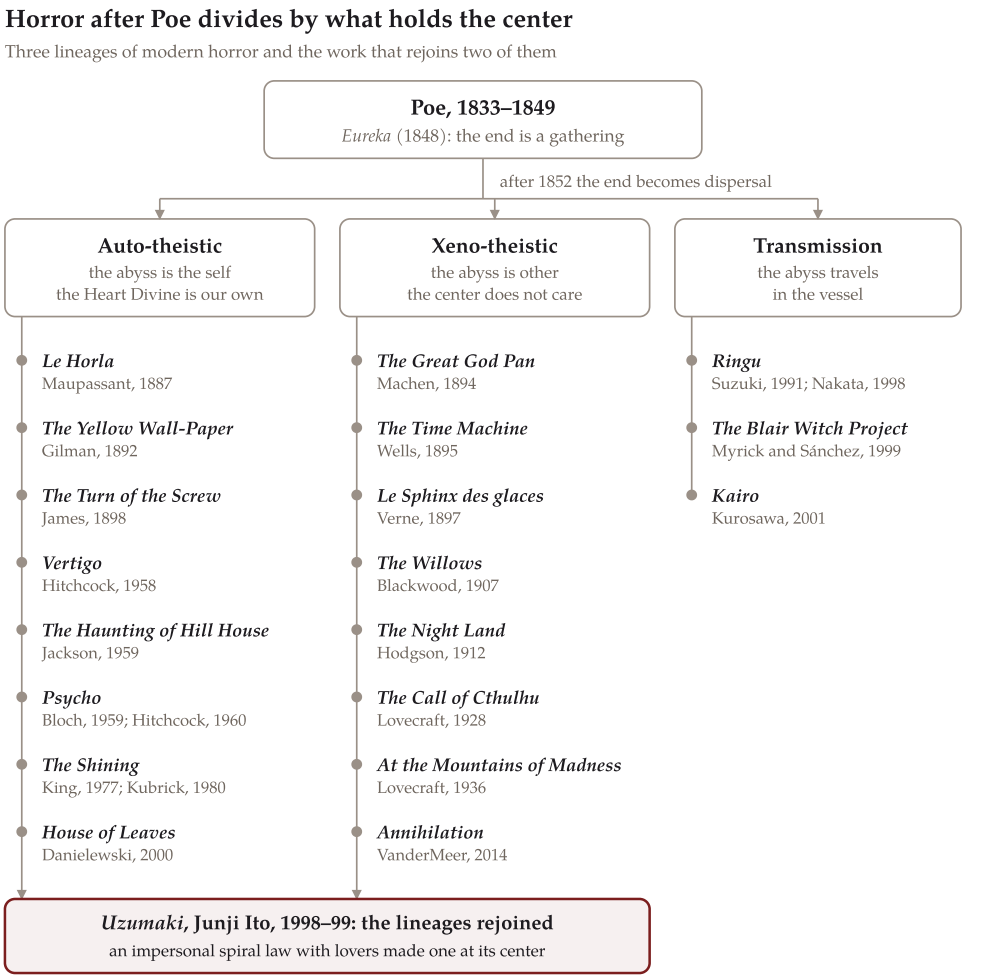


Figure 1 *Three lineages of horror after Poe, 1887–2014*

Read each lineage downward in order of publication. Ito's Uzumaki *(1998–99) sits beneath the first two as their structural rejoining, not their chronological end; the horror of transmission runs apart.*

13.1 The widening gyre

The twentieth century's most famous image of history is Poe's vortex reversed. "Turning and turning in the widening gyre / The falcon cannot hear the falconer; / Things fall apart; the centre cannot hold," Yeats wrote in "The Second Coming" (1920), and his *A Vision* (1925) built a cosmology of interpenetrating gyres. Yeats had dismissed "The Raven" in 1899 as a commonplace subject executed by a rhythmical trick. His gyre is nonetheless the dinic figure turned outward. Poe's spiral narrows toward a center that draws everything in; Yeats's widens until

the center loses its hold. Between them lies the passage from a gravitational to an entropic imagination, and the history of horror after Poe takes place in that passage.

13.2 Contemporaries: the coffin that floats

Poe's contemporaries shared the dinic structures without his system. Hawthorne's "The Minister's Black Veil" (1836) seals a man's face behind crape for life. Reviewing it in 1842, Poe suggested that only congenial minds would perceive its insinuated meaning: a crime of dark dye involving the young lady whose funeral the minister conducts. Poe read Hawthorne's veil as concealing his own subject, the dead young woman. Gogol's "Viy" (1835) encloses a seminarian in a chalk circle for three nights of prayer over the corpse of a beautiful witch, who rises from her coffin and flies around the church in it. On the third night the monsters bring Viy, whose eyelids reach to the ground; when they are lifted, the seminarian looks back and dies. The circle holds against everything except the gaze.

Melville's *Moby-Dick* (1851) ends in Poe's double emblem. The *Pequod* sinks, and "concentric circles" seize the last boat and carry it "round and round in one vortex." Ishmael, thrown clear, drifts toward the closing vortex and revolves in it "like another Ixion," the king bound forever to a turning wheel, until at its vital center a black bubble bursts upward and releases Queequeg's coffin, which the ship's carpenter had caulked into a life-buoy. "Buoyed up by that coffin," he floats for a day and a night until the *Rachel* finds him. The coffin that rises from the center of the whirlpool is the Maelström's cask and Wyatt's oblong box in one object (Chapter 9). Melville's survivor is saved by a vessel made for the dead.

13.3 The French Poe

Baudelaire translated Poe from 1848 until 1865, and through him Poe became a founder of French modernity. Odilon Redon's album of lithographs *À Edgar Poe* (1882) opens with an emblem of the whole corpus: an eye, rising like a strange balloon toward the infinite. The old man's eye in "The Tell-Tale Heart," Hans Pfaall's balloon, and the moth's ascent toward the star are one image. Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's "La Torture par l'espérance" (1883) rewrites "The Pit and the Pendulum" without Lasalle. A prisoner of the Inquisition at Saragossa finds his cell unlocked, creeps through the corridors, and reaches a garden under the

night sky, where he falls into the arms of the Grand Inquisitor, who asks why, on the eve perhaps of salvation, he would leave them. Hope was the last torment. Villiers' *L'Ève future* (1886) has Thomas Edison build an android, Hadaly, to hold the beauty of a living woman without her vulgar soul, a synthesis of "The Oval Portrait" and "The Man That Was Used Up"; shipped to England in a coffin-like case, Hadaly is lost when her steamer burns and sinks, as Wyatt's oblong box was lost. Huysmans's Des Esseintes, sealed in his villa at Fontenay in *À rebours* (1884), admires Poe's analyses of the will and its maladies; his villa is "The Philosophy of Furniture" made into a life.

Film took up the French inheritance early. Jean Epstein's *La Chute de la maison Usher* (1928), with Luis Buñuel as assistant, made Madeline Roderick's wife and had him paint her portrait, which drains her life as he works: "Usher" and "The Oval Portrait" fused into one film. Adaptation behaves as Lévi-Strauss said versions of a myth behave (Chapter 12). Roger Corman's cycle for American International Pictures (1960–64) carried the fusion further. *The Haunted Palace* (1963) took its title from Roderick Usher's poem and its plot from Lovecraft's *The Case of Charles Dexter Ward*, and *The Raven* (1963) was a comedy, the comic twin restored. Jan Švankmajer's *Kyvadlo, jáma a naděje* (*The Pendulum, the Pit and Hope*, 1983) joined Poe's tale to Villiers', so that the prisoner escapes the blade only to meet the Inquisitor.

13.4 The auto-theistic lineage: the abyss is the self

The first lineage takes *Eureka*'s last sentence literally: the Heart Divine is our own. Dostoevsky's doubles and confessions, Stevenson's Jekyll, and Wilde's Dorian Gray carried the structure through the nineteenth century (Chapter 6). Maupassant's "Le Horla" (1887) gives it a vessel. The diarist finds his carafe emptied each night, sets out water, milk, wine, bread, and strawberries as a test, and learns that an invisible being drinks only the water and the milk. Standing before his mirror, he cannot see himself, because the invisible thing stands between him and the glass: the reverse of William Wilson's mirror, where the double appears in the place of the self. He locks the creature in his room and burns his house, with his servants in it, then concludes that the Horla is not dead and that he must kill himself.

Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wall-Paper" (1892) gives the lineage a woman's voice and the arabesque its revenge. Confined by her physician husband to a nursery with barred windows, the narrator studies a wallpaper whose "lame uncertain curves" suddenly "commit suicide," and discovers a

woman creeping behind the pattern. By the end she has torn the paper away and become that woman: "I've got out at last," she tells her husband, who faints, and over whom she creeps. Poe's dead woman, sealed inside the design, here narrates her own escape from it. The insurgent center (Chapter 8) acquires a voice.

Henry James's *The Turn of the Screw* (1898) supplies the lineage's characteristic ambiguity, and its title names a spiral. A manuscript written by a governess dead these twenty years is read aloud by the fire: Poe's bottled document domesticated. Whether the ghosts of Quint and Miss Jessel are real or the governess's projections, as Edmund Wilson argued in 1934, the tale cannot settle, and that undecidability is the auto-theistic premise: the abyss might be the self. Its last sentence returns to Poe's organ. The boy Miles dies in the governess's arms, "and his little heart, dispossessed, had stopped."

Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) theorized the lineage as the return of the repressed, and Hitchcock filmed it. Hitchcock said in 1960 that Poe's tales had shaped his work. *Vertigo* (1958), adapted from Boileau and Narcejac's novel *D'entre les morts* ("from among the dead"), is the dinic film. Its titles are spirals; its hero suffers from vertigo, the Imp's sickness at the edge; its heroine sits before the portrait of a dead woman whose spiral coiffure she wears; and its second half shows a man remaking a living woman, hair, suit, and all, into the form of a dead one. That is "The Oval Portrait" run backward and the Lullian motto (Chapter 8) turned into compulsion: preserve the specific form, and the soul may return. *Psycho* (1960) keeps a dead mother in the fruit cellar of a house on a hill and lets her speak through her son. Its source novel's author, Robert Bloch, had begun as a teenage correspondent of Lovecraft, who killed off a character modeled on Bloch in "The Haunter of the Dark" (1936). The two lineages meet in the writer who turned Lovecraft's abyss inward.

Shirley Jackson's *The Haunting of Hill House* (1959) ends with the perverse plunge. Eleanor, sent away from the house that has claimed her, drives into a tree at its gate, thinking in the last second, "Why am I doing this?" Stanley Kubrick's *The Shining* (1980), from Stephen King's novel, seals a family for a winter in an empty hotel, makes a sentence typed over hundreds of pages its refrain of madness, freezes its villain at the center of a hedge maze, like Dante's Satan in the ice of Cocytus, and ends on a photograph of 1921 in which he has "always" been present. Mark Z. Danielewski's *House of Leaves* (2000) literalizes Wilbur's reading of Usher (Introduction). A house measures larger inside than out; a hallway opens onto a darkness in which a spiral staircase descends beyond

measure; the account of it is a manuscript left by a dead man and found by another, set in spirals and inversions of type, with every reference to the Minotaur struck through. Its companion album, *Haunted* (2000), was recorded by Danielewski's sister, who performs under the name Poe.

13.5 The xeno-theistic lineage: the abyss is other

The second lineage keeps the abyss and gives it away. Jules Verne, who published an essay on Poe in 1864, completed *Pym* in *Le Sphinx des glaces* (1897), in which an expedition finds near the pole a mountain of magnetic rock, with Pym's corpse fixed to it by the iron of his rifle. Verne made Poe's center literal: attraction became magnetism, and the white figure became a geological fact. H. G. Wells sent his Time Traveller to a beach thirty million years hence, under a swollen red sun, where a black tentacled thing moves in the shallows of a dying world (*The Time Machine*, 1895), and in "The Star" (1897) he retold "Eiros and Charmion" with a coda from Martian astronomers, for whom the earth's catastrophe is a minor event. The universe after thermodynamics ends by running down, and it does not notice.

Arthur Machen's "The Great God Pan" (1894) gives the return to origin a biology. A surgeon operates on a young woman's brain so that she may "see the god Pan," and the daughter she bears becomes a woman whose death a witness describes as a regression through every form of life: the body wavers from sex to sex, descends to the beasts, and goes down at last "even to the abyss of all being." Valdemar's liquefaction (Chapter 9) becomes a reverse evolution, a return to the primal unity of life. Algernon Blackwood's "The Willows" (1907), which Lovecraft placed first among weird tales, strands two travellers on a Danube island where the presence of another order of being is announced by small funnel-shaped hollows forming in the sand. William Hope Hodgson's *The House on the Borderland* (1908) sets a house above a pit and lets its recluse watch the sun die in an accelerated future; *The Night Land* (1912) imagines the last humans in a metal pyramid, the Last Redoubt, on an earth whose sun has gone out, besieged by watching powers. The Redoubt is the last vessel in an entropic cosmos.

H. P. Lovecraft made the lineage a doctrine. "Supernatural Horror in Literature" (1927) begins by declaring fear of the unknown the oldest and strongest kind of fear and devotes a chapter to Poe as the founder of the modern horror tale. Lovecraft's "cosmic indifferentism" holds that the universe neither loves nor hates humanity, and its consequence for Poe's system is precise. "The

Call of Cthulhu" (1928) opens by calling it merciful that the human mind cannot correlate all its contents, since the piecing together of dissociated knowledge will one day open terrifying vistas of reality. Dupin's art of correlation saved its practitioner (Chapter 7); Lovecraft's correlation drives him mad. The Odyssean knot has been cut. *At the Mountains of Madness* (1936) sends an Antarctic expedition after Pym and ends with a survivor screaming Pym's cry, "Tekeli-li!" And "at the center of all infinity" sits Azathoth, the blind idiot god, amid the beating of drums and the piping of flutes, while lesser gods dance around him. This is Prospero's masque with the Red Death replaced by a mindless sovereign, and the drumbeat at the center of infinity is *Eureka*'s Heart Divine with its last sentence removed. The heart at the center is not our own.

The lineage continues in philosophy and fiction. Thomas Ligotti's *The Conspiracy against the Human Race* (2010) presents consciousness as a curse and human beings as puppets, the "mere puppets" of "The Conqueror Worm," who come and go at the bidding of "vast formless things." Jeff VanderMeer's *Annihilation* (2014) sends an expedition into a zone where a structure the biologist insists on calling a tower descends into the earth, its walls inscribed with a living script that a creature below writes without end. The biologist's insistence restates Heraclitus (Chapter 1), for whom the way up and the way down are one, and the script on the walls is Pym's hieroglyphic chasm (Chapter 10). The novel's title names the destination of the dinic law.

13.6 The horror of transmission

The vessel has a lineage of its own. The manuscript in the bottle became the found document of Lovecraft's narrators and then the found footage of *The Blair Witch Project* (1999), which ends in a cellar where a man stands facing a corner. Suzuki Kōji's novel *Ringu* (1991) and Nakata Hideo's film (1998) invert the bottled message. A videotape kills whoever watches it within seven days unless the viewer copies it and shows it to someone else. Poe's manuscript was addressed to whoever might find it; in *Ringu* the finder survives only by becoming a sender. At the source of the curse lies a well, and in the film the dead girl Sadako climbs out of it, through the television screen, into the room. The center crosses the frame of the vessel, as Madeline "stands without the door." Kurosawa Kiyoshi's *Kairo* (2001) carries the dead into the computer network, through rooms sealed with red tape.

These works complete a logic that "The Balloon-Hoax" began (Chapter 11). The vessel no longer carries a message across the abyss. It carries the abyss itself,

and every reader becomes its carrier.

13.7 Uzumaki: the lineages rejoined

One modern work restates the dinic law whole. Junji Ito's *Uzumaki* (1998–99) is set in Kurôzu-chō, a name meaning "black vortex town," where spirals infect everything: a man's obsession, a schoolgirl's hair, a potter's kiln, the smoke of the crematorium, a whirlwind, the bodies of the townspeople themselves. The town's row houses turn out to form a single spiral, and at its center, beneath the town, lies an ancient spiral city full of entwined bodies. The heroine and her lover descend to the center and are drawn into one another, and the curse ends at the moment it begins, to recur whenever a town is built on the site.

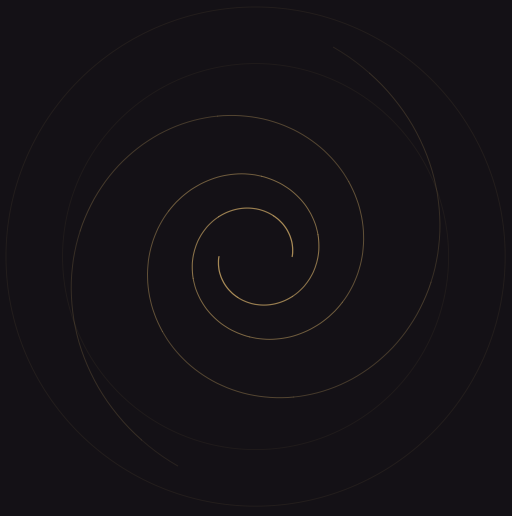
Uzumaki joins what horror after Poe divided. Its spiral is an impersonal law, indifferent and contagious, as in the xeno-theistic lineage. Its center is erotic union, two bodies becoming one, as in Aristophanes' myth and *Eureka*'s nostalgia (Chapter 5). Its time is eternal return. Ito's "The Enigma of Amigara Fault" (2002) distills the auto-theistic half into a parable. An earthquake exposes a mountainside riddled with human-shaped holes; each visitor finds the one made in his or her own shape and feels compelled to enter it. The hole is the perfect vessel, and the compulsion to enter it is the Imp of the Perverse (Chapter 6).

13.8 Conclusion

Poe is not merely an ancestor of modern horror. He is its point of divergence. His system held together what his successors separated: the center as self and the center as other, the abyss as longing and the abyss as indifference, the vessel as rescue and the vessel as contagion. Thermodynamics broke the gathering apart, and horror inherited the pieces. The auto-theistic lineage found the abyss in the mind, the xeno-theistic in a cosmos that does not care, and the horror of transmission in the vessel itself. Each lineage keeps one face of the dinic law and loses the other. Read together, they reconstitute the system from which they came.

PART FOUR

Synthesis and Critique



14 Twelve Theses toward a Unified Field Theory of Poe

15 The Odyssean Binding

16 The White Center

CHAPTER

14

Twelve Theses toward a Unified Field Theory of Poe

A unified field theory, in physics, seeks one framework from which apparently distinct forces follow as special cases. The preceding chapters have assembled the materials for such a theory of Poe. Its claim is that his apparently incompatible modes, lyric and Gothic tale, confession and detection, comedy and hoax, colloquy of the dead, landscape fantasy, and cosmology, follow from one law and two forces in different configurations, distinguished by a single further variable: whether the vessel holds. This chapter states the theory in twelve theses, maps its field, answers four objections, and tests it on a text the preceding chapters did not read.

14.1 The theses

I. The dinic law. Poe's corpus is generated by a single dynamics, formalized in *Eureka* and operative from 1833: whatever has been differentiated tends to return to an originary unity, and that return, registered by an individual consciousness, is an indissoluble compound of longing and dread. The law is not a theme that some texts share but a grammar that every text instantiates. Its two forces, Attraction and Repulsion, and its two emblems, the vortex and the vessel, recur across every genre Poe practised because every genre is one of their configurations.

II. Gravitation is nostalgia. *Eureka* supplies the cause that Newton declined to frame. Each atom tends not toward another atom but toward Unity, and the inverse-square law is the geometric trace of the original diffusion. The force that holds the universe together is homesickness, Hofer's malady universalized, and Platonic recollection is extended from the soul to matter (Chapters 2 and 5).

III. Perversity is gravitation felt from within. The Imp of the Perverse is the cosmic pull as experienced by a being whose law of life is Repulsion, and it is felt as a desire to fall. Because the center toward which the soul falls is Unity, and Unity is God, Poe abolishes the distinction between the Fall and the Return. Sin and salvation are one motion seen from two positions (Chapter 6).

IV. Affect is position. The emotions of Poe's art are coordinates in the field. Beauty is the song of the center heard at a distance; melancholy is the affect of orbit, the state of a body that perceives its attractor and cannot reach it; terror is the vertigo of the rim; horror is the center's approach against the will; laughter is Repulsion released. Poe's aesthetic is a topology of feeling (Chapters 3, 4, 8, and 11).

V. Form is the vessel. Unity of effect, the single sitting, composition from the end, the close circumscription of space, and the refrain together make a technology of containment, which lets a reader approach the center without being annihilated by it. The creed of that technology is the Lullian motto of "Eleonora": under the preservation of the specific form, the soul is safe (Chapters 4 and 8).

VI. Every vessel is breached from within, and every center is untenanted. Poe's walls move inward, because concentration is approach. His vessels fail from inside, because they hold the destiny they were built to exclude. His centers, once reached, are empty. He keeps the structures of myth and removes the god: he is a mythographer without gods, and the empty center is his signature (Chapters 9 and 12).

VII. Ratiocination is the Odyssean knot. The detective hears the center's song from the rim and survives by binding himself to a vessel, whether a cask, a method, or a genre. The detective tale and the vortex tale were born together in 1841 because they divide one episode of myth between them, the Sirens and Charybdis of the twelfth book of the *Odyssey* (Chapters 7 and 12).

VIII. The center is insurgent. The beautiful dead woman whom the poetics enthrones as a passive center does not remain there. She returns, and her return repeats the One's first act of diffusion in a single body. The return runs both ways, and its meeting with the lover's fall is what Poe's tales call horror. Myth adds a law of exchange: whatever returns from the center requires a substitute (Chapters 8 and 12).

IX. Words are forces, and every word is posthumous. A word is an impulse that outlasts its speaker; a name is a vessel that summons and annihilates; script turns the cosmos into a cipher; the refrain is the microphysics of return; and the last sense of the dead is meter. "I am dead" is not an exception to language but language seen at the end of its trajectory (Chapter 10).

X. Genre is vector. Comedy is the centrifugal phase of the pulse and horror its centripetal phase, and nearly every Gothic tale has a comic twin built on the same device. Irony is Repulsion as method. The long dispute between the metaphysical and the ironic Poe is a dispute between Attraction and Repulsion, and each party is right about one force (Chapter 11).

XI. Theodicy collapses into confession. *Eureka*'s Heart Divine "is our own," and it is the heart beneath the floor. Since each soul is in part its own God, each is the author of all suffering, its own included. "Thou art the man" and *tat tvam asi* are one sentence, spoken by the absolute as revelation and by a corpse in a wine case as indictment (Chapters 5 and 6).

XII. The field contains its readers and its heirs. The major interpretations of Poe are positions inside his field rather than instruments applied to it. Lacan's letter that always arrives is Attraction; Derrida's letter that may never arrive is Repulsion; Barbara Johnson describes their tension. Bonaparte names the insurgent center a mother; Tate and Wilbur read the vessel; Thompson reads Repulsion. Modern horror is the same field divided, its auto-theistic and xeno-theistic lineages each inheriting one face of the center (Chapters 7, 8, 11, and 13).

14.2 The field

Read across Poe's modes, the theses yield a map. Each mode is a configuration of the two forces, distinguished by the state of the vessel.

Mode	Configuration of force	State of the vessel	Affect	Emblem	Representative texts
Lyric	Attraction at a distance: a stable orbit	Holds (stanza, refrain)	Melancholy	Moth and star	"To Helen," "The Raven," "Ulalume"
Gothic tale	Attraction against the will: capture	Breached from within	Dread, then horror	Vortex, tomb	"Usher," "Ligeia," "The Pit and the Pendulum"
Confession	Attraction within the self: the fall	Ruptured by speech	Perverse delight	Precipice, floorboards	"The Imp of the Perverse," "The Tell-Tale Heart," "The Black Cat"
Detective tale	Attraction bound by method	Holds by design	Curiosity, then mastery	Mast, cask, letter	"Rue Morgue," "The Purloined Letter," "The Gold-Bug"
Comic tale	Repulsion: dispersal	Inverted: bodies made of parts	Laughter	Balloon, body in pieces	"The Man That Was Used Up," "A Predicament," "Hans Pfaall"
Hoax	Repulsion projected outward	Sealed and set adrift	Credence, then exposure	Newspaper, bottle	"The Balloon-Hoax," "Valdemar," "Von Kempelen"
Colloquy of the dead	Speech from the center	Dissolved: the grave as home	Calm, residual measure	Pendulum of Time	"Monos and Una," "Eiros and Charmion," "The Power of Words"
Landscape fantasy	Attraction redeemed: a benign vortex	Holds as paradise	Bliss	Ivory canoe	"The Domain of Arnheim," "Landor's Cottage"
Cosmology	The whole pulse	Sealed in a comic frame	The sublime	Heart Divine	*Eureka*

The map reduces to two variables. The sign of the force separates horror from comedy, which share devices and differ in direction (Chapter 11). The fate of the vessel separates horror from detection, which share a direction and differ in whether the binding holds (Chapter 7). Two variables and one law make the minimal grammar of the corpus, and *Eureka*, which contains the whole pulse, stands at their intersection.

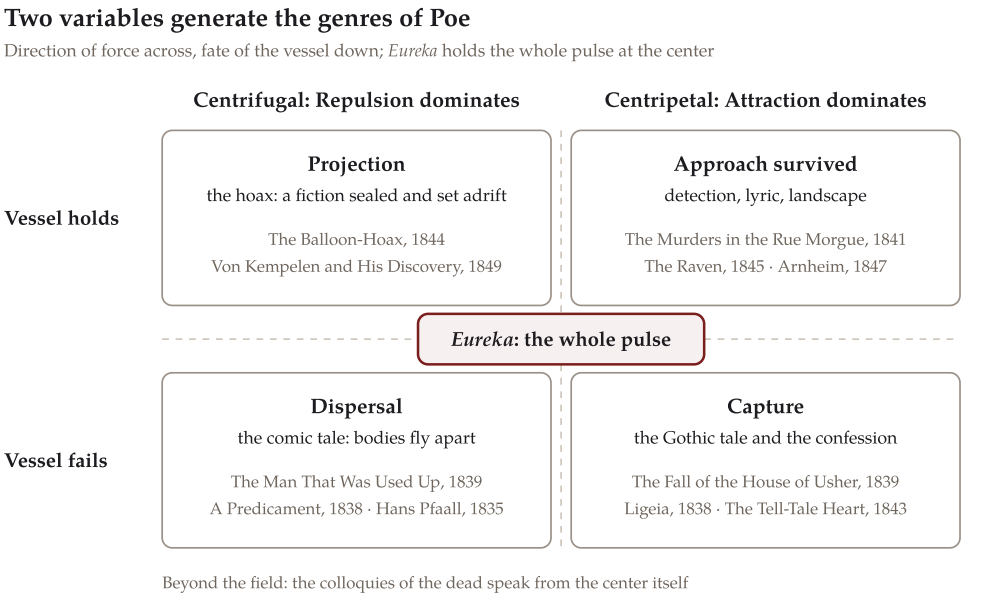


Figure 2 *The minimal grammar: direction of force × fate of the vessel*

Horror and comedy share the lower row and differ in direction; horror and detection share the right-hand column and differ in whether the vessel holds.

14.3 Objections and replies

The objection from reduction. A single law, it may be said, flattens a various corpus into monotony. The reply is that the law is generative rather than thematic. Like a grammar it produces difference, nine modes from two variables, and it explains what thematic readings leave unexplained: the comic twins, the joint birth of the detective and vortex tales in 1841, the empty centers, the law of substitution, and the fact that Poe's most solemn book arrives inside a joke.

The objection from irony. Poe was a hoaxer, and *Eureka* may itself be a hoax, as its comic frame invites one to suspect. The reply is that irony belongs to the system as Repulsion, and that the frame is the vessel of the contents, not their cancellation (Chapter 11). Poe asked in his preface that the book be judged "as a Poem only" after his death, and he wrote to George Eveleth on 29 February 1848 that what he had propounded would "(in good time) revolutionize the world of Physical & Metaphysical Science. I say this calmly—but I say it."

The objection from anachronism. The theory reads an antebellum writer through thermodynamics, Freud, Bataille, and Lacan. The reply is the method stated at the outset. Genealogy distinguishes documented sources, mediated

atmospheres, and structural homologies, and later theory enters as later positions in the field, not as keys. Any claim that a structure outlives its moment is anachronistic in this sense. The safeguard is prediction, which section 14.4 supplies.

The objection from politics. A formal and metaphysical theory, it may be said, evades history: slavery, the market, and gender. The objection is correct about the theory as stated so far. A theory of Poe that cannot account for "Hop-Frog," for the economics of the single sitting, or for the white figure at the end of *Pym* is incomplete. Chapters 15 and 16 answer it by asking what the theory's own terms, the center, the vessel, the return, and the purity of Unity, encode.

14.4 A test: "The Lighthouse"

A theory earns its keep by prediction. The dinic theory predicts that any Poe text will contain a vessel, a center, and a vector, and that the vessel's fate will determine its mode. "The Lighthouse," the unfinished manuscript generally dated to 1849, was read by none of the preceding chapters. It is a diary begun on 1 January 1796 by a man who has sought solitude as keeper of a lighthouse, alone but for his dog Neptune: the god of the sea kept as a pet inside the tower. The lighthouse is a vessel raised on the vertical axis above the abyss, and its keeper insists on its strength. Then he notes that the basis on which the structure rests seems to him to be chalk. The breach will come from within the foundation. The manuscript ends with the date of a fourth entry and nothing after it, a voice that stops, like the manuscript in the bottle, at the edge of its last impulse.

All three predicted elements are present in three pages, and the vessel's fate, left suspended, leaves the mode undecided. In 1953 Robert Bloch, the writer who turned Lovecraft's abyss inward (Chapter 13), completed the tale.

14.5 Limits

The theory claims a grammar, not an intention. It does not assert that Poe designed his corpus as a system, though *Eureka* shows that he came to see one. It does not rank the texts, which instantiate the law with very different success. And it does not reduce the work to biography, which Chapter 8 showed to be shaped by the structure rather than its source. Above all, it is not innocent. Its central terms, a pure center, a return to unity, and a beauty whose occasion is a dead woman, carry a politics. The final chapters turn the theory on itself.

CHAPTER

15

The Odyssean Binding

Form, Market, and the Political Economy of Effect

The vessel is not only a metaphysical emblem. It is the magazine page, the newspaper column, the hour of reading bought for a few cents, and the tale built to be reprinted without its author. Poe's poetics of effect took shape in the first American mass literary market, and among other things it is a theory of how to sell a controlled catastrophe. This chapter reads the dinic law as political economy. The reader bound to the mast is the consumer of a commodified sublime; capital's circuit of return is the market's vortex; and Poe's comedies are the self-critique of the industry his poetics helped to found.

15.1 The magazine prison-house

Poe was among the first American writers to try to live by writing alone, and he did so in a market that made it nearly impossible. He edited the *Southern Literary Messenger* in Richmond (1835–37), *Burton's Gentleman's Magazine* (1839–40) and *Graham's Magazine* (1841–42) in Philadelphia, and, briefly as its owner, the *Broadway Journal* in New York, which failed in January 1846. Under his editorship the circulations of the *Messenger* and of *Graham's* multiplied, as he never tired of pointing out; his salary at *Graham's* was eight hundred dollars a year. His prizes give the market value of a tale: fifty dollars for "MS. Found in a Bottle" in 1833, a hundred for "The Gold-Bug" in 1843. For *Eureka* he urged George Putnam to print fifty thousand copies; Putnam printed a few hundred.

Poe named the conditions in "Some Secrets of the Magazine Prison-House" (1845). Without an international copyright law, American publishers could reprint British books for nothing, and so had little reason to pay American authors; magazines that prospered on their contributors' work paid them late, little, or not at all. Poe met Dickens in Philadelphia in 1842, during the tour on which Dickens campaigned for international copyright; no such law came until 1891. Meredith McGill's *American Literature and the Culture of Reprinting* (2003) showed how this regime shaped authorship itself. Newspapers and magazines reprinted one another freely, texts travelled without their authors, and a tale's value lay in its portability. The manuscript in the bottle, addressed to whoever finds it, is the allegory of that market: a text sealed to survive circulation without its maker.

The single sitting is, among other things, a format. Terence Whalen's *Edgar Allan Poe and the Masses* (1999) read Poe's aesthetics as a response to a capitalized literary market, in which a writer had to produce effects legible to a mass audience divided by region and politics. The brevity Poe derived from the intensity of effect (Chapter 4) was also the length a magazine could print and a reader could buy. The vessel of the poetics and the vessel of the market coincide.

15.2 The bound listener

Horkheimer and Adorno's reading of the Sirens in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944–47) gives the political economy of the Odyssean knot (Chapter 7). Odysseus, bound to the mast, hears the song and cannot act on it; his rowers, ears stopped with wax, labor without hearing. The master enjoys beauty as a spectacle that commits him to nothing, and his men produce the motion that carries him past it. Art and labor part company, and the bound listener becomes, as they put it, a forerunner of the later concert audience: motionless, safe, entranced.

Poe's reader "at the writer's control" for an hour is this listener. The single sitting binds him to the mast of the tale, and the effect is the Sirens' song made safe by the binding. Burke had already stated the condition. Danger and pain, he wrote, are simply terrible when they press too nearly, but "at certain distances, and with certain modifications," they are delightful (*Enquiry* I.7). The vessel supplies the distance. The frame, the closed form, and the purchase together make terror consumable. This is the commodified sublime announced in the Abstract: the abyss delivered by the hour, at a safe remove, to a reader who has paid to be bound.

The rowers are present too. They are the compositors and printers of the magazines, the printer's boy of "X-ing a Paragrab" who sets *x* for the stolen *o*, and the underpaid magazinist himself. Within the tales they are the servants whose labor keeps the leisure of the bound in motion: Pompey assembling the general each morning, Jupiter climbing the tulip-tree and digging for Legrand's gold (Chapter 16).

15.3 The effect as commodity

"The Philosophy of Composition" is the first manual of an industry. Poe claims that no point in the composition of "The Raven" "is referrible either to accident or intuition," and that the work proceeded "with the precision and rigid consequence of a mathematical problem." He states his aim plainly: a poem "that should suit at once the popular and the critical taste." The effect is chosen first, the means are engineered to produce it, and the ending is known before the beginning is written.

Horkheimer and Adorno's chapter on the culture industry describes the same procedure as domination. Its products are standardized; their outcome is known from the start; calculated effect displaces the integrity of the work; and the consumer's response is anticipated and manufactured. Poe anticipates the procedure but not entirely its result. His demand that every word serve one design is a demand for totality, not for interchangeable details, and his insistence that meaning remain an undercurrent preserves a residue the formula cannot use. Poe's poetics stands at the threshold of the culture industry, sharing its method and not yet its indifference to the whole.

Walter Benjamin's "On Some Motifs in Baudelaire" (1939) located the threshold historically. Reading "The Man of the Crowd," Benjamin observed that Poe's pedestrians behave as though adapted to machines, reacting to the city's shocks with automatic gestures, and argued that the shock experience of the crowd corresponds to the worker's experience at the machine. Poe's effect is the aesthetic form of that shock: a calculated jolt delivered within a bounded time, to be absorbed and survived.

The industry formalized the method. Alfred Hitchcock, who said in 1960 that Poe's tales had shaped his films, distinguished surprise from suspense in his conversations with François Truffaut (1966). A bomb that explodes under a table without warning gives the audience fifteen seconds of surprise; a bomb the audience knows about gives it fifteen minutes of suspense. Suspense is composition from the end, the ending known to the audience before the

characters know it. Screenwriting manuals such as Syd Field's *Screenplay* (1979) made knowing one's ending before writing the first rule of the trade. The amusement park built the Maelström in steel and water. Dreamland on Coney Island, opened in 1904, offered "Hell Gate," a ride in which boats circled a whirlpool and were drawn down into darkness. The fire that destroyed Dreamland in May 1911 began in Hell Gate.

15.4 Capital's vortex

Marx's *Capital* (1867) describes the movement of capital as a circuit of return: money becomes a commodity and returns as more money, M–C–M′. Value, Marx wrote, here becomes the subject of a process, an "automatic subject" that returns to itself enlarged. In the vocabulary of this dissertation, capital is a center that grows by incorporation, the economic form of *Eureka*'s marginal note in which each intelligence absorbs every other (Chapter 5). Marx reached for Gothic images to describe it. Capital is dead labor that, vampire-like, lives only by sucking living labor. The commodity, once it enters exchange, becomes a haunted object, a table that stands on its head and evolves out of its wooden brain ideas, in the English translation "grotesque ideas," more wonderful than the table-turning of the séance rooms.

Franco Moretti's "Dialectic of Fear" (1982) showed how much such images explain, reading Dracula as monopoly capital and Frankenstein's creature as the proletariat. Poe's comedies supply the figures of an earlier capitalism. The Angel of the Odd, a god whose body is a wine-pipe, whose limbs are kegs and bottles, and who presides over accidents, is the commodity fetish incarnate: a deity made of containers of goods, ruling the market's contingency (Chapter 11). General Smith is a body assembled from branded parts, each maker named as it is fitted. Peter Proffit of "The Business Man" (1840) runs, among his enterprises, an assault-and-battery business, provoking blows in order to sue for damages, so that injury to the body becomes income. "Von Kempelen and His Discovery" (1849) answers the gold rush with a hoax of transmutation, value produced from lead by a story. In this vocabulary the law of substitution observed in Chapter 12, that whatever returns from the center requires a body given in exchange, is a law of exchange.

"The Gold-Bug" (1843), Poe's greatest popular success, is the fable of this economy. Written in the long depression that followed the Panic of 1837, it restores a ruined gentleman to fortune through buried coin and jewels, the fantasy of specie in an age of doubtful paper money. Marc Shell's *Money,*

Language, and Thought (1982) read the tale's cryptography alongside that monetary crisis: a cipher and a banknote are alike signs whose value depends on what lies behind them. Legrand's chest is the center of the tale's spiral of inference, and it is full of gold. The tale won a hundred dollars and was reprinted everywhere. Its author remained poor.

15.5 Property and the critic

Poe's criticism is the economy's counter-force. His slashing reviews at the *Messenger* made his name, and his campaign against plagiarism culminated in the so-called Little Longfellow War of 1845, in which he charged, among other things, that Longfellow's "The Beleaguered City" imitated his own "The Haunted Palace." In a culture of reprinting, where texts circulated without their authors, originality was the only property an author could claim, and plagiarism the only theft he could prosecute. Criticism, in dinic terms, is Repulsion: it separates, distinguishes, and defends the boundary of a self. The plagiarism charge is the vessel defending its contents against a market that dissolved authorship into circulation.

Poe's lifelong project of an independent magazine, *The Penn* and then *The Stylus*, was the same defense on a larger scale: a vessel under the author's control, outside the prison-house. It never appeared. The modernists revived both the project and the emblem. The little magazines of the 1910s were the independent vessels Poe could not finance, and the Vorticists' *BLAST* (1914) declared the vortex "the point of maximum energy." Ezra Pound defined the image itself as a vortex, a node from which, through which, and into which ideas are constantly rushing. Paul Valéry, who called Poe the demon of lucidity, built his own poetics on Poe's conception of the work as an engineered effect upon a reader. Modernism recovered the vortex as energy and the vessel as autonomy, and the market absorbed both. By the 1960s American International Pictures was selling Poe by the reel (Chapter 13).

15.6 Conclusion

The Odyssean binding is at once the reader's safety and the reader's servitude. Poe invented, or at least first theorized with full lucidity, the procedure by which the abyss can be sold by the hour: an effect chosen in advance, a form that binds, an ending known before the beginning, and a reader who pays to be held at a delightful distance from destruction. He also wrote the procedure's critique. Mr.

Blackwood's advice to note one's sensations while drowning, at ten guineas a sheet, is the industry's formula as farce; the hoaxes expose the credulity on which it trades; and the Angel of the Odd is its god. The vessel that carries Poe's vortex to the reader is a commodity, and Poe knew it. What escapes the market is the undercurrent, the meaning that does not surface and cannot be sold. Whether it also escapes the ideology of the center is the question of the last chapter.

CHAPTER

16

The White Center

The Ideology of Return and Its Undoing

The dinic law is not innocent. Its central terms, an originary unity, a pure and simple center, a return in which all difference is absorbed, were not neutral in a slaveholding republic whose politics turned on purity of origin and the subordination of difference. In Poe's texts the center is coded white and male. The creative center is a masculine God and author who irradiates a world from a design known in advance; the attractive center is a dead white woman; and the bodies that labor at the rim are Black. Yet the same texts evacuate the center they erect. Whiteness at the end of *Pym* is a shrouded figure and a broken-off page, the One of *Eureka* is Nothing, and the insurgencies of the dead woman from the center and of the enslaved from the rim converge against it. This chapter reads both movements, and the answers that Black writers and artists have returned to them.

16.1 The center and its politics

Poe was raised in Richmond in the household of a tobacco merchant whose trade, like the city's, rested on enslaved labor. In 1829, acting in Baltimore as agent for his aunt Maria Clemm, he executed a bill of sale for an enslaved man named Edwin. As editor of the *Southern Literary Messenger* he published, in April 1836, the so-called Paulding-Drayton review, a defense of slavery as a patriarchal bond. It was long attributed to him; most scholars now assign it to Nathaniel Beverley Tucker, but it appeared under his editorship. Terence Whalen (1999)

called Poe's public position an "average racism": a racism calibrated to a national market, never proslavery enough to lose the North nor antislavery enough to lose the South, and trading freely in the stereotypes both sections shared.

The dinic theory adds a structural claim. Every center in Poe is produced by an exclusion and sustained by labor at the rim. The bound listener enjoys the song because the rowers row (Chapter 15). Legrand's gold is dug by Jupiter, "manumitted" but still attending his "Massa Will." General Smith is assembled each morning by Pompey, and the heroine of "A Predicament" reaches the clock face of Time by standing on the shoulders of another Pompey. In antebellum America the geometry of center and rim is also a geometry of race.

It is a geometry of gender as well. The poetics places a masculine creator at the generative center, the God of *Eureka* and the author whose design is fixed before the first word, and a feminine object at the attractive center, the dead beautiful woman (Chapter 8). The man speaks, irradiates, and survives; the woman dies, attracts, and is silent. The two centers sustain each other: the author's control over the reader's soul and the death of a beautiful woman as the most poetical topic in the world belong to one ideology.

16.2 Tsalal and the white curtain

The Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym stages this geometry as a voyage. Near the pole the crew of the *Jane Guy* reaches the island of Tsalal, whose inhabitants are black down to their teeth and fear everything white; at the carcass of a white animal they cry "Tekeli-li!" Feigning friendship, they lure the crew into a ravine, bury them by bringing down the hillsides, and destroy the ship. Pym and Dirk Peters, a sailor whose mother was Upsaroka, survive among chasms whose shapes, the appended note explains, spell "to be shady" and "to be white." They escape southward with a captive islander, Nu-Nu, across a sea that grows warm and milky beneath a fall of white ash, toward a white cataract. Nu-Nu dies of terror as they approach. A chasm opens to receive the canoe, and in its path there rises "a shrouded human figure, very far larger in its proportions than any dweller among men. And the hue of the skin of the figure was of the perfect whiteness of the snow." The narrative ends there.

Criticism has read this geography for six decades. Sidney Kaplan's introduction of 1960 read the novel as a racial theology built on the curse of Ham, a proslavery allegory in which blackness is damnation and the scripture graven in the rock is God's vengeance. John Carlos Rowe (1992) argued that readings which bracket race reproduce the novel's ideology. Toni Morrison's

Playing in the Dark (1992) placed Poe at the origin of what she called "American Africanism," the use of an imagined Black presence to define a white American self, and read the impenetrable whiteness that closes narratives like Pym's as a meditation on the dark presence that shadows it. In dinic terms the novel's two poles form a racial cosmology: blackness at the rim, whiteness at the center, and a voyage from one to the other in which the Black captive dies.

16.3 The revolt of the rim

The tales return again and again to bodies at the rim seizing the center. The orangutan of "The Murders in the Rue Morgue" kills two white women in a locked room, and Elise Lemire (2001) has read the tale against the "amalgamation" panic of Poe's Philadelphia, where an anti-abolitionist mob burned Pennsylvania Hall in May 1838 after interracial meetings were held there. "The System of Doctor Tarr and Professor Fether" ends with the keepers blackened by tar and feathers and appearing to the narrator as apes. "Hop-Frog," whose crippled jester was carried off from his homeland as a present to a king, ends with the king and his ministers chained, tarred, hoisted, and burned. Joan Dayan (1994) and Lesley Ginsberg (1998) have read "The Black Cat" through slavery: a household creature named for the god of the underworld is mutilated and hanged, and its successor bears on its breast a white mark that slowly takes the shape of the gallows.

These are the Saturnalian plots of Chapter 11 in their historical meaning. The insurgency of the rim mirrors the insurgency of the dead woman at the center (Chapter 8). Both are returns of what the system excluded, and Poe's narrators experience both as horror.

16.4 The lady and the slave

Dayan's "Amorous Bondage" (1994) joined the two insurgencies. In the discourse of the slaveholding South, she argued, the idealized white lady and the enslaved Black woman were bound to each other, the purity of the one guaranteed by the degradation of the other, and Poe's possessed and possessing ladies speak this bond in the language of romance. "Ligeia" carries it in its plot. The dark-haired Ligeia, whose eyes are "far larger than the ordinary eyes of our own race" and fuller than the gazelle eyes of an oriental tribe, returns through the body of the fair-haired Saxon Rowena and consumes it (Chapter 8). In the America of 1838 a tale of a dark woman possessing a fair one could not be free

of the fears that the word "amalgamation" carried. The insurgent center is racially marked.

16.5 Whiteness as blankness

And yet the center does not keep its color. The white figure at the end of *Pym* is shrouded; its face is never seen; it speaks no word; the narrative breaks off before it, and the editorial note reports that the last chapters are lost. The center of Poe's racial cosmos is a blank. Melville gave the blank its theory in "The Whiteness of the Whale" (*Moby-Dick*, chapter 42), where whiteness is at once the visible absence of color and the concrete of all colors, "a dumb blankness, full of meaning," a "colorless, all-color of atheism" from which we shrink. Melville's "Benito Cereno" (1855) completed it. Aboard the slave ship *San Dominick*, whose captive Africans have risen and now stage their own servitude for an American captain who cannot read what he sees, the figurehead has been replaced by the skeleton of the slaveholder Aranda, with "Follow your leader" chalked beneath it. Captain Delano is Dupin's opposite, an observer whom race has made unable to read. The white center is a skeleton on a prow.

Eureka's own logic undoes the ideology its imagery supports. Its cosmos descends from a single particle and returns to a single Unity. In the decade when Samuel George Morton's *Crania Aegyptiaca* (1844) claimed the ancient Egyptians for the white race, and when George Gliddon, whom Poe set beside the mummy's case in "Some Words with a Mummy," was preparing with Josiah Nott the polygenist ethnology of *Types of Mankind* (1854), Poe's cosmology insisted on one origin and one destiny for all matter. And its Unity is Nothing. Whiteness is a difference, and in the return to the One every difference is annihilated. The purity the center seemed to promise is the purity of a blank. The law that ranks the rim beneath the center ends by abolishing both.

16.6 Answers

Black writers and artists have answered Poe from inside his field. Richard Wright's "How 'Bigger' Was Born" (1940) relocated American horror in the racial order itself: were Poe alive, Wright observed, he "would not have to invent horror; horror would invent him." *Native Son* (1940) rewrites "The Black Cat" from the other side. A young Black chauffeur who has smothered his employer's daughter in panic burns her body in the furnace of a Chicago mansion while the

family's white cat watches, and when the furnace is cleared the bones in its ashes give him away.

Toni Morrison's *Beloved* (1987) answers the insurgent center. The dead woman who returns to 124 Bluestone Road is the daughter whom a fugitive mother killed rather than see her carried back into slavery. She returns in flesh, and as she grows, her mother wastes: the law of substitution of Chapters 8 and 12, with its history restored. What Poe's dead women carry as an unnamed dread, Morrison names.

Jordan Peele's *Get Out* (2017) gives the dinic machinery its racial truth in a single image. A white hypnotist stirs a spoon in a teacup, a vortex in a vessel, and the young Black hero sinks into an endless darkness, the Sunken Place, from which he can see but cannot act: the bound listener of Chapter 15, made literal and racialized. The family's procedure transplants the minds of aging white people into Black bodies. Ligeia's possession of Rowena returns as the white center's colonization of the rim.

The xeno-theistic lineage has been answered too. Lovecraft's fear of the alien was bound up with his fear of immigrants and people of color, nowhere more openly than in "The Horror at Red Hook" (1927). Victor LaValle's *The Ballad of Black Tom* (2016) retells that story through a Black musician from Harlem, and Matt Ruff's *Lovecraft Country* (2016) sends a Black family through cosmic horror in the America of Jim Crow. The indifferent cosmos, these works suggest, was never as indifferent to color as its author claimed.

16.7 Conclusion

The center of Poe's system is coded white and male, its object of desire is a dead white woman, and its rim is Black. Poe's texts erect this geometry and, in the same gesture, evacuate it. The white figure is a shroud over nothing; the One is Nothing; the purity of the center is the purity of a blank; and the excluded return from both directions, the dead woman from the center and the enslaved from the rim. The answers of Wright, Morrison, Peele, and LaValle complete the field by naming what Poe's dread left unnamed. A theory of Poe that stops at metaphysics stops halfway. The dinic law describes not only how a cosmos returns to itself but how an order founded on exclusion is haunted by what it excludes.

CONCLUSION

Nevermore and Evermore

"The Raven" passes through three refrains. Its early stanzas close on "nothing more," the self-sufficient present of a scholar who explains each sound away. One closes on "evermore," the eternity in which the lost Lenore is "Nameless here for evermore." From the eighth stanza on, every stanza closes on "Nevermore." The last two words differ by a single letter: *nevermore* is *evermore* with a negation set before it, the eternity of the cosmos denied to the individual. That letter states the dinic law at both its scales. The universe of *Eureka* returns evermore, swelling into existence and subsiding at every throb of the Heart Divine; the self that longs for the center returns nevermore, except as the God that has absorbed it. As one letter divides *emet* from *met*, truth from death (Chapter 10), one letter divides the return of the cosmos from the return of the soul.

The argument can now be gathered. Part One followed the vortex through ancient cosmogony and modern natural philosophy and located Poe's originality in a fusion: he gave the physical whirl of the atomists the longing of the Neoplatonic soul, and gave the soul's return a gravitational mechanism. He made the vortex want something. Part Two showed that the tenets usually treated as separate are modes of one law. Form is the vessel; perversity is gravitation felt from within; ratiocination is the Odyssean knot; the dead woman is an insurgent center; words are forces; and comedy is the centrifugal phase of the pulse. Part Three showed that Poe kept the structures of myth and removed its gods, and that modern horror divides along the line his system held together. Part Four stated the theory in twelve theses, reduced it to two variables, and turned it on the market that sold it and the racial order it encoded.

Several of the results are, as far as this study can determine, new. The detective tale and the vortex tale were born together in 1841 because they divide

the twelfth book of the *Odyssey* between them. Nearly every Gothic tale has a comic twin built on the same device with the force reversed. Poe's centers are untenanted, and whatever returns from them requires a substitute. The founding controversies of Poe theory restage *Eureka*'s two forces. Modern horror descends from Poe along lineages defined by what they place at the center, and one modern work, Ito's *Uzumaki*, rejoins them. And the law's own logic, a return to a Unity that is Nothing, undoes the purity its imagery of whiteness seemed to promise.

The dinic imagination reaches well beyond the authors this study could treat. Poe's reception in Japan begins with a pen name: the detective novelist Hirai Tarō wrote as Edogawa Ranpo, a sounding of Edgar Allan Poe. In Latin America, Julio Cortázar translated the complete tales (1956), and Borges built a metaphysics of the labyrinth on Dupin's method. In Russia the Symbolists, Konstantin Balmont above all, translated and venerated him. The figure has also left literature. Meteorologists speak of the polar vortex, and oceanographers map the great subtropical gyres in which the world's discarded bottles and wrappers slowly turn and gather. Poe's private emblems, the vessel and the vortex, have become the signature of an epoch whose refuse returns to the center of its seas. A study of the dinic imagination in the Anthropocene would begin there.

On 3 October 1849 Poe was found in Baltimore, delirious and in clothes not his own, at a tavern serving as a polling place on election day. He died four days later at Washington College Hospital. The attending physician, John J. Moran, whose accounts grew more elaborate with each retelling, reported that on his last night Poe called repeatedly for "Reynolds." Some biographers have proposed Jeremiah N. Reynolds, the advocate of polar exploration whose ideas stand behind "MS. Found in a Bottle" and *Pym* (Chapter 2); others, an election judge named Henry Reynolds; others, no one. The conjecture cannot be proved. It is recorded here because it has the shape of everything this study has described: a voice at the end of its trajectory, calling toward the pole.

Dînos was a whirl and a pot. Poe's work is both: a vortex that wants its center, and a vessel that carries the wanting to whoever finds it. The vessel is sealed, the vortex turns, and the manuscript, like every manuscript Poe wrote, is addressed to a reader on the far shore.

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Keywords

Edgar Allan Poe · *Eureka* · *dînos* · dinic law · vortex · vessel · unity of effect · poetics of effect · cosmology · cosmogony · nebular hypothesis · gravitation · nostalgia · Imp of the Perverse · perversity · the double · confession · ratiocination · detective fiction · *Odyssey* · the Sirens · Charybdis · Gothic fiction · American Gothic · grotesque and arabesque · Romantic irony · hoax · the sublime · the numinous · Neoplatonism · Gnosticism · Lurianic Kabbalah · Empedocles · atomism · katabasis · comparative mythology · eternal return · the symbolism of the center · the beautiful dead · the insurgent center · psychoanalytic criticism · deconstruction · Lacan · Derrida · Bataille · Blanchot · feminist criticism · whiteness studies · American Africanism · race and slavery in American literature · political economy of literature · culture industry · print culture and reprinting · cosmic horror · psychological horror · H. P. Lovecraft · Alfred Hitchcock · Junji Ito · Toni Morrison · Charles Baudelaire · Stéphane Mallarmé · Paul Valéry



Set in TeX Gyre Pagella, with Greek in GFS Porson.